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1 Timothy

1 Timothy 1:1

Section 1:1–2: Paul greeted Timothy

In this first section of this letter, Paul introduced himself as the writer of the letter and explained to whom he was writing it. Then he wrote a short prayer for Timothy. Paul began this letter the way most people did when they wrote letters in New Testament times. That is why he put his name first and then wrote Timothy's name.

In your language, people may not start letters the same way that Paul did. To follow the Greek word order might even convey wrong information. It may, therefore, be necessary to change the order of some of the information. Perhaps your readers may not understand that this was a letter or would think that Paul was being rude or was not well-educated. So in some languages it may be necessary to place the name of the person to whom Paul was writing before Paul's own name. Then follow that with information that Paul was an apostle by the command of God.

1:1a Paul,

- ¶ I, Paul, am writing this letter.
- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul.

Paul: Paul began this letter to Timothy by stating his own name first. In some languages, it is not natural for a person to use his own name to refer to himself, as Paul did here. If that is the case in your language, you may have to say something like:

I, Paul

In addition, Paul did not use a verb here, so you may have to supply one. For example, you may have to say:

I, Paul, am sending this letter

I, Paul, am writing this letter

Other possibilities are:

I, Paul, greet you

This letter is from me, Paul

1:1b

an apostle of Christ Jesus

- I am an apostle of Christ Jesus,
- Christ Jesus sent me as his representative.

an apostle of Christ Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostle means “sent one.” Therefore an apostle is someone who has been sent to do a specific job. Christ Jesus had sent Paul to represent him and authorized Paul to teach others about him. For more information, see apostle in the Glossary.

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Some people, however, think that when Paul used the word Christ before the word Jesus, as in Christ Jesus, he was emphasizing that Jesus was the Messiah.

In most English versions “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

However, it is possible that, in some languages, people may be confused to see the names in two different orders. They may even think that Paul was referring to two different people. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ.” This is the more usual word order in the New Testament.

Christ: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

1:1c

by the command of God our Savior and of Christ Jesus our hope,

- as God our^(incl) Savior and Christ Jesus our^(incl) hope commanded me to be.
- It was God who saves us^(incl) and Christ Jesus in whom we^(incl) hope who appointed me to be an apostle.

by the command of God our Savior and of Christ Jesus our hope: Paul knew he was an apostle because God and Christ wanted him to be one. He did not choose himself to be an apostle. The other apostles did not choose him either, nor did any other human being. Rather, Paul became an apostle by

the command of God and of Christ Jesus. They had appointed him to be an apostle.

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the command with a verb. For example:

God our Savior and Christ Jesus our hope commanded/commissioned me to be an apostle of Christ Jesus.

God our Savior: When Paul mentioned God here, he was referring to God the Father. New Testament authors usually refer to Christ as Savior. However, Paul used this expression six times in 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus.

our: This refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

Savior: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Savior refers to a person who saves or rescues someone else from danger. Paul was saying that God rescues all people who trust in Christ. In other words, he saves them from their sin and its consequences.

Christ Jesus our hope: When Paul described Christ as our hope, he meant that Christ was the one who gives Christians hope.

In some languages, it may be necessary to translate hope with a verb. One way to express this would be to say:

we can hope/trust in Christ Jesus

our: Here again this refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

General Comment on 1:1c

Paul became an apostle because God and Christ had appointed him as one. This was Paul's main point in 1:1. In 1:1c, he also included the information that God is our Savior and that Christ Jesus is our hope. This is secondary information. Paul did not explain how or why God is our Savior or in what way Christ Jesus is our hope. Do not add too many details to your translation to explain what it means to say that God is our Savior and that Christ is our hope. Otherwise your readers may miss Paul's main point.

1 Timothy 1:2

Section 1:1–2: Paul greeted Timothy

In this first section of this letter, Paul introduced himself as the writer of the letter and explained to whom he was writing it. Then he wrote a short prayer for

Timothy. Paul began this letter the way most people did when they wrote letters in New Testament times. That is why he put his name first and then wrote Timothy's name.

In your language, people may not start letters the same way that Paul did. To follow the Greek word order might even convey wrong information. It may, therefore, be necessary to change the order of some of the information. Perhaps your readers may not understand that this was a letter or would think that Paul was being rude or was not well-educated. So in some languages it may be necessary to place the name of the person to whom Paul was writing before Paul's own name. Then follow that with information that Paul was an apostle by the command of God.

1:2a

To Timothy,

- I am writing this letter to you, Timothy.

To Timothy: You may need to use a verb and the second person pronoun "you" to translate the words To Timothy. For example:

I am writing this letter to you, Timothy.

I greet you, Timothy.

1:2b

my true child in the faith:

- You are my very own son because you also trust in Christ.
- You are just like a son to me because you believe in Christ as I do.

If you have already translated Titus, compare 1 Timothy 1:2 to Titus 1:4. The Titus passage has a similar meaning. It differs in that it has "in our common faith" instead of "in the faith."

my true child: This is a metaphor. Paul meant that Timothy was like a son to him; that is, he loved him like a father loves his son.

In some languages it is not possible to call someone "my son" if he is not a biological son. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use a simile rather than a metaphor. For example:

You are like a real son to me.

Or you may prefer to use a more natural expression, such as "my dear [Timothy]" or "my beloved [Timothy]."

true: The Greek word that the BSB translates as true can also be translated “genuine” or “real.” When Paul described Timothy as his true son, he probably meant that he loved Timothy as much as he would love his biological son.

in the faith: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the faith is literally “in faith.” Here it probably refers to Timothy’s own faith. For example, the NCV has:

because you believe, [you are like a son to me]

Timothy was like a son to Paul because Timothy believed in Christ (as Paul himself did). See also Titus 1:4a.

See faith, meaning 1 in the Glossary.

1:2c

Grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

- May God the Father and Christ Jesus our^(incl) Lord show you his favor and mercy and give you peace.
- I pray that God, who is our^(incl) Father, and Christ Jesus, who is our^(incl) master, would be kind to you, treat you mercifully, and grant you well-being.

Grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord: When people wrote letters in Greek they often began them with a short prayer like this. Compare this to the similar greeting-prayers in Titus 1:4; Romans 1:7; and Philippians 1:2. This kind of prayer is called a “blessing.” Paul was asking God to bless Timothy.

I pray that...

I ask God and Christ Jesus our Lord to...

Compare this to the similar greeting-prayers in Titus 1:4; Romans 1:7; and Philippians 1:2.

Grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Grace means “favor, good will, kindness.” Paul wanted God to show kindness and favor to Timothy.

In some languages, it may be necessary to use an expression to translate the word Grace. One way to do this would be:

May [God the Father and Christ Jesus our^(incl) Lord]
be kind to you^(sing).

See Grace, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

mercy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mercy also refers to God’s kindness and compassion toward people. But mercy emphasizes that God is kind and does not punish someone who deserves it.

peace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as peace applies to three aspects:

1. the absence of conflict within oneself
2. the absence of conflict between oneself and another person
3. the absence of conflict between oneself and God

However, Paul was probably using the word peace here as people who spoke Hebrew used the word shalom. This Hebrew word refers to wholeness or well-being. It was used to talk about people who live in peace with God and with other people. If your language has a word that combines the ideas of inner peace and inner well-being, use it here. Otherwise, use a word that refers to an absence of conflict.

God the Father: You may need to translate this phrase as “God our^(incl) Father” if that is the natural way to say this phrase in your language.

our: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord is a general word that means “master.” It was used to address any respected person. Here it refers to Christ. You could translate it as “owner” or “chief.”

1 Timothy 1:3

Section 1:3–11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

Paul reminded Timothy about things that he had told him to do the last time he was with him. That is, he told him to command certain people to stop teaching the Old Testament Scriptures incorrectly. Paul told Timothy that when people listened to the false teachers, they started arguing about things that were unimportant. Paul said that when Timothy taught the Scriptures, the result should be that people love one another, not that they argue with one another.

After talking about the incorrect use of Scripture in 1:3–7, Paul talked about the correct use of Scripture in 1:8–11. Paul did not want people to use Scripture to speculate about unimportant things. Instead he wanted them to stop sinning and behave how God wanted them to behave.

Paragraph 1:3–4

Some time before Paul wrote this letter, he had been with Timothy in the city of Ephesus. As he was prepar-

ing to leave Ephesus for Macedonia, he told Timothy to remain in Ephesus.

One of the reasons that Paul wanted Timothy to remain in Ephesus was to command certain people not to teach false doctrines any longer. In 1:3–4, Paul was reminding Timothy about this.

Specifically, Paul told Timothy to command people to stop using the lists of ancestors in the Scriptures to teach things that were untrue. When they taught like that, they caused people to argue about unimportant topics.

1:3a

As I urged you on my departure to Macedonia,

- ¶ I repeat what I urged you^(sing) to do before I left Ephesus to go to the region of Macedonia:
- ¶ As I was about to go to Macedonia, I strongly encouraged you to

As I urged you: Paul was referring to instructions that he had given Timothy on an earlier occasion. Here he repeated those instructions. You may need to translate this as:

Now I am telling you again the things that I urged you to do before

Or you may need to say something like:

Continue to command them in the way I told you earlier

on my departure to Macedonia: The clause that the BSB translates as on my departure to Macedonia means:

as I was leaving for Macedonia

before I left Ephesus to go into Macedonia

Macedonia: Macedonia was a region in the northern part of the modern country of Greece. In New Testament times, it was a province in the Roman Empire. Paul may have been writing this letter from one of the cities there, perhaps Philippi. You may need to supply the information that Macedonia was a region or province.

1:3b

you should stay on at Ephesus

- remain in the city of Ephesus

you should stay on: In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a direct quote. One possibility might be:

Before I left for Macedonia, I told you: “Stay here in Ephesus...”

Ephesus: Ephesus was a large city in the Roman province of Asia. Paul first visited Ephesus on his second missionary journey (Acts 18:19–21). On his third missionary journey, he stayed and taught there for about two years (Acts 19:1–41).

1:3c

to instruct certain men

- so that you may command those false teachers
- and give this command to the false teachers there:

to instruct: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to instruct here indicates purpose. The purpose for Timothy remaining in Ephesus is explained in the rest of this verse.

certain men: When Paul used the Greek word that the BSB translates as certain men, he implied that both he and Timothy knew people who were teaching these wrong doctrines.

1:3d

not to teach false doctrines

- to stop teaching people things about the gospel which are wrong.
- “Stop teaching false things.

not to teach false doctrines: This means “to stop teaching false doctrines.”

to teach false doctrines: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to teach false doctrines literally means “to teach what is different.” The false teachers were teaching something different from the things that Paul taught. More importantly, what these people were teaching was different from what Jesus and the apostles taught, and from what God wanted them to teach. Paul used the same term again in 6:3a.

1 Timothy 1:4

Section 1:3–11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

Paul reminded Timothy about things that he had told him to do the last time he was with him. That is, he told him to command certain people to stop teaching the Old Testament Scriptures incorrectly. Paul told Timothy that when people listened to the false teachers, they started arguing about things that were

unimportant. Paul said that when Timothy taught the Scriptures, the result should be that people love one another, not that they argue with one another.

After talking about the incorrect use of Scripture in 1:3–7, Paul talked about the correct use of Scripture in 1:8–11. Paul did not want people to use Scripture to speculate about unimportant things. Instead he wanted them to stop sinning and behave how God wanted them to behave.

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Some time before Paul wrote this letter, he had been with Timothy in the city of Ephesus. As he was preparing to leave Ephesus for Macedonia, he told Timothy to remain in Ephesus.

One of the reasons that Paul wanted Timothy to remain in Ephesus was to command certain people not to teach false doctrines any longer. In 1:3–4, Paul was reminding Timothy about this.

Specifically, Paul told Timothy to command people to stop using the lists of ancestors in the Scriptures to teach things that were untrue. When they taught like that, they caused people to argue about unimportant topics.

1:4a

or devote themselves to myths and endless genealogies,

- Command them to stop paying so much attention to legends and numerous lists of ancestors.
- Do not spend your^(plur) time on untrue stories and never-ending family histories.”

In 1:4a, Paul was explaining the specific false doctrines that he had referred to in 1:3d.

devote themselves to myths and endless genealogies: The Greek word that the BSB translates as “devote to” means “pay close attention to.” The false teachers were paying close attention to myths and endless genealogies. They were continually thinking about them and teaching people about them. Some commentators understand myths and endless genealogies as a hendiadys; that is, the two nouns compose one unit of meaning. The phrase would then mean that false teachers were teaching myths that they based on endless genealogies. For example, Lock, page 8, says that the two words should “be taken closely together, muthoi being defined by genealogiai, legendary stories about genealogies.” Stott, page 44, agrees.

myths: A myth is a story that has been made up and passed down from one generation to another. It may be based on something that happened in the past. Or

it might be something made up to teach people why they should follow certain customs. But it is not true like history. See also 2 Timothy 4:4 and Titus 1:14.

endless genealogies: A “genealogy” is a list of the names of ancestors in a family history. It shows how people are related to each other. Paul did not explain what genealogies he meant here. Some commentators think that the false teachers in Crete studied the Jewish genealogies in the OT and tried to find secret meaning in them. Other commentators think that the false teachers studied long lists of names of angels and other supernatural beings that they thought could help them reach God, but it was probably something connected to religion, and something that people studied and argued about. Some people do not think that Paul was referring to lists of ancestors when he said genealogies. They say that he was talking about different spirits, or angels, that stood between men and God. The idea that there were different levels of spirits, or angels, between men and God is a part of Gnosticism. But Paul was probably not talking about this here. Stott, page 45, comments: “There are two main problems with this reconstruction [that Paul was talking about Gnosticism]. The first is that Paul was not predicting the future phenomenon of developed second-century Gnosticism, but was describing a reality with which Timothy had to deal in his own day, in which Gnosticism had only begun to develop. Secondly, there is no evidence that the Gnostics ever referred to the aeons as ‘genealogies’.... All we can say in conclusion is that Paul’s references suggest a false teaching which combined Jewish and Gnostic elements, either ‘a Gnosticizing Judaism’ or ‘Judaizing forms of Gnosticism.’” Knight, pages 73–74, drawing on Spicq, mentions that this kind of teaching is found in rabbinic Haggadah, Philo’s writings, the pseudo-Philonian The Biblical Antiquities of Philo (shortly after AD 70), in The Book of Jubilees (135–195 BC), and in the Qumran writings (cf. 1QS 3:13–15). Stott, page 44, says, “The author of The Biblical Antiquities supplements the biblical narrative ‘by means of his fabulous genealogies’, which occupy chapters 1, 2, 4 and 8. Similarly The Book of Jubilees supplies us with the names of all the children of Adam and Eve, of Enoch’s family, of Noah’s predecessors and descendants, and of the seventy people who went down into Egypt. It may be, then, that it is to this kind of fanciful literature that Paul is referring when he writes of law, myths and genealogies.” See also Titus 3:9.

endless: The genealogies that the false teachers taught were very long and complicated. That is the reason that Paul called the genealogies endless. This is an example of hyperbole or exaggeration.

1:4b which promote speculation

- The teaching of these stories and ancestral lists only encourages people to argue
- When they teach people such things, everyone begins to argue about them

which: The relative pronoun which refers grammatically to the “endless genealogies” (1:4a). However Paul probably intended to refer both to the myths and to the genealogies. Try to make this clear in your translation.

promote: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as promote means “cause” or “bring about.” You could also say “lead to,” “produce,” or “result in.”

speculation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as speculation is only found in Christian writings. A similar word occurs in 6:4b; 2 Timothy 2:23; and Titus 3:9. Scholars understand the word here in two ways:

1. It means “controversies” or “arguments.” These teachers spent a lot of time talking about “myths and endless genealogies.” This caused other people to discuss them and argue about them. For example, the CEV says:

Such things only cause arguments. (CEV, NIV, GNT, NCV)

1. It means “speculations” or “questions.” People were listening to what the false teachers were teaching. When they heard these things, they began to wonder about things that were unimportant. For example, GW says:

These myths and genealogies raise a lot of questions (BSB, GW, RSV, NJB, NASB, REB, NET, NLT, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was telling Timothy that false teaching caused arguments.

1:4c rather than the stewardship of God’s work,

- instead of encouraging them to do God’s work,
- instead of doing the work that God wants them to do,

rather than: In 1:4b Paul said what the myths and genealogies did promote (that is, speculation and controversies; see 1:4b). Here, in 1:4c, he told Timothy

what they did not promote. They did not promote God’s work.

the stewardship of God’s work: Scholars interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as God’s work in three ways:

1. It refers to the work that God had given believers to do. By teaching wrongly, the false teachers were not working for God in the way that he wanted them to work for him. For example, the CEV says:

They don’t help anyone to do God’s work (BSB, CEV, NIV, NCV)

1. It refers to God’s plan to save people and change them so that they will behave as God wants them to behave. For example, the REB says:

and do not further God’s plan for us (REB, GNT, NJB, NET, GW)

1. It refers to training or instruction. For example, the RSV says:

rather than the divine training

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). God’s work refers to work that is done for God or work that God has given people to do.

1:4d which is by faith.

- for this work can only be done by those who believe in him.
- which they can only do by believing in him.

by faith: There are two different ways to interpret the Greek words that the BSB translates as by faith:

1. A person can only do God’s work when he himself has faith in God. The NCV probably follows this interpretation when it says:

God’s work...is done in faith. (NCV, CEV)

1. A person can only do God’s work when he helps other people have faith in God. For example, the NLT translates this verse part as:

They [myths and genealogies]... don’t help people live a life of faith in God.

Most translations do not say who was to have faith, and it is recommended that you do not either. But if you must be specific, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). God's work can only be done by people who have faith. That is, only those who trust in him can do his work. See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 1:3–4

In some languages it may be more natural to combine these verses and change the order of some of the information. In 1:3b Paul told Timothy to stay in Ephesus. In 1:3c–d Paul told Timothy the purpose for that command. He wanted Timothy to tell certain men to stop teaching wrong things. In 1:4 he gave more details about this.

In some languages it may be necessary to mention some of the information about the false teachers before you translate Paul's command. This will help people understand the reason that Paul wanted Timothy to tell them not to teach wrong doctrines. Here is one way to combine these verses and reorder the parts:

^{4a} As you know, Timothy, there are some people in Ephesus who teach what is wrong. They continually teach untrue stories which they base on long lists of ancestors. ^{3a}Remember when I was ready to go to Macedonia? ^{3b}At that time I asked you to remain in Ephesus ^{3c}and to tell those people ^{3d}not to teach like that. ^{4b}When they teach such things, people argue about them. ^{4c}The result is that those teachers are not doing the work God gave them, ^{4d}which they can only do by trusting God.

1 Timothy 1:5

Section 1:3–11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

Paul reminded Timothy about things that he had told him to do the last time he was with him. That is, he told him to command certain people to stop teaching the Old Testament Scriptures incorrectly. Paul told Timothy that when people listened to the false teachers, they started arguing about things that were unimportant. Paul said that when Timothy taught the Scriptures, the result should be that people love one another, not that they argue with one another.

After talking about the incorrect use of Scripture in 1:3–7, Paul talked about the correct use of Scripture in 1:8–11. Paul did not want people to use Scripture to speculate about unimportant things. Instead he

wanted them to stop sinning and behave how God wanted them to behave.

Paragraph 1:5–7

Paul said that when people taught about God, the result should be that people begin to love each other. The false teachers did not love other believers. They wanted people to think that they were important teachers but they did not teach the Scriptures correctly.

1:5

In Greek this verse connects with the previous verse with the Greek word *de*. BAGD says that the word *de* is “one of the most commonly used Gk. particles, used to connect one clause w. another when it is felt that there is some contrast betw. them, though the contrast is oft. scarcely discernible. Most common translations: but, when a contrast is clearly implied; and, when a simple connective is desired, without contrast; freq. it cannot be translated at all.” However, Levinsohn (1992) refers to it simply as a “developmental marker, in the sense that the information it introduces builds on what has gone before and makes a distinct contribution to the argument” (page 64). He further adds, “...the sense in which material introduced with *de* builds on and develops from the context is not always readily apparent. However, we do well to take the presence of *de* seriously” (pages 65–66). In this context, *de* shows that Paul was contrasting two ways of behaving: “arguing” (1:4b) and “loving each other” (1:5a). One way to translate this word in English is “instead.” People should not argue, but love one another.

1:5a

The goal of our instruction is the love

- ¶ Your aim in giving this command is that people will show love to one another,
- ¶ You should give this command in order that people will start to love each other.

The goal of our instruction: The Greek word that the BSB translates as goal refers to the purpose/aim for which something is done. Timothy should give these instructions with a certain purpose in mind. In some languages it may be necessary to say “your” goal/purpose/aim instead of the goal/purpose/aim.

our instruction: There are at least three ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to the instruction that Timothy was to give to the false teachers. In 1:3c–d Paul urged Timothy to instruct the false teachers to stop teaching incorrect doctrines. Here Paul told Timothy to instruct people to love each other instead of arguing about

what the false teachers had said. For example, the NRSV says:

the aim of such instruction (NRSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, CEV, REB, perhaps the BSB)

1. It refers to Paul's instruction to Timothy. For example, the NLT says:

The purpose of my instruction... (NLT, GW)

1. It refers to God's instruction to people to obey him and to teach others about him. It is another way of speaking of "God's work," which Paul mentioned in 1:4c. The RSV possibly follows this interpretation when it uses the expression "our charge." Knight, page 76, says, "Some would relate *παραγγελία* [=command] to the specific charge of 1:3.... This is correct, but is also a too restricted view (so likewise in 1:18). The other occurrence of the word in Paul, in 1 Thes. 4:2 (plural), speaks of commands handed on from Christ as requirements for the Christian's life. Since the context here speaks of Paul as an apostle according to commandment (1:1) and of Timothy being commanded by him in that capacity, *παραγγελία* [=command] is used here in the broader sense of the command of the Christian life seen in its entirety as God's charge to us (cf. Mt. 22:37-40; Mk. 12:31; 1 Jn. 4:21; 3:23). Not only does this understanding of the word fit with usage elsewhere in the NT, but more particularly it continues the emphasis on God's *οικονομία* [=work] (v. 4), which led to this statement in v. 5."

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) which is supported by the majority of English versions.

1:5b

that comes from a pure heart,

- and this love is only produced from a heart that is without deceit,
- In order to really love each other, we^(incl) must be sincere in what we^(incl) do,

that comes from: Paul said that love comes from three sources: a pure heart (1:5b), a clear conscience and a sincere faith (1:5c). This means that if a person has these things, he will be able to love other people. One way to express this would be:

If a man has a pure heart, a clear conscience, and a sincere faith, he will [be able to] love others.

a pure heart: The phrase "to do something from a pure heart" means "to do something sincerely or without deceit." In many languages there is an idiom to express this aspect of a person's character. If your language has such an idiom, use it if it is appropriate.

1:5c

a clear conscience, and a sincere faith.

- from a clean conscience and genuine trust.
- we^(incl) must do what we^(incl) know is right, and we^(incl) must truly trust in Christ.

a clear conscience: A person who has a clear conscience knows that he has done the right thing. Therefore he does not feel guilty. In English this is could also be expressed as "a good conscience."

conscience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conscience refers to the part of a person that helps him know what is right and what is wrong to think or do. A person's conscience causes him to feel ashamed or guilty when he does something wrong. It also makes him feel good when he does what is right.

However, in many languages, there is not a word that means conscience. In some languages, there may be an idiom that can be used. In other languages, it may be necessary to translate the expression clear conscience by an expression like:

doing what he knows is right

a sincere faith: When a person has a sincere faith, it means that he truly trusts in God. In some languages it may be possible to say:

he truly/completely believes

See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

1 Timothy 1:6

Section 1:3-11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

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Paragraph 1:5–7

Paul said that when people taught about God, the result should be that people begin to love each other. The false teachers did not love other believers. They wanted people to think that they were important teachers but they did not teach the Scriptures correctly.

1:6

This verse contrasts the way that the false teachers were behaving with the way that Paul wanted the believers in Ephesus to behave (1:5).

1:6a

Some have strayed from these ways

- The false teachers have abandoned all these
- But these false teachers have stopped doing these things.

Some: The word Some refers to the false teachers whom Paul had referred to in 1:3c.

have strayed from these ways: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as strayed from originally meant “to miss the mark.” Later it came to mean “to miss, fail, deviate, and depart.” Here it has a figurative meaning, that is, that the false teachers no longer had these characteristics that Paul had just been describing. See the note on 6:10b and 6:21b. This verb also occurs in 2 Timothy 2:18.

these ways: This phrase refers to the characteristics that Paul had mentioned in 1:5, that is, “a pure heart,” “a good conscience,” and “a sincere faith.”

1:6b

and turned aside to empty talk.

- and now merely talk about useless topics.
- Instead, they have begun talking about things that have no real meaning.

turned aside to empty talk: Paul here continued his figure of speech. If you cannot say turned aside to empty talk, you may want to say:

and have started talking about meaningless things

empty talk: The Greek word that the BSB translates as empty talk only occurs here in the New Testament. It indicates that what the false teachers taught had no

real meaning. It might have sounded good but it had no value. See Titus 1:10 where Paul used a similar word.

1 Timothy 1:7

Section 1:3–11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

Paul reminded Timothy about things that he had told him to do the last time he was with him. That is, he told him to command certain people to stop teaching the Old Testament Scriptures incorrectly. Paul told Timothy that when people listened to the false teachers, they started arguing about things that were unimportant. Paul said that when Timothy taught the Scriptures, the result should be that people love one another, not that they argue with one another.

After talking about the incorrect use of Scripture in 1:3–7, Paul talked about the correct use of Scripture in 1:8–11. Paul did not want people to use Scripture to speculate about unimportant things. Instead he wanted them to stop sinning and behave how God wanted them to behave.

Paragraph 1:5–7

Paul said that when people taught about God, the result should be that people begin to love each other. The false teachers did not love other believers. They wanted people to think that they were important teachers but they did not teach the Scriptures correctly.

1:7a

They want to be teachers of the law,

- They want to be recognized as teachers of the law,
- They want people to believe that they can teach the law/laws which God told to Moses,

They want to be teachers of the law: People respected the teachers of Moses’ law and recognized that they were experts. The false teachers about whom Paul was writing here also wanted people to respect them and to consider them experts.

teachers of the law: The Greek word that the BSB translates as teachers of the law refers to men who were experts in the laws which are recorded in the Old Testament.

the law: Here Paul was referring to the laws that God gave to Moses and that are recorded in the first five books of the Old Testament.

Some ways to translate the law in the sense of “the law of Moses” are:

God’s laws that Moses taught

the law that God gave to Moses

Since this phrase is singular in English (and Greek), some readers may think that Paul was talking about only one law. If this causes a problem for your readers you may need to use a plural term.

1:7b

but they do not understand what they are saying

- but they do not really understand what they are trying to teach others about,

they do not understand what they are saying: Paul said that these false teachers did not understand what they were saying. They did not understand the meaning of God's laws, even though they thought they knew them well enough to teach others. This is similar to what Paul said about the false teachers in 6:4a. See the note there.

1:7c

or that which they so confidently assert.

- and what they confidently insist is true.

or that which they so confidently assert: This phrase is similar to what Paul said in 1:7b. However, he now added the idea that the false teachers taught confidently. That meant that they spoke boldly as if they understood what they were teaching.

so confidently assert: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so confidently assert could also be translated as "insist [on]." This word also occurs in Titus 3:8, where the BSB translates it as "emphasize."

General Comment on 1:7b–c

In some languages, it may be best to translate 1:7b and 1:7c as two separate clauses, as the BSB does. But in other languages, it may be better to combine both clauses and translate them as only one emphatic clause. For example:

...but they really know absolutely nothing about what they are trying to teach.

1 Timothy 1:8

Section 1:3–11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

Paul reminded Timothy about things that he had told him to do the last time he was with him. That is, he told him to command certain people to stop teaching the Old Testament Scriptures incorrectly. Paul told Timothy that when people listened to the false teachers, they started arguing about things that were unimportant. Paul said that when Timothy taught the

Scriptures, the result should be that people love one another, not that they argue with one another.

After talking about the incorrect use of Scripture in 1:3–7, Paul talked about the correct use of Scripture in 1:8–11. Paul did not want people to use Scripture to speculate about unimportant things. Instead he wanted them to stop sinning and behave how God wanted them to behave.

Paragraph 1:8–11

Paul said that when people teach the Scriptures, they should teach them correctly.

1:8a

Now we know that the law is good,

- ¶ We^(incl) know that God's law is just,

Now: This translates a Greek word, *de*, that is often translated as "but." It connects 1:8 to 1:7. In this context it contrasts two facts. First, the false teachers do not understand the things they teach (1:7). Second, Paul, Timothy, and other believers do understand the law (1:8) which they teach.

we know: Paul did not mean that he and Timothy were the only people who knew that God's laws are good. He included all believers.

the law is good: Paul was saying that God's law is morally or ethically right. The things that the law says that people should do are just. When people obey the law, they please God. If you have translated Romans, compare Romans 7:12 and 7:16, where Paul also says that "the law is good".

the law: Paul was still referring to the laws that God gave to Moses. See the note on 1:7a.

Since this phrase is singular in English (and Greek), some readers may think that Paul was talking about only one law. If this causes a problem for your readers you may need to use a plural term.

1:8b

if one uses it legitimately.

- but people must teach it correctly.

if one uses: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as uses is a general word that means "teaches," "studies," and "obeys." Here Paul was primarily thinking about teaching the law.

legitimately: It is good to teach the law only if people teach it legitimately or "correctly." The Greek word that the BSB translates as legitimately literally means "lawfully." If a person teaches the law "lawfully," it means that the way he teaches it agrees with the

purpose for which God gave it. In 1:9–10 Paul explained the true purpose of God’s law.

1 Timothy 1:9

Section 1:3–11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

Paul reminded Timothy about things that he had told him to do the last time he was with him. That is, he told him to command certain people to stop teaching the Old Testament Scriptures incorrectly. Paul told Timothy that when people listened to the false teachers, they started arguing about things that were unimportant. Paul said that when Timothy taught the Scriptures, the result should be that people love one another, not that they argue with one another.

After talking about the incorrect use of Scripture in 1:3–7, Paul talked about the correct use of Scripture in 1:8–11. Paul did not want people to use Scripture to speculate about unimportant things. Instead he wanted them to stop sinning and behave how God wanted them to behave.

Paragraph 1:8–11

Paul said that when people teach the Scriptures, they should teach them correctly.

1:9a

We realize that

- We^(incl) also know that

We realize: The Greek words that the BSB translates as We realize literally mean “understanding this.” Paul was saying that people needed to understand the reasons that God gave them his law. The false teachers did not understand this, and so they were not teaching the law properly. People have interpreted the phrase “We also know that law is made not for the righteous” (1:9a) in several different ways. The interpretation which the Notes and the Display explain is probably the best interpretation. Other interpretations include the following:(1) Paul was not referring to the Mosaic law when he mentioned the word “law,” but to laws made by governments. When he said that “law is not for the righteous,” he meant that people would not need to make laws if everybody always did what was right. This fits the popular Greek thinking about the purpose of laws in general. This is a possible interpretation. It is true that people do not make laws for those who do what is right. The purpose of law is to change people’s behavior by warning them to avoid doing what is wrong or harmful. Paul referred to this to imply that the primary purpose of God’s laws in the Scriptures is similar to the purpose of other laws. This interpretation is very similar to what is detailed in the

Notes. However, the immediate context in 1 Timothy talks about God’s laws in the Scriptures. It is unnecessary to think that Paul changed to talk about laws in general.(2) Paul did not mean that the righteous should not teach, study, and obey the law. Instead, he meant that they should not use it for teaching myths and speculation. Knight seems to follow this view when he says, “Paul is saying that the law is not given to apply in some mystical way to people who are already ‘righteous,’ i.e, those already seeking to conform to the law.” But the trouble with this interpretation is that it seems to mean the opposite of what the text actually says: that “the law is intended for the righteous,” while the text says “the law is not for the righteous.”(3) God’s commandments which are in the Old Testament are “not for the righteous” in the sense that Christians do not need to obey all the commandments and rules which are in the Old Testament in order to please God (as Galatians 5:18 says). Before Jesus came and fulfilled the law, God wanted people to obey him by carefully observing all the commandments in the Old Testament. But now, Christians serve God in a new way by obeying his Spirit (as Romans 7:6 says). However, this interpretation is not best because Paul did not talk about Christians no longer having to obey the Old Testament laws anywhere else in 1 Timothy. It would be surprising if he mentioned such a weighty topic in such a passing way in 1:9a.

1:9b

law is not enacted for the righteous,

- God did not give his laws to correct righteous people.
- God’s laws are not intended for people who do what is right.

law: Scholars interpret the word law here in two different ways:

1. It refers to the law that God gave to Moses, that is, the same law that Paul mentioned in 1:7a and 1:8a. English versions that say “the law” or “these laws” probably follow this interpretation. (RSV, KJV, CEV, NCV, NLT)
2. It refers to all laws. This includes all human laws, as well as the law of Moses. English versions that say “law” or “laws” instead of “the law” probably follow this interpretation. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NET, GW)

Paul had been talking about God’s law immediately before this verse, in 1:8. So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul’s point was that God gave people his law to stop them from doing wrong.

is not enacted: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as is not enacted literally means “does not exist,” “does not exist for a purpose,” or “is not set.” Louw and Nida (13.73) say, “to exist, with the implication of having been established and thus having continuity and purpose - ‘to exist, to exist for, to be set.’” In this context, you could also translate this word as “is not given.”

for the righteous: Paul used this phrase to mean that God gave his law because people were sinful (1:9b–1:10d) and needed to know the right way to behave.

When Paul said “not enacted for the righteous”, he did not mean that righteous people should not learn about God’s law. But he meant that the law was not primarily intended to correct their behavior. It was intended to show other people that they were sinning.

the righteous: A righteous person in this context refers to someone who is just and upright, who wants to do what pleases God.

1:9c–f

In the rest of this verse, as well as in 1:10, Paul listed different kinds of people who needed to understand God’s law in order to stop sinning. The sins that Paul mentioned here are similar to the sins mentioned in the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:2–17). Since the Ten Commandments refer to the most important of God’s laws, Paul possibly made his list of sins similar to the list in the Ten Commandments so that it would refer to those who break the most important of God’s laws. It is not always clear to which of the Ten Commandments each item on Paul’s list refers. Probably the first pair of words are general descriptions that introduce the whole list. After that, each element of the list is similar to one of the Ten Commandments.

The list is long, so in some languages it may be helpful to split the list into several shorter lists. If you do so, you may want to begin each list with something like:

God gave his law to teach people who...

1:9c

but for the lawless and rebellious,

- Instead, God made his law to correct people who deliberately disobey him and are rebellious,

but: The Greek particle *de* that the BSB translates as but introduces a contrast between “the righteous” (1:9b) and “the lawless and rebellious” (1:9c).

the lawless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the lawless here refers to people who ignore God’s law and disobey it.

and rebellious: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rebellious refers to people who are disobedient to those in authority. They defy their authorities. Here Paul specifically refers to people who refuse to accept God’s authority. This word is also used in Titus 1:10.

These two words translated lawless and rebellious mean almost the same thing. In some languages it may be necessary to combine these two terms into one expression. For example:

those who disobey God

1:9d

for the ungodly and sinful,

- for people who behave as if God did not exist and for people who continually sin,
- God gave his law for the sake of people who continually ignore God and people who continually sin,

for the ungodly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ungodly refers to those who behave without respect for God. This word is also used in Romans 5:6 and Jude 4 and 15. This may refer to the first of the Ten Commandments. Knight, page 84, points out, “*ἄσεβής* means ‘godless’ or ‘impious.’ Since the first commandment of the Decalogue (Ex. 20:3) prohibits having other gods and abandoning God as the one and only true God, and since the NT uses *σεβόμενοι* (*τὸν θεὸν*) of those who accepted the ethical monotheism of the OT (and of this commandment; cf. Acts 13:43, 50; 16:14; 17:4, 17; 18:7), then it is understandable how violators of this command could be designated by the *ἀ-*privative negative cognate of that concept, namely *ἄσεβής*.” See godless, Word 1, in the Glossary.

and sinful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sinful refers to a person who continues to sin without repenting. Sometimes this word was used in a special way to refer to people who did not obey the Law of Moses, especially Gentiles (see for example Matthew 9:10–11, 11:19; Mark 2:15–16; Luke 5:30, 7:34, 15:1; Galatians 2:15). People called Gentiles “sinners” because they did not worship the Lord as the one true God. If that is what Paul meant, then the word sinful here refers especially to those who break the Second Commandment against worshiping idols (Exodus 20:4–6).

1:9e

for the unholy and profane,

- people who do wicked things and people who do not treat God with respect,
- for people who are corrupt, people who do not honor God,

for the unholy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unholy refers to people who behave in ways that do not please God. They behave wickedly and as if God were not important. Some English synonyms for this term are “irreverent,” “profane,” or “wicked.” This sin could be related to the Third Commandment, which says, “You shall not take the name of the LORD your God in vain...” (Exodus 20:7). Those who are unholy may either speak as if God were unimportant or behave as if he were unimportant.. The Greek word that the BSB translates as unholy occurs only here and in 2 Timothy 3:2.

and profane: The Greek word that the BSB translates as profane refers to people who do not respect God. They are only concerned about things in this world. See godless, Word 2, in the Glossary. This word is also used in Hebrews 12:16. This word could be connected to the Fourth Commandment, which prohibits people from profaning the Sabbath by treating it as if it were like any other day (Exodus 20:8–11).

1:9f

for killers of father or mother, for murderers,

- for people who kill their fathers or mothers, for people who kill other people deliberately,

for killers of father or mother: The phrase those who kill their fathers or mothers refers to those who radically disobey the Fifth Commandment, which says that a person must honor his or her father and mother (Exodus 20:12). At the time when Paul wrote, the words in Greek generally referred to those who actually killed their mother or father. Even so, it is worthwhile to note that in Exodus 21:15, which is found in a chapter which serves as a commentary on the Ten Commandments, God forbids even the striking of a person’s father or mother. The phrase killers of father or mother is literally “father-killers and mother-killers.” It refers to people who murder their fathers and to people who murder their mothers.

for murderers: The term murderers refers to people who deliberately kill someone. The Sixth Commandment, in Exodus 20:13, prohibits murder.

1 Timothy 1:10

Section 1:3–11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

Paul reminded Timothy about things that he had told him to do the last time he was with him. That is, he told him to command certain people to stop teaching the Old Testament Scriptures incorrectly. Paul told Timothy that when people listened to the false teachers, they started arguing about things that were

unimportant. Paul said that when Timothy taught the Scriptures, the result should be that people love one another, not that they argue with one another.

After talking about the incorrect use of Scripture in 1:3–7, Paul talked about the correct use of Scripture in 1:8–11. Paul did not want people to use Scripture to speculate about unimportant things. Instead he wanted them to stop sinning and behave how God wanted them to behave.

Paragraph 1:8–11

Paul said that when people teach the Scriptures, they should teach them correctly.

1:10a

for the sexually immoral, for homosexuals,

- for people who sin sexually, for people who are homosexuals,

the sexually immoral: Paul possibly used this Greek word here to include those who disobey the Seventh Commandment against adultery (Exodus 20:14). The Greek word that the BSB translates as sexually immoral is a general word that refers to people who sin sexually in any way. Try to use a general term in your translation.

homosexuals: The Greek word that the BSB translated as homosexuals refers to people who have sexual relations with people of their own sex.

1:10b

for slave traders

- for people who kidnap people in order to sell them as slaves,

slave traders: The Greek word that the BSB translates as slave traders refers to those who capture people and then sell them as slaves. Paul may have used slave traders as an extreme example of people who break the Eighth Commandment against stealing (Exodus 20:15).

1:10c

and liars and perjurers,

- people who do not tell the truth, and people who lie even when they have promised to tell the truth,

liars: This word refers to people who say things that they know are not true. These people break the Ninth Commandment, which prohibits testifying falsely against anyone (Exodus 20:16).

perjurers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perjurers is found only here in the New Testament, though a similar verb occurs in Matthew 5:33. It refers

to people who swear to tell the truth, usually before a judge, and then lie.

1:10d

and for anyone else who is averse to sound teaching

- and for anything else that is opposed to accurate teaching about God.
- and people who do anything else that the correct teaching about God forbids them to do.

anyone else: Paul finished his list by a general statement so that the list included everything a person might do or say that did not please God. You could translate this as:

all other things that a person might do...

averse to: The Greek word that the BSB translates as averse to refers to being against or opposed to something. In this verse, Paul was referring to any action, statement, or thought that is against sound doctrine.

sound teaching: The Greek words that the BSB translates as sound teaching here literally mean “healthy teaching.” This refers to correct teaching about the way in which God wants people to behave. This Greek phrase is also used in 2 Timothy 4:3 and Titus 1:9, 2:1.

sound: The word that the BSB translates as sound literally means “healthy.” In this context, it means free from error, correct.

teaching: The word that the BSB translates as teaching refers to the facts that Christians should believe about God and Christ. These were the facts that Paul and other apostles accepted as true.

The things that the false teachers were teaching contradicted these facts and rejected the true message about Christ.

General Comment on 1:10d

In many languages, only people can “be contrary to” or oppose something. Actions, statements, or thoughts cannot be “against something.” If that is true in your language, one way you could translate this is:

and people who do anything else that the correct teaching forbids us to do

1 Timothy 1:11

Section 1:3–11: Paul told Timothy to oppose false teaching

Paul reminded Timothy about things that he had told him to do the last time he was with him. That is, he told him to command certain people to stop teaching the Old Testament Scriptures incorrectly. Paul told Timothy that when people listened to the false teachers, they started arguing about things that were unimportant. Paul said that when Timothy taught the Scriptures, the result should be that people love one another, not that they argue with one another.

After talking about the incorrect use of Scripture in 1:3–7, Paul talked about the correct use of Scripture in 1:8–11. Paul did not want people to use Scripture to speculate about unimportant things. Instead he wanted them to stop sinning and behave how God wanted them to behave.

Paragraph 1:8–11

Paul said that when people teach the Scriptures, they should teach them correctly.

1:11a

that agrees with the glorious gospel of the blessed God,

- This correct teaching agrees with the good news about the glory of our^(incl) wonderful God,

agrees with the glorious gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as agrees with literally means “according to.” In this verse, Paul was saying that healthy instruction is instruction that agrees with the gospel. It is implied that, when people tell others about the gospel, they also teach about the way that God wants people to behave. Stott, page 50, makes an important point: “It is particularly noteworthy that sins which contravene the law (such as breaches of the Ten Commandments) are also contrary to the sound doctrine of the gospel. So the moral standards of the gospel do not differ from the moral standards of the law. We must not therefore imagine that, because we have embraced the gospel, we may now repudiate the law!...There is no antithesis between law and gospel in the moral standards which they teach; the antithesis is in the way of salvation, since the law condemns, while the gospel justifies.”

the glorious gospel of the blessed God: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as the glorious gospel of the blessed God is literally “the gospel of the glory of the blessed God....” Scholars do not agree about the way in which the Greek word for “glory” connects with the rest of the expression:

1. It refers to God's glory. For example, the REB says:

the gospel which tells of the glory of the ever-blessed God (REB, NJB, GW) Most commentators also follow this interpretation.

1. It refers to how glorious God is. For example, the GNT says:

the [gospel]...from the glorious and blessed God (GNT, CEV)

1. It refers to the glory of the gospel itself. For example, the NIV says:

the glorious gospel of the blessed God (BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, NET, NLT, KJV)

Interpretation (1) has the strongest commentary support. It is recommended that you follow it. Paul was talking about the glory of God. See Zerwick, §47, "where, as often happens in Paul, several genitives follow one another, each commonly depends upon the preceding one, e.g. 2 Cor 4:4..." See also BDF §168. Arichea and Hatton say that the reason is "because of the presence of the definite article before 'glory' in the Greek." In 2 Corinthians 4:4, the construction is almost identical, mentioning "the gospel of the glory of Christ." In 2 Corinthians 4:4 and 6 it is clear that the construction refers to the gospel which tells of the glory of Christ. The verses say, "The god of this age has blinded the minds of unbelievers, so that they cannot see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.... For God, who said, 'Let light shine out of darkness,' made his light shine in our hearts to give us the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ." There is a similar phrase, "the gospel of the glory of Christ," in 2 Corinthians 4:4.

glorious: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as glorious literally means "glory" (see the REB). This refers to God's greatness or majesty. See glory, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel literally means "good news." In the New Testament it specifically refers to the good news about Christ.

the blessed God: In the New Testament, the Greek word *makarios* that the BSB translates as blessed is only used to describe God here and in 6:15. It means that God has all blessings in himself. He is not dependent on anyone else for joy or for anything. Hanson,

page 60, says, "It came originally from pagan Greek literature (Homer calls the gods 'blessed'), and was adopted by Hellenistic Judaism, which is no doubt how it entered the vocabulary of the author of the Pastorals. D-C [Dibelius and Conzelmann], rightly no doubt, see here traces of a liturgical style."

In your translation, use an expression that would be appropriate for referring to God. Some possibilities are:

the God who lives in perfect joy

the God who has all blessings

the perfect God

In some languages, it is not possible to use the definite article (the) in a phrase like the blessed God. To do so might cause the readers to think that there is another god who is not blessed. If this is true in your language, you may need to say something like:

our^(incl) blessed God

1:11b

with which I have been entrusted.

- the good news that God has given me the responsibility to proclaim.

with which I have been entrusted: Paul was saying that God had trusted him to teach the gospel message accurately.

1 Timothy 1:12

Section 1:12–17: Paul thanked Christ Jesus for his mercy

Paul began this section by thanking Christ Jesus for forgiving him. He described himself as the worst sinner. He said that Christ would forgive everyone who believed in him, no matter how sinful they were, just as Christ had forgiven him.

1:12a

I thank Christ Jesus our Lord,

- ¶ I am grateful to Christ Jesus our^(incl) Lord,

thank: That is, Paul was grateful to Christ Jesus for all that he had done for him. Some languages may not have a word that means thank. If your language is like that, you may have to say something like:

I tell Christ Jesus our Lord that he has done good to me.

Christ Jesus our Lord: This is the same expression that was used in 1:2c.

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Some people, however, think that when Paul used the word Christ before the word Jesus, as in Christ Jesus, he was emphasizing that Jesus was the Messiah.

In most English versions “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

However, it is possible that, in some languages, people may be confused to see the names in two different orders. They may even think that Paul was referring to two different people. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ.” This is the more usual word order in the New Testament.

Christ: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

our: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord is a general word that means “master.” It was used to address any respected person. It is a title used frequently in the New Testament to refer to either Christ or God. When it refers to them, you could translate it as “owner” or “chief.”

1:12b

who has strengthened me,

- who has always made me strong enough to serve him.

strengthened me: In 1:12c, Paul thanked Christ for giving him the responsibility to preach the gospel. But first he acknowledged that Christ had strengthened him to preach the gospel. That means that Christ enabled him to do it.

1:12c

that He considered me faithful

- I thank him because he treated me as someone whom he could trust

that He considered me faithful: When Paul said that Christ had considered him faithful, he meant that Christ considered him to be trustworthy, dependable, and reliable.

Before Paul became a believer he had not been faithful. See 1:13. He had even persecuted those who believed in Christ, and he had blasphemed God. But, here in 1:12c, he said that, despite his past, Christ treated him as if he were faithful.

1:12d

and appointed me to service.

- and chose me to serve [him].

and appointed me to service: The words appointed me to service explain the way in which Christ showed Paul that he considered him faithful. Paul used the word service here to refer to the task that Christ assigned to him. Paul’s task was to preach the gospel as an apostle. Christ appointed Paul to be his representative at the time when Paul first came to believe in him (see Acts 22:14–15).

service: You may need to translate service with a verb like “serve.” In some languages it may also be necessary to supply an object that specifies whom Paul was to serve. If so, you should follow the model of the NIV, RSV, and GNT, and indicate that Christ had chosen Paul to serve him.

The word “serve” here refers to serving or working for God, doing what God asks a Christian to do. In some languages it might be better to use a word that means “worship.”

General Comment on 1:12a

If you need to translate “thank” with direct speech, you may say something like this:

I say to Christ Jesus our Lord, he who has given me strength, “Thank you for considering me trustworthy and appointing me to serve you.”

General Comment on 1:12a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder this verse. For example, first mention that Christ gave Paul the responsibility to preach the gospel (1:12c–d). Then say that Christ had given him the strength to do it. One way to do this would be:

^{12a}I thank Christ Jesus our Lord ^{12c}because he has counted me as faithful ^{12d}and called me to serve him by preaching the gospel. ^{12b}And he has made me strong enough to do what he called me to do.

1 Timothy 1:13

Section 1:12–17: Paul thanked Christ Jesus for his mercy

Paul began this section by thanking Christ Jesus for forgiving him. He described himself as the worst sinner. He said that Christ would forgive everyone who believed in him, no matter how sinful they were, just as Christ had forgiven him.

1:13a

I was formerly a blasphemer,

- At one time I used to say evil things about Christ
- In the past I used to deny that Jesus was sent by God

I was formerly: Paul was referring to the time before he committed his life to Christ. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

before I believed in Christ, I was...

formerly: This means that the following things were things that Paul used to do in the past, before he became a Christian.

a blasphemer: Paul was not saying here that he cursed God. Instead, he was saying that he spoke evil about Jesus and said that Jesus was not the Messiah sent by God. You may need to make this clear in your translation.

1:13b

a persecutor,

- and treat believers badly
- and used to search for his disciples to cause trouble for them

a persecutor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as persecutor in this situation refers to a person who uses physical abuse. See Acts 8:3 for details of how Paul (then called Saul) persecuted Christians.

In your language it may be necessary to say whom Paul persecuted. There are two possible objects for this verb:

1. Paul persecuted believers. Paul said in Acts 22:4 that he persecuted believers by searching for them and arresting them. Then, he took them to the people in authority who put them in prison or punished them in other ways. For example, the NLT says:

I hunted down his people.

1. Paul persecuted Christ. For example, the NCV says:

I spoke against Christ and persecuted him. (NCV, GNT, RSV, REB, CEV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and say that Paul persecuted believers.

1:13c

and a violent man;

- and harm them
- and act cruelly toward them

a violent man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as violent man describes a person who behaves violently and speaks insolently and without respect. This word is also found in Romans 1:30 (third word in the list). Here in 1:13b, it implies that Paul acted cruelly and violently against the Christians whom he was persecuting.

1:13d

yet because I had acted in ignorance

- In spite of that, because I did not understand that I was doing evil

yet: This phrase shows the contrast between the sort of person Paul was and the way that God treated him. You should express this contrast in the way that is most natural in your language.

because: Paul was not implying that, because he had “acted in ignorance and unbelief,” his actions were not sinful. Instead, Paul was explaining the reason that Christ had shown him mercy, that is, because he “acted in ignorance and unbelief.”

I had acted in ignorance: Paul had not been sinning against God deliberately. In some languages it may be necessary to specify what Paul was ignorant of. If this is true in your language, choose something very general. For example, the GNT says:

I...did not know what I was doing

1:13e

and unbelief,

- and I did not yet believe in Christ

unbelief: When Paul said that he had acted in unbelief, he did not mean that before he became a Christian he did not believe in God. Rather, he was saying that he did not yet believe that Christ was the Savior

whom God had sent. When he persecuted Christians, Paul actually believed that he was pleasing God.

1:13f

I was shown mercy.

- I received mercy.
- Christ showed me mercy.

I was shown mercy: When Paul said that he was shown mercy, he meant that he was not judged or punished as he deserved.

Paul did not say who showed him mercy. However in some languages, it will be necessary to specify this. Scholars do not agree about whom Paul meant:

1. He meant Christ. For example, the CEV says:

But he [Christ Jesus] had mercy on me...

1. He meant God. For example, the GNT says:

But God was merciful to me (GNT, NCV, NLT)

Christ is called “our Lord” in 1:12a. Also the phrase I was shown mercy seems to mean almost the same thing as “the grace of our Lord was poured out on me” in 1:14a. For these reasons, if it is necessary for you to specify who had shown mercy to Paul, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and say that it was Jesus who showed him mercy.

mercy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mercy also refers to God’s kindness and compassion toward people. But mercy emphasizes that God is kind and does not punish someone who deserves it.

General Comment on 1:13d–f

In the Greek text, the order is: (1:13f) Christ was merciful because (1:13d) Paul acted in ignorance and (1:13e) unbelief. In some languages it may be better to reorder these parts of the verse. Another way to do this would be:

^{13e}I did not yet believe in Christ ^{13d}and so I did not understand that what I was doing was wrong.

^{13c}Because of this Christ was merciful to me.

1 Timothy 1:14

Section 1:12–17: Paul thanked Christ Jesus for his mercy

Paul began this section by thanking Christ Jesus for forgiving him. He described himself as the worst sinner. He said that Christ would forgive everyone who

believed in him, no matter how sinful they were, just as Christ had forgiven him.

1:14a

And the grace of our Lord overflowed to me,

- Our^(incl) Lord showed me great favor.
- Our^(incl) Lord was extremely kind to me.

And the grace of our Lord: This means that the grace came from the Lord. The Lord acted graciously or showed his grace.

grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grace refers to kindness or generosity shown to someone who does not deserve it. See grace, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

our: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

Lord: Scholars have interpreted this in two ways:

1. It refers to the Lord Jesus (CEV)
2. It refers to God the Father (probably the NLT)

In 1:12a Paul referred to Christ as “our Lord.” So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) that Lord here refers to Christ.

overflowed to me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as overflowed literally means “was more abundant.” Here the verb is used figuratively. The sense is that the Lord was extremely kind. Other possible ways to say this are:

The Lord generously poured out his grace upon me.

The Lord was wonderfully kind to me.

1:14b

along with the faith and love

- I could also believe in him and love others
- He also made me able to believe in him and love others

along with: Along with grace, Christ gave Paul “faith” and “love.”

faith: This refers to Paul’s faith in Christ. See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

love: In this context Paul probably meant that he was able both to love God and other people. To love God primarily means to obey him (1 John 5:3). To love other people primarily means to serve and help them (1 Corinthians 13:4–7; 1 John 3:16–18).

1:14c**that are in Christ Jesus.**

- because I was united with Christ Jesus.
- as I was made one with him.

that are in Christ Jesus: Scholars disagree about what the Greek word that the BSB translates as that are refers to. There are two ways to interpret this:

1. Paul meant that both faith and love are in Christ Jesus. For example, the GNT says:

the faith and love which are ours in union with Christ Jesus (BSB, GNT, RSV, NIV, NASB, REB, CEV, NCV)

1. Paul meant that love is in Christ Jesus For example, the NJB says:

with faith and with the love that is in Christ Jesus (NJB, KJV, GW, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

in Christ Jesus: Paul said here that the faith and love that he received were in Christ Jesus. By this, he meant that he was able to trust and to love because he was now united with Christ Jesus.

1 Timothy 1:15**Section 1:12–17: Paul thanked Christ Jesus for his mercy**

Paul began this section by thanking Christ Jesus for forgiving him. He described himself as the worst sinner. He said that Christ would forgive everyone who believed in him, no matter how sinful they were, just as Christ had forgiven him.

Paragraph 1:15–17

In the same way that Christ saved Paul, he will also save everyone else who believes in him, no matter how sinful they are.

1:15a**This is a trustworthy saying,**

- ¶ This saying is reliable,
- ¶ This saying is something that you can be sure is true,
- ¶ Believers know the following words, which can be trusted,

This is a trustworthy saying: This is an expression that Paul used often in his letters to Timothy and Titus. See 1 Timothy 3:1, 4:9; 2 Timothy 2:11; Titus 1:9, 3:8. You should try to use the same expression of introduction

in all these places. Paul used this expression to introduce a saying that was well-known among believers at that time. This saying is found in 1:15c.

trustworthy: Paul said that this saying (1:15c) about Christ was trustworthy. That means that it was true and reliable. Other ways to say this could be: “This saying really is true,” or “people should believe this.”

saying: A saying is an expression that is well known to people. In some languages it may be possible to use a word like “proverb.”

1:15b**worthy of full acceptance:**

- and it deserves to be accepted without doubt:
- and they are worthy to be believed completely:

worthy of full acceptance: Because the saying in 1:15c is “trustworthy”, everyone should believe it and should not doubt it in any way. They can be sure that it is true.

1:15c**Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners,**

- “Christ Jesus came to this world to save those who had sinned,”
- Christ Jesus was born into our^(incl) world to rescue us^(incl) sinners.

Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners:

This is the saying that Paul introduced in 1:15a–b.

Christ Jesus came into the world: This refers to when Christ Jesus came to earth the first time and died on the cross.

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Some people, however, think that when Paul used the word Christ before the word Jesus, as in Christ Jesus, he was emphasizing that Jesus was the Messiah.

In most English versions “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

However, it is possible that, in some languages, people may be confused to see the names in two different orders. They may even think that Paul was referring to two different people. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ.” This is the more usual word order in the New Testament.

Christ: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

to save sinners: This is the purpose for which Jesus came into the world. The Greek word that the BSB translates as save means “to rescue from danger.” In this context, the danger is that if a person does not repent and stop sinning, he will not receive eternal life.

sinners: A sinner is a person who has disobeyed God.

General Comment on 1:15c

Sayings are normally short because people want to remember them. Therefore translate this saying with as few words as possible. It would also be helpful to keep the saying in one sentence. One way to do this is:

Christ Jesus came to earth to rescue people who have sinned.

In some languages it may be helpful to indicate the beginning and end of the saying in some way. For example, you may want to use quotation marks or a different printing style, such as italics. The JBP uses both.

1:15d

of whom I am the worst.

- and I am the greatest sinner of all.
- Of all the people who have sinned, I am the one who has sinned the most.

of whom I am the worst: Notice that this part of the verse is not part of the saying in 1:15c. One way to make this clear would be to use special punctuation. For example, the NIV uses a dash, that is, —. If you place the saying in quotation marks, make sure you close the quotation marks at the end of 1:15c. Paul added these words to make it personal in this context.

I am the worst: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worst literally means “first.” Paul meant that he considered himself to be the greatest sinner. This did not mean that Paul had committed more or greater sins than anyone else in the world. It meant that Paul felt as if he were the worst sinner. Stott, page 53, says, “...when we are convicted of sin by the Holy Spirit, an immediate result is that we give up all such comparisons. Paul was so vividly aware of his own sins that

he could not conceive that anybody could be worse. It is the language of every sinner whose conscience has been awakened and disturbed by the Holy Spirit. We may begin like the Pharisee in Jesus’ parable, ‘God, I thank you that I am not like other men’, but we end like the tax collector who beat his breast and said (literally), ‘God have mercy on me, the sinner [Luke 18:9ff.]’ The Pharisee indulged in odious comparisons; as far as the tax collector was concerned, however, there were no other sinners with whom to compare himself; he was the one and only.” Paul was so aware of his own sins that he could not imagine that anybody could be worse than he was.

General Comment on 1:15a–d

In some languages it may be best to reorder this verse. For example, it may be better to translate the saying before stating that it is trustworthy. One way to do this is:

We believers often say: ^{15c}“Christ Jesus came to the world to save sinners.” ^{15a}These words are true ^{15b}and everyone can believe them without doubting them in any way. ^{15d}And I have sinned more than anyone...

1 Timothy 1:16

Section 1:12–17: Paul thanked Christ Jesus for his mercy

Paul began this section by thanking Christ Jesus for forgiving him. He described himself as the worst sinner. He said that Christ would forgive everyone who believed in him, no matter how sinful they were, just as Christ had forgiven him.

Paragraph 1:15–17

In the same way that Christ saved Paul, he will also save everyone else who believes in him, no matter how sinful they are.

1:16a

But for this very reason I was shown mercy,

- But here is the reason that I was treated with such compassion:
- But Christ Jesus acted mercifully toward me

But: This Greek word that the BSB translates as But shows contrast. Paul was contrasting what he had done with the merciful way that Christ had treated him. He was the worst sinner, but Christ had mercy on him.

for this very reason: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for this very reason literally means “be-

cause of this.” Scholars understand the word “this” in two ways:

1. The word “this” refers to God’s purpose, as stated in 1:16b–d. For example,

I was mercifully dealt with for this very purpose, that Jesus Christ... (REB)

but God was merciful to me in order that Christ Jesus... (GNT) (BSB, REB, GNT, NJB, NET, NLT, NCV, GW)

1. The word “this” refers back to the fact that Paul was the worst of sinners, as stated in 1:15c–d. For example, the CEV says:

since I was worse than anyone else, God had mercy on me... (CEV, NIV, NRSV, JBP)

Several English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

In some languages it may be difficult to use a phrase like “because of this” to refer to God’s purpose, which has not yet been stated. Consider how to introduce the purpose in a natural way in your language. It is also possible to leave the phrase “because of this” implicit, as the GNT, NCV, and GW have done.

I was shown mercy: The Greek text does not state who was merciful to Paul. There are two possibilities:

1. Christ
2. God the Father (GNT, CEV, NLT)

Most translations do not say who showed mercy to Paul. If possible you also should leave this ambiguous and say something like “I received mercy.” But in some languages it may be necessary to state who showed Paul mercy. In 1:16b, Paul said that it was Christ who showed patience toward him. Therefore, he was probably also referring to Christ here.

mercy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mercy also refers to God’s kindness and compassion toward people. But mercy emphasizes that God is kind and does not punish someone who deserves it.

1:16b

so that in me, the worst of sinners, Christ Jesus might display His perfect patience

- Christ Jesus wanted to demonstrate how wonderfully patient he is by forgiving me, who had sinned more than anyone else.

- because I was the worst of sinners and he used me to show people that he had complete patience to wait until I was ready to repent.

so that: This is the Greek word *hina*. These words introduce a purpose clause. Paul had been shown mercy in order that he could be an example of the way that Christ forgives people. As stated above, the words “for that very reason” in 1:16a emphasize that purpose.

in me, the worst of sinners, Christ Jesus might display His perfect patience: Paul expressed this as a purpose for which Christ Jesus had shown him mercy. That is, Christ wanted Paul to be an example to other people and show them that Christ forgives even the greatest sinner if he repents. For that reason Christ showed Paul mercy.

in me: When Paul said that Christ was going to display his patience in me, he meant “in my case,” or “in the way that he treated me.”

the worst of sinners: See the note on “I am the worst” in 1:15d. Use the same expression here.

display: That is, “show” or “demonstrate.”

His perfect patience: When Paul said that Christ showed perfect patience toward him, he probably meant that he had not punished Paul as soon as he sinned. Instead, he waited for him to repent (see 2 Peter 3:9).

perfect: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perfect literally means “all.” In this context it can mean “perfect,” “utmost,” “full,” and “endless.” Paul used this word to show that he was amazed at how patient Christ was with him.

patience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as patience describes a person who is able to endure something unpleasant without complaining. Here Paul was referring to Christ’s patience with him even though he was “the worst of sinners.”

1:16c

as an example to those who would believe in Him

- This was in order to provide an example for people who would one day believe in him.
- Then people who would later trust in him could realize that he would be patient with them in the same way.

as an example: Christ wanted people to understand that he would be patient with them in the same way. The Greek word that the BSB translates as example also occurs in 2 Timothy 1:13, where the BSB translates it as “pattern.” For that reason Christ was patient with Paul.

to those who would believe in Him: Paul was referring to those people who would believe in Christ in the future.

believe in: The Greek word that the BSB translates as believe literally means “to have faith in.” It implies that the believer does not just know some facts about Christ. A person who believes in Christ believes that Christ is able and willing to do the things that he has promised to do.

1:16d for eternal life.

- And so these people will be able to receive eternal life.
- Because they will trust in Christ, God will give these people life which continues forever.

for eternal life: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as for eternal life has no verb. If you need a verb in your language, you could say, “to receive eternal life.” The meaning is that 1:16d is the result of 1:16c. People receive eternal life because they have believed in Christ.

In some languages, it is not possible to use a verb like “receive” with an object that cannot be touched, like “hope,” “joy,” “love,” or “eternal life.” In languages like that, it may be possible to say:

God will give them eternal life.

God will cause them to live forever.

In other languages it may be enough to say:

they will live forever

eternal life: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as eternal life means life that never ends. However, it does not refer to physical life. Rather, it refers to a quality of life that believers experience now, before they die. For example, in John 3:36, Jesus says, “Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life....” He uses the present tense “has,” not the future “will have.” and that they will experience more fully after they die.

1 Timothy 1:17

Section 1:12–17: Paul thanked Christ Jesus for his mercy

Paul began this section by thanking Christ Jesus for forgiving him. He described himself as the worst sinner. He said that Christ would forgive everyone who

believed in him, no matter how sinful they were, just as Christ had forgiven him.

Paragraph 1:15–17

In the same way that Christ saved Paul, he will also save everyone else who believes in him, no matter how sinful they are.

1:17

Here Paul stopped what he had been talking about and began to praise God. He also invited Timothy and everyone else to praise God with him.

In 1:17a–c, Paul listed some characteristics of God for which we should praise him (God). Then, in 1:17d, Paul said the way in which God should be praised.

It might be helpful in some languages to format this verse as poetry.

1:17a

Now to the King eternal,

- May the King who rules forever,

Now: The Greek word *de* that the BSB translates as Now is used here to start a new thought. It does not express any idea of time, as the English word Now often does. In some languages it is best not to translate this word in this context.

the King eternal: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as the King eternal is literally “the king of the ages.” It means that God is the one who always has had and always will have authority to rule. He was King before the world was created and he will always be King.

1:17b

immortal, and invisible,

- who lives forever, and who cannot be seen,
- who will never die, and whom no one can see,

immortal: The Greek word that the BSB translates as immortal means “incorruptible” or “unchangeable.” In this context it means that God will never die. The only other place in the New Testament where God is described as immortal is Romans 1:23. There the word is used to contrast God with humans, who are mortal and can die.

and invisible: No one alive on earth can see God because he is spirit and so invisible to human eyes. Later, in 6:16c, Paul mentioned again that no one has seen God or ever can see him. God is also described as invisible in Colossians 1:15.

1:17c

the only God,

- who is the only God,

the only God: There is a textual problem with this part of 1:17. English versions and scholars do not agree about what the original text was here. There are two main possibilities:

1. Follow the Greek manuscripts that the BSB has used and translate the only God. (BSB, NIV, NJB, RSV, GNT, NASB, NLT, NET, NCV, REB, GW, CEV)
2. Follow other Greek manuscripts that include the Greek word that can be translated as “wise.” For example, the KJV has “the only wise God.”

Most scholars agree that this word was not present in the original Greek text and so you should omit it. The Editorial Committee of the UBS New Testament (4th edition) gives the reading without “wise” an {A} rating, indicating that the text is almost certain. However if many people in your area use the KJV, it might be helpful to mention the alternative in a footnote.

Other ways to translate the expression “the only God” are:

he alone is God (NLT)

there is no other God

1:17d

be honor and glory forever and ever. Amen.

- receive honor and glory forever. Amen.
- be honored and praised for eternity. Amen.

honor: In some languages it may be necessary to use a verb rather than a noun like honor. To honor someone means to respect him and to treat him as an important person.

glory: To give glory to someone means to worship him, to praise him, or to tell other people how wonderful he is. See glory, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

In some languages it may be necessary to use direct speech in order to translate this. Here is one way to do that:

Let us honor him, saying, “You are wonderful!”

forever and ever: In Greek the expression that the BSB translates as forever and ever means that God deserves praise that will never end.

Amen: When people in the Bible prayed to God, they often ended by saying Amen. This means not only that they had finished, but that they fully agreed with what they had said. Because this word is well known even today, many translations just transliterate it. Another

possibility is to translate it with an expression like “so let it be.”

General Comment on 1:17a–d

You may need to reorder this verse so that the description of God’s greatness comes after the call to praise. One way to do this is:

^{17d} Let everybody honor God and give him glory forever. ^{17a}He is the King who rules forever. ^{17b}He lives forever, no one can see him, ^{17c}and he is the only God. Amen.

1 Timothy 1:18

Section 1:18–20: Paul encouraged Timothy to persevere

In this section, Paul tried to encourage Timothy. He did not want Timothy to become discouraged because of the false teachers in Ephesus. So he reminded Timothy about the prophecies that people had spoken about him when the believers dedicated him as a pastor.

1:18a

Timothy, my child, I entrust you with this command

- ¶ Timothy, my son, I am giving you this command
- ¶ Timothy, my son, what I am telling you to do

my child: This is a metaphor. When Paul called Timothy my child, he meant that Timothy was like a son to him and that he loved him like a father loves his son. See the comments on “my true son” in 1:2b.

In some languages it is not possible to call someone “my child” if he is not a biological child. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use a simile rather than a metaphor. For example:

You are like my real son.

Or you may prefer to use a more natural expression, such as “my dear [Timothy]” or “my beloved [Timothy].”

I entrust you with this command: Paul was commanding Timothy to correct those who were teaching wrongly. The same Greek word which means “entrust” or “commit” is also used in 1 Timothy 6:20 and 2 Timothy 2:2.

this command: Scholars interpret the phrase this command in several different ways. Two of the ways are:

1. Paul was referring to his command to Timothy in 1:3a-4a to correct the false teachers. For example, the NCV says:

Timothy, my child, I am giving you a command that agrees with the prophecies that were given about you in the past. (BSB, NCV, RSV, NIV, NJB, KJV, NET)

1. Paul was referring to his command in 1:18d to “fight the good fight.” For example, the NASB says:

This command I entrust to you, Timothy, my son, in accordance with the prophecies previously made concerning you, that by them you fight the good fight (NASB, GNT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the same word is used here as in 1:3 and 1:5.

1:18b

in keeping with the previous prophecies about you,

- in accordance with what some prophets said to you when the Holy Spirit revealed to them what you would do.
- agrees with what some elders have already told you about your ministry.

in keeping with the previous prophecies about you:

If we consider what Jesus told Paul when Paul first started his ministry, it helps us to understand the kinds of things which Timothy may also have been told by prophets when he began his ministry. You can read what Jesus told Paul in Acts 9:15-16, 22:14-15, 22:21 and 26:16-18. Jesus told Paul the following (see Hendriksen p. 85): (a) Paul would have a special job of announcing God’s message, (b) some of the details of his job, (c) Paul would suffer, and (d) Jesus would always help him when he suffered. It could be that the prophetic messages which Timothy received were similar to these messages which Paul received, although the details were probably different. If these messages were similar, then Timothy needed to remember things like the following: (a) It was God himself who had called him to the job of proclaiming the gospel. Timothy did not get this job merely from some person’s idea or from his own imagination. (b) God himself promised to help him do that job. Consequently, as Timothy remembered the prophecies which people had spoken about him, he would want to continue to do his job in spite of difficulties. Paul was saying that what he was telling Timothy to do in this letter agreed with some prophecies that had been made about Timothy earlier. If Timothy did what Paul told him to, he would

be doing what God, by means of the prophecies, had told him to do.

the previous prophecies about you: Paul was probably referring to the time (see 4:14b) when church leaders placed their hands on Timothy, prayed for him, and dedicated him as a pastor and special helper for Paul.

the previous prophecies: The word prophecies refers to special messages that the Holy Spirit gives to people.

1:18c

so that by them

- I am telling you this so that what those prophets told you will encourage you

so that: Paul here told Timothy his purpose in reminding him about the prophecies.

by them: The pronoun them refers to the prophecies made about Timothy. Scholars interpret this in several ways:

1. Timothy was to remember the things that the prophets said in their message from God to him and be encouraged by it. For example, the NET says:

that with such encouragement... (NET, RSV, REB, NLT)

1. Timothy was to use what the prophets said (as a weapon against evil). For example, the GNT says:

Use those words as weapons... (BSB, GNT, GW)

1. Timothy was to obey what the prophets said. For example, the CEV says:

If you follow these instructions... (CEV, NIV, NRSV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was probably telling Timothy to remember certain things. As Timothy remembered these things, he would be more likely to be faithful and “fight the good fight.”

1:18d

you may fight the good fight,

- to fight the good fight for the gospel.
- to fight well in the same way that a good soldier fights hard in a battle.

fight the good fight: Timothy's task was to proclaim the gospel and to correct false teaching. Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do this no matter how difficult it might become. He compared this to fighting. There are two ways to make this clearer. For example:

to fight well in the Lord's battles (NLT)

you will fight like a good soldier (CEV)

In some languages, the phrase fight the good fight can only refer to physical fighting. If your language is like that, you may need to make it clear in your translation the way Timothy's job was like fighting in a physical battle. For example, you could say:

contend for the truth of the gospel as a good soldier fights to win a war

Or you may have to translate without a comparison here, in order for Paul's main point to be clear enough that people can understand it. For example:

continue to proclaim the gospel despite opposition

good fight: This has been interpreted in two ways:

1. It means to fight well; that is, bravely or expertly. For example, the GNT says "fight well." (GNT, NJB, NLT, CEV)
2. It means that the fight was itself good; that is, just and right. When Timothy did his job to proclaim God's message, he was fighting for a worthy principle or goal. GW says:

fight this noble war

Most English versions are ambiguous. If you must choose between these interpretations, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1).

fight: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fight means "campaign" or "war," not a single battle.

1 Timothy 1:19

Section 1:18–20: Paul encouraged Timothy to persevere

In this section, Paul tried to encourage Timothy. He did not want Timothy to become discouraged because of the false teachers in Ephesus. So he reminded Timothy

about the prophecies that people had spoken about him when the believers dedicated him as a pastor.

1:19a

holding on to faith and a good conscience,

- At the same time, always believe in Christ and do what you know is right.

holding on to faith and a good conscience: This phrase describes one way that Timothy needed to "fight" to proclaim the gospel. He was to use his faith in God and his good conscience.

In some languages, people cannot use a verb like hold on with an object that cannot be touched, like faith or a good conscience. In such languages it may be necessary to say something like:

continue to have faith and a good conscience

See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

a good conscience: A person who has a good conscience does not feel guilty because he knows that he has done the right thing. In English this is often expressed as "a clear conscience."

conscience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conscience refers to the part of a person that helps him know what is right and what is wrong to think or do. A conscience causes a person to feel ashamed or guilty if he does wrong. It also makes him feel good when he does what is right.

However, in many languages, there is not a word that means conscience. In some languages, there may be an idiom that can be used. In other languages, it may be necessary to translate the expression good conscience by an expression like:

doing what he knows is right

See the note on good conscience in 1:5c.

1:19b

which some have rejected

- Some people no longer pay attention to what they know is right.

Here, Paul contrasted what he was telling Timothy to do with what some people had actually done. Paul implied that Timothy should not be like the other people whom he was describing here. In some languages it may be necessary to use a connecting word to express this contrast.

which some have rejected: the Greek word *ēn*, which, is singular. This means that it probably refers to only a “good conscience.” The RSV has made this clear by saying:

By rejecting conscience

some: Paul was probably referring to the people whom he had mentioned in 1:3c, people who were teaching wrong doctrines. What he said about them here is similar to what he said about them in 1:6a. That is, he had said that they had “strayed” from a “clear conscience” and a “sincere faith.”

have rejected: When Paul said that some people rejected a “good conscience,” he meant that they were no longer paying attention to what their conscience was telling them. So they were no longer doing what they knew was right.

1:19c

and thereby shipwrecked their faith.

- Such people destroy their ability to believe in Christ, in the same way that a shipwreck destroys a ship.
- As a result, they no longer believe in Christ.

shipwrecked their faith: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as shipwrecked their faith is a metaphor. When a ship is shipwrecked, it gets damaged so badly that people can no longer use it. The ship is destroyed and useless. In this part of the verse, Paul used the word shipwrecked to refer to a person’s faith that would be destroyed. He was not referring to a literal ship. It is a person’s faith that is ruined. See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

If, in your area, ships and shipwrecks are unknown, it may not be possible to use a metaphor here. So you could do two things:

- Explain the metaphor in your translation. For example:

they destroy their ability to trust God, in the same way that a shipwreck destroys a ship

- Remove the metaphor and translate the meaning directly. For example, the GNT says:

Some people...have made a ruin of their faith.

You should use whatever method communicates best in your language.

1 Timothy 1:20

Section 1:18–20: Paul encouraged Timothy to persevere

In this section, Paul tried to encourage Timothy. He did not want Timothy to become discouraged because of the false teachers in Ephesus. So he reminded Timothy about the prophecies that people had spoken about him when the believers dedicated him as a pastor.

1:20a

Among them are Hymenaeus and Alexander,

- Hymenaeus and Alexander are among the people who act like this.

Hymenaeus and Alexander: Paul next mentioned two men, Hymenaeus and Alexander, who were examples of people who had “shipwrecked their faith.” Both these men had opposed Paul when he had taught in Ephesus, where Timothy now lived. These are probably the same two men mentioned in 2 Timothy 2:18 and 4:14–15.

1:20b

whom I have handed over to Satan

- I have separated these men from the other believers, as if I were giving them to Satan

handed over to Satan: Paul was using a figure of speech here. He meant that he would no longer allow Hymenaeus and Alexander to be part of the community of believers. In some languages, a literal translation would make people think that Paul was acting like a witch. If that is the case in your language, you may need to say something like:

I have separated them from God’s people.

Paul used similar language in 1 Corinthians 5:5, and he explained in 1 Corinthians 5:13 that it meant:

expel the wicked man from among you

Satan: Satan is the supreme evil spiritual being who leads and directs all other evil spiritual beings. In other parts of the New Testament he is referred to as “the devil” or “the Evil One.”

Satan is a proper name. So keep that name in your translation if you can. However, in some languages, it may be necessary to explain that he is the chief of the evil spirits. See Satan in the Glossary.

1:20c

to be taught not to blaspheme.

- in order that they may learn not to speak evil about God.

to be taught: Here, Paul told Timothy his purpose in no longer allowing Hymenaeus and Alexander to meet together with other believers. He was doing it to discipline them and to help them to repent.

Paul did not say who or what would teach these men not to blaspheme. There are several possibilities:

1. the punishment that Paul gave them would teach them (GNT, GW)
2. God would teach them
3. Satan would teach them

Most English versions, like the Greek text, do not say. It is recommended that you try to avoid saying whom Paul thought would teach them this. It may be possible to say something like “so that they might learn” or “so that they might realize.” It also may be possible to say that the punishment or discipline would teach them.

not to blaspheme: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to blaspheme means to speak against God in a way that dishonors him. Hymenaeus and Alexander were blaspheming by teaching wrong ideas about God.

1 Timothy 2:1

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:1–7

When believers gather together, they should pray for everybody. They should pray that God would help their government officials to govern well so that believers can worship God peacefully. They should also pray for everybody else because God wants to save everybody.

Everything that Paul wrote in this paragraph (2:1–7) was to help Timothy communicate the gospel to everyone.

One reason that Paul emphasized that the gospel was for everyone was probably because the false teachers were doing exactly the opposite. They were encouraging their followers to consider themselves as better than other people and as part of a small, elite group that excluded other people. Fee, pages 61 and 62, says, “...what might be the place of this first paragraph in

the argument? The frequent answer is that the point lies in verse 2, that prayer be made for rulers so that the church may enjoy a peaceful existence. It has even been suggested that a correct Christian attitude toward the state is what is in view. Verses 4–7, then, are seen as nearly irrelevant to that point, but go back to elaborate on a secondary point made in verse 1 (prayer be made for everyone). However, it seems much more likely that precisely the opposite is the case. The one clear concern that runs through the whole paragraph has to do with the gospel as for everyone (‘all people,’ vv. 1, 4–6, and 7). In this view, the phrase this is good in verse 3 refers to prayer for everyone in verse 1, thus seeing verse 2 as something of a digression –albeit as before (1:12–17), a meaningful one. The best explanation for this emphasis lies with the false teachers, who either through the esoteric, highly speculative nature of their teaching (1:4–6) or through its ‘Jewishness’ (1:7) or ascetic character (4:3) are promoting an elitist or exclusivist mentality among their followers. The whole paragraph attacks that narrowness.”

2:1a

First of all, then, I urge

- ¶ Therefore, Timothy,, the most important thing that I am strongly encouraging you and the other believers to do is

First of all: The Greek word that the BSB translates as First of all is the word that means “first.” In this context there are two possible meanings:

1. It refers to something that is first in importance. So Paul was saying that prayer was more important than anything else he mentioned in this section.
2. It refers to something that is first in order. So the first thing that Paul urged people to do in this section was to pray.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and translate First of all as “most importantly.”

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then is *oun*, which literally means “therefore.” Louw and Nida (89.50) say that it is a “marker of result, often implying the conclusion of a process of reasoning - ‘so, therefore, consequently, accordingly, then, so then.’” It connects this paragraph to what Paul said in chapter 1. Try to translate this connection in a general way. For example, use a word like “therefore” or “so,” or an expression like:

so, this is what I want you to do

urge: In the Greek text, this word is the same as the word that the BSB translates as urged in 1:3a. Paul was

strongly encouraging something or making an important request.

In some languages, it may be necessary to say whom Paul was addressing or urging. If this is true in your language, you could use a second person plural pronoun (like “you^(plur)”). This will make it clear that Paul was not only writing to Timothy, but expected other believers to read the letter.

2:1b

that petitions, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgiving be offered for everyone—

- to make requests to God for all people, to pray and intercede for them, and to thank God for what he has done for them.
- to pray earnestly to God for everyone and also to thank God for all that he does for them.

petitions, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgiving:

Paul used four Greek words to describe prayer. The BSB translates them as petitions, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgiving. The first three words all refer to asking God to do something. The last word, thanksgiving, refers to thanking God for what he has done.

petitions, prayers, intercessions: These three words mean almost the same thing.

petitions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as petitions refers to people asking God for particular things that they or other people need.

prayers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prayers is a more general word. It refers to people asking God in a general way to bless and care for themselves and other people.

intercessions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as intercessions refers to people asking God to supply other people’s needs.

The reason that Paul used these three similar words was to emphasize that prayer is important and that believers should pray often. However, in some languages there may not be three different words for prayer. If this is true in your language, translate this part of the verse in a way that emphasizes how important prayer is. For example:

pray earnestly

pray in every way

thanksgiving: Although the first three words that Paul used (petitions, prayers, intercessions) have a similar meaning, the final word in the list, thanksgiving, is

different. The Greek word that the BSB translates as thanksgiving refers to people thanking God for what he has done rather than asking him to do something.

be offered for everyone: Paul meant that we should pray for all kinds of people, no matter who they are. No one should be excluded. Knight, page 115, says, “The repetition of *ὑπέρ* [=‘for’] and further specification, as a subgroup, of civil rulers (v. 2) points in the direction of it meaning all kinds of people. This meaning would fit in the other occurrences of the phrase in 1 Timothy and Titus (especially Tit. 3:2) and would appear to be the understanding of the term when it was first presented to Paul as the perspective for his ministry (Acts 22:15). It is also the most natural understanding in a number of the Pauline passages where an absolute universalism is a virtual impossibility and a reference to all kinds of individuals is more likely (cf. Rom. 12:17, 18; 2 Cor. 3:2; Phil. 4:5; perhaps 1 Thes. 2:15; cf. also *εἰς πάντας* in Rom. 10:12...).”

General Comment on 2:1a–b

In some languages it may be helpful to start a new sentence for the idea of thanksgiving. For example:

So first of all, I urge you^(plur) to make petitions, prayers and intercessions for all people. And I urge you all to thank God for all that he does for us.

In other languages, it may be necessary to reorder the verse and place 2:1a after 2:1b. For example:

I urge you^(plur) to make petitions, prayers and intercessions for all people. And I urge you all to thank God. These are the most important things to do.

General Comment on 2:1b

In some languages it may be necessary to state what believers should ask God for. Paul wanted believers to pray that God would help people to stop sinning and begin to trust Christ. In the following verses (2:3–7) Paul said that God wanted to save all people. If you can avoid specifying what the believers should pray about, you should do so. However if you need to say what the believers should pray for, you could say:

to pray that everyone be saved

In other languages, it may be necessary to state what people should thank God for. Avoid being too specific. Instead, use a general phrase like:

thank God for everything he has done for people

1 Timothy 2:2

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:1–7

When believers gather together, they should pray for everybody. They should pray that God would help their government officials to govern well so that believers can worship God peacefully. They should also pray for everybody else because God wants to save everybody.

Everything that Paul wrote in this paragraph (2:1–7) was to help Timothy communicate the gospel to everyone.

One reason that Paul emphasized that the gospel was for everyone was probably because the false teachers were doing exactly the opposite. They were encouraging their followers to consider themselves as better than other people and as part of a small, elite group that excluded other people. Fee, pages 61 and 62, says, “...what might be the place of this first paragraph in the argument? The frequent answer is that the point lies in verse 2, that prayer be made for rulers so that the church may enjoy a peaceful existence. It has even been suggested that a correct Christian attitude toward the state is what is in view. Verses 4–7, then, are seen as nearly irrelevant to that point, but go back to elaborate on a secondary point made in verse 1 (prayer be made for everyone). However, it seems much more likely that precisely the opposite is the case. The one clear concern that runs through the whole paragraph has to do with the gospel as for everyone (‘all people,’ vv. 1, 4–6, and 7). In this view, the phrase this is good in verse 3 refers to prayer for everyone in verse 1, thus seeing verse 2 as something of a digression —albeit as before (1:12–17), a meaningful one. The best explanation for this emphasis lies with the false teachers, who either through the esoteric, highly speculative nature of their teaching (1:4–6) or through its ‘Jewishness’ (1:7) or ascetic character (4:3) are promoting an elitist or exclusivist mentality among their followers. The whole paragraph attacks that narrowness.”

2:2a

for kings and all those in authority—

- You^(plur) should pray especially for kings and all other government officials.
- Especially pray that God may help all those who rule and have authority to rule justly

for kings and all those in authority: In 2:1 Paul said that people should pray for everyone. Here in 2:2 Paul became more specific and said that believers should especially pray for people in positions of authority. Paul probably wanted the believers to ask God to help government officials to govern justly. When the authorities govern well, it is much more likely that people can live “peaceful and quiet lives,” as Paul mentioned in 2:2b.

kings: Notice that Paul used the plural form of the word for “king.” So he was not referring only to the Roman emperor (who ruled over all the countries in the Roman empire), but also to other rulers under the Emperor’s authority. For example, people called Agrippa a king, even though he was under the authority of the Roman emperor (Acts 25:13).

all those in authority: Paul wanted believers to pray not only for kings, but also for everyone who had authority in the community. This refers to government rulers and includes people like district officials and village chiefs—anyone who has been appointed or elected as a leader of the community.

General Comment on 2:2a

Paul uses the expression “kings and all those in authority” to include everyone who was involved in governing people in any way or who was responsible for making sure people acted peacefully. It is important that you also communicate that all rulers are included from the most important ones to the lower officials.

2:2b

so that we may lead tranquil and quiet lives

- In that way, we^(incl) will be able to live peacefully and safely.
- so that they will enable us^(incl) to live in peace and security.

so that: The Greek word *hina* that the BSB translates as so that shows the result of 2:2a, that is, the result when people in authority govern justly.

tranquil and quiet: The Greek words that the BSB translates as tranquil and quiet are very similar in meaning. They both refer to a way of life that is calm and orderly. In this context, Paul meant that if believers prayed for those in authority, then no one would cause trouble for the believers. They would be

free to tell other people about Christ, to meet with other believers, and to worship God.

2:2c

in all godliness and dignity.

- Then we^(incl) will be able to freely worship God and to do what he wants us^(incl) to do.

When government officials govern justly, it is much easier for believers to obey God's laws. They are able to meet together to worship God. They can tell also others freely about Christ because they do not fear that they will be persecuted or imprisoned.

godliness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as godliness refers to the way people behave when they respect God. See godliness, godly in the Glossary.

dignity: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as dignity could also be translated as “proper conduct,” “respect for God,” and “honesty.” This word also occurs in 3:4b.

It could be translated as:

to act in the right way

to act as one ought

1 Timothy 2:3

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

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2:3a

This is good

- It is good to pray for people like this,
- We^(incl) do what is right when we^(incl) pray like this,

This is good: The Greek word that the BSB translates as This refers to what Paul commanded in 2:1–2, that is, to pray for everyone. So here he said it was a good/right thing for people to pray for everyone.

2:3b

and pleasing in the sight of God our Savior,

- and such prayers please God our^(incl) Savior.
- and God, who saves us,^(incl) is pleased.

pleasing in the sight of God our Savior: This is the reason that it is “good” to pray for everyone (2:3a). When a person prays, it is pleasing to God.

God our Savior: When Paul mentioned God here, he was referring to God the Father. As discussed in the note on 1:1c, New Testament authors more usually refer to Christ as Savior. However, Paul used this expression six times in 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus.

our: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

Savior: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Savior refers to a person who saves or rescues someone else from danger. Paul was saying that God rescues all people who trust in Christ. In other words, he saves them from their sin and its consequences.

1 Timothy 2:4

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

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When believers gather together, they should pray for everybody. They should pray that God would help their government officials to govern well so that believers can worship God peacefully. They should also pray for everybody else because God wants to save everybody.

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One reason that Paul emphasized that the gospel was for everyone was probably because the false teachers were doing exactly the opposite. They were encouraging their followers to consider themselves as better than other people and as part of a small, elite group that excluded other people. Fee, pages 61 and 62, says, “...what might be the place of this first paragraph in the argument? The frequent answer is that the point lies in verse 2, that prayer be made for rulers so that the church may enjoy a peaceful existence. It has even been suggested that a correct Christian attitude toward the state is what is in view. Verses 4–7, then, are seen as nearly irrelevant to that point, but go back to elaborate on a secondary point made in verse 1 (prayer be made for everyone). However, it seems much more likely that precisely the opposite is the case. The one clear concern that runs through the whole paragraph has to do with the gospel as for everyone (‘all people,’ vv. 1, 4–6, and 7). In this view, the phrase this is good in verse 3 refers to prayer for everyone in verse 1, thus seeing verse 2 as something of a digression —albeit as before (1:12–17), a meaningful one. The best explanation for this emphasis lies with the false teachers, who either through the esoteric, highly speculative nature of their teaching (1:4–6) or through its ‘Jewishness’ (1:7) or ascetic character (4:3) are promoting an elitist or exclusivist mentality among their followers. The whole paragraph attacks that narrowness.”

2:4

Here Paul stated the reasons that God would be pleased when believers prayed for everyone. Paul knew that God wanted two important things:

1. that people are saved (2:4a)

2. that people come to a knowledge of the truth (2:4b)

2:4a

who wants everyone to be saved

- God wants everyone to be saved from sin

wants everyone to be saved: This is the first thing that God wants for everyone, that is he wants to save everyone.

to be saved: In some languages it will be necessary to provide a subject here and say that it is God who saves people. In other languages it may be necessary to make explicit what people are to be saved from. God saves people from their sin.

2:4b

and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

- and to eventually know the truth.
- and to learn the truth of his message.

to come to the knowledge of the truth: Not only does God want to save everyone. He also wants everyone to understand the truth about him, not just with their minds. They should also act according to the truth.

the truth: In this context, Paul used the expression that the BSB translates as the truth to refer to the Christian message. Paul explained more about this in 2:5b through 2:6b.

In many languages this can be a difficult expression to translate. Three possible ways are:

God’s true message

what is true, that is, God’s message

the true message about God

General Comment on 2:3–4

In 2:4, Paul stated the reason that it is good to pray for other people and why it pleases God. In some languages, it may be necessary to reorder 2:3 and 2:4. One way to do this is:

^{4a}God wants all people to be saved ^{4b}and come to know the truth. Therefore, when we pray for everyone, ^{3a}we are doing something right ^{3b}and pleasing God.

1 Timothy 2:5

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

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2:5–6

These verses were probably a special saying that believers recited together when they met to worship God. It is not clear where the saying ends.

2:5a

For there is one God,

- For there is only one God
- We^(incl) believe that there is one true God

For: Paul used the Greek word that the BSB translates as For to introduce verses 2:5–6. Paul could have used this Greek word *gar* in one of two ways in this verse:

1. To loosely connect two thoughts BAGD says that for (*γάρ*) in this verse expresses “continuation or connection (in later Gk. writers, where more recent users of the texts, not finding the causal force they expect, would often prefer to see it replaced by *δέ*...) yes, indeed; certainly...” See also Zerwick, paragraph 473. Dibelius and Conzelmann on page 41 say, “These verses are not easy to connect with what precedes. The contrast is not “one God and not many” (as in 1 Cor 8:6), but rather, looking back to “all men” (*πάντες*), “since there is one God, all shall be saved” (related to this are Rom 3:30 and Eph 4:6). However this connection seems secondary and the phrase is perhaps best explained by the assumption that the author concludes the thought with a solemn formula.”
2. To introduce a reason for the previous verses. This is the more normal use of *gar* in Greek.

However, 2:5 says that there is one God (2:5a) and one mediator (2:5b). It does not give the reason why God wants to save everybody. Therefore, it is best to translate the word For here in a way that shows that 2:5 is loosely connected with what Paul had said in 2:4.

there is one God: One of the most important beliefs of the Bible is that there is only one God. Even before New Testament times Jewish people repeated the words of Deuteronomy 6:4 every day to remind themselves of this truth. These words say, “Hear, O Israel: the Lord our God, the Lord is one.” This confession is called the Shema. M. R. Wilson in International Standard Bible Encyclopedia (volume 4, page 469) says, “The practice of reciting the Shema daily is firmly established in the Mishnah (ca. A.D. 200), which underscores the Shema’s importance in Jewish religious experience by its opening words: ‘From what time in the evening may the Shema’ be recited?’ (Berakoth i.1). But there is also evidence of the Shema’s use during and even before the NT era...”

2:5b

and there is one mediator between God and men,

- and there is only one person who can make peace between God and people.

one mediator between God and men: At the time when Paul wrote this letter, some Jewish people thought that Moses was the mediator between God and humanity. Other people thought that angels were mediators. Paul was making it clear here that there is only one person who can mediate between God and people.

mediator: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mediator refers to a person who helps two people or groups of people resolve a dispute.

In 2:6a Paul explained the way in which Christ was the mediator between God and people. After Jesus died on the cross, he began to mediate between God and sinful people, so that God could accept them.

men: The word that the BSB translates as men here does not only refer to males. It includes all human beings: men, women, and children.

2:5c

the man Christ Jesus,

- That person is Christ Jesus.

the man Christ Jesus: Jesus was both God and human. That means that he is a good mediator because he can represent both God and people. When Paul said here that Christ, the mediator, was a man, he was emphasizing that Christ was not only God, but also fully human.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as man does not emphasize that Christ was male instead of female. Instead, it emphasizes that he is a person, a human being.

Notice that Paul said the name of the mediator, Christ Jesus, only after he had talked about him. By waiting until after he had talked about him to say his name, Paul emphasized the identity of the mediator. In your language it may be necessary to show this emphasis in another way.

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Some people, however, think that when Paul used the word Christ before the word Jesus, as in Christ Jesus, he was emphasizing that Jesus was the Messiah.

In most English versions “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

However, it is possible that, in some languages, people may be confused to see the names in two different

orders. They may even think that Paul was referring to two different people. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ.” This is the more usual word order in the New Testament.

Christ: The word Christ is used in two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

1 Timothy 2:6

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:1–7

When believers gather together, they should pray for everybody. They should pray that God would help their government officials to govern well so that believers can worship God peacefully. They should also pray for everybody else because God wants to save everybody.

Everything that Paul wrote in this paragraph (2:1–7) was to help Timothy communicate the gospel to everyone.

One reason that Paul emphasized that the gospel was for everyone was probably because the false teachers were doing exactly the opposite. They were encouraging their followers to consider themselves as better than other people and as part of a small, elite group that excluded other people. Fee, pages 61 and 62, says, “...what might be the place of this first paragraph in the argument? The frequent answer is that the point lies in verse 2, that prayer be made for rulers so that the church may enjoy a peaceful existence. It has even been suggested that a correct Christian attitude toward the state is what is in view. Verses 4–7, then, are seen as nearly irrelevant to that point, but go back to elaborate on a secondary point made in verse 1 (prayer be made for everyone). However, it seems much more likely that precisely the opposite is the case. The one clear concern that runs through the whole paragraph has to do with the gospel as for everyone (‘all people,’ vv. 1, 4–6, and 7). In this view, the phrase this is good

in verse 3 refers to prayer for everyone in verse 1, thus seeing verse 2 as something of a digression —albeit as before (1:12–17), a meaningful one. The best explanation for this emphasis lies with the false teachers, who either through the esoteric, highly speculative nature of their teaching (1:4–6) or through its ‘Jewishness’ (1:7) or ascetic character (4:3) are promoting an elitist or exclusivist mentality among their followers. The whole paragraph attacks that narrowness.”

2:6a

who gave Himself as a ransom for all—

- He died willingly to pay the price to set everybody free from sin.

In this verse part Paul described the way in which Christ acted as a mediator.

gave Himself: This means that Jesus willingly died.

ransom: The Greek word *antilutron* that the BSB translates as ransom refers to a price that was paid to set someone free from captivity or slavery. In this verse Paul said that Jesus himself was the ransom. When he died, he paid the price to set people free (see Romans 3:23–24 and 1 Peter 1:18–19).

Paul did not say who received the payment of Jesus’ death. Since the New Testament never actually states to whom the payment was made, different theories have developed. The theory that God paid himself is referred to by Millard Erickson in *Christian Theology*, page 796, as the commercial or satisfaction theory of the atonement. He says, “It emphasizes that Christ died to satisfy a principle in the very nature of God the Father. Not only was the atonement not primarily directed at man, but it also did not involve any sort of payment to Satan.” So you should avoid making this explicit in your translation. R. W. Lyon, in the article entitled “Ransom” in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, page 908, says, “In the NT the terms of ransom and purchase, which in other contexts suggest an economic or financial exchange, speak of the consequences or results (cf. 1 Cor. 7:23). The release is from judgment (Rom. 3:25–26), sin (Eph. 1:7), death (Rom. 8:2). There is no need, then, to ask the question posed so often in the past: to whom was the ransom paid?” For example, the NCV says:

He gave himself as a payment to free all people.

and the NLT says:

He gave his life to purchase freedom for everyone.

In some languages it will not be possible to keep the figure of speech about paying a ransom. If this is true in your language, you could follow the REB which says:

who sacrificed himself to win freedom for all mankind

However if you translate that way, the verse will not explain the way that Jesus’ death sets people free from sin. So try to keep the figure of speech if you can.

A similar Greek word *lutron* occurs in Matthew 20:28 and Mark 10:45. In those verses, Jesus said that he came “to give his life as a ransom for many.” Try to translate ransom in the same way here as you did in these other passages.

for: The Greek word *huper* that the BSB translates as for means “on behalf of, in the place of” in this context.

all: The word that the BSB translates as all here refers to all people. It includes all human beings: men, women, and children. There is debate as to whether Christ actually died for all people, meaning every single person (this is called universal atonement), or only for the elect (this is called limited atonement). John Stott’s statement at this point is worth mentioning: “As with the statement that God desires all people to be saved, so with the statement that Christ gave himself for all people, it is possible to argue that ‘all’ means ‘all kinds and classes’ and not ‘absolutely everybody’.” Yet it is probably wiser to concede that Scripture appears to affirm both positions in an antinomy [a logical contradiction which cannot be resolved] which we are at present unable to resolve. Whatever we may decide about the scope of the atonement, we are absolutely forbidden to limit the scope of world mission. The gospel must be preached to all, and salvation must be offered to all” (page 71).

2:6b

the testimony that was given at just the right time.

- At the right time he became evidence that God wanted to save everyone.
- At the time God chose, God provided him as proof that he wanted to save everyone.

the testimony that was given at just the right time:

The Greek text here literally says “the testimony in its own times.” In most languages it is necessary to supply a verb here. The BSB does so by using the verb given. Paul had mentioned Christ’s sacrifice in 2:5b–6a. Here he said it was the message that has been told to people (by God).

the testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testimony refers to something that proves something else. In this verse Paul said that Jesus' death was a testimony, or proof, that God wanted all people to be saved (2:4a) and to come to know the truth (2:4b). The GNT makes this clear by translating this verse part as:

That was the proof at the right time that God wants everyone to be saved

at just the right time: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as at just the right time means that God announced his message to people at the exact time he had chosen. For example, the NLT says:

This is the message that God gave to the world at the proper time.

(BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, REB, NET, CEV, NCV, NLT)

General Comment on 2:5–6

As stated above, these verses possibly contain a saying that believers used to recite. Some English versions try to show this by using a poetry format. For example, the CEV says:

^{5a}There is only one God,

^{5b}and Christ Jesus

is the only one

who can bring us

to God.

^{5c}Jesus was truly human,

^{6a}and he gave himself

to rescue all of us.

^{6b}God showed us this

at the right time.

Another way to indicate this is to use quotations marks for the saying. However, scholars do not agree about where the saying ends. It may end with 2:6b, or 2:6b may have been a comment made by Paul. If it was a comment, it was not part of the saying (See the NRSV). Therefore, it is recommended that you do not use any special formatting here.

1 Timothy 2:7

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:1–7

When believers gather together, they should pray for everybody. They should pray that God would help their government officials to govern well so that believers can worship God peacefully. They should also pray for everybody else because God wants to save everybody.

Everything that Paul wrote in this paragraph (2:1–7) was to help Timothy communicate the gospel to everyone.

One reason that Paul emphasized that the gospel was for everyone was probably because the false teachers were doing exactly the opposite. They were encouraging their followers to consider themselves as better than other people and as part of a small, elite group that excluded other people. Fee, pages 61 and 62, says, "...what might be the place of this first paragraph in the argument? The frequent answer is that the point lies in verse 2, that prayer be made for rulers so that the church may enjoy a peaceful existence. It has even been suggested that a correct Christian attitude toward the state is what is in view. Verses 4–7, then, are seen as nearly irrelevant to that point, but go back to elaborate on a secondary point made in verse 1 (prayer be made for everyone). However, it seems much more likely that precisely the opposite is the case. The one clear concern that runs through the whole paragraph has to do with the gospel as for everyone ('all people,' vv. 1, 4–6, and 7). In this view, the phrase this is good in verse 3 refers to prayer for everyone in verse 1, thus seeing verse 2 as something of a digression –albeit as before (1:12–17), a meaningful one. The best explanation for this emphasis lies with the false teachers, who either through the esoteric, highly speculative nature of their teaching (1:4–6) or through its 'Jewishness' (1:7) or ascetic character (4:3) are promoting an

elitist or exclusivist mentality among their followers. The whole paragraph attacks that narrowness.”

2:7a

For this reason

- That is why

For this reason: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as For this reason literally means “for which.” The phrase connects 2:7 with 2:6 and this connection can be understood in two ways:

1. Verse 7 is the result of 2:6. For example, the GNT says:

and that is why (GNT, NCV, CEV)

1. Verse 7 is the purpose for which 2:6 occurred. For example, the NIV says:

And for this purpose (BSB, NIV, GW)

Some English translations say “for this.” This English phrase does not make it clear whether they mean “for this reason” or “for this purpose” (NASB, RSV, NET). If you cannot keep the ambiguity, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Because God sent Christ Jesus to save all people (2:3–6), he appointed Paul to announce the gospel.

2:7b

I was appointed as a preacher, an apostle,

- I was chosen to be a herald of the gospel and an apostle.
- God appointed me to announce the gospel and be an apostle.

I was appointed: The Greek text uses a passive here and does not say who had appointed Paul. If it is necessary in your language to use an active verb here, you should say that God appointed him. Some other words for appointed are “assigned” or “chosen.”

a preacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a preacher is more literally “a herald.” A herald is a person that a king or another ruler has appointed to announce a message publicly. Paul was emphasizing that he announced important news like a herald does.

an apostle: Paul was emphasizing that God had sent him to represent Christ. For more details, see the note on “apostle” at 1:1b.

In some languages it may be helpful to translate this part of the verse as a direct quote. For example:

That is the reason that Christ appointed me and told me: “You are to announce the gospel message publicly and represent me.”

2:7c

and a faithful and true teacher of the Gentiles.

- I was also chosen to teach the true message of faith to the Gentiles.
- God also appointed me to teach his true message to the non-Jews.

faithful and true: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as faithful and true literally means “in faith and truth.” These words can refer to:

1. what Paul taught: the content of his message. For example, the GNT says:

the message of faith and truth (GNT, NIV, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. how Paul taught, that is, he taught faithfully and truthfully. For example, the NJB says:

a teacher of the gentiles in faith and truth (BSB, NJB, RSV, KJV, NASB)

Paul had been talking about the message that he proclaimed. There is no reason to think that Paul suddenly changed his topic and said that he himself was teaching faithfully and truthfully. So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). That is, Paul was continuing to talk about the message that he proclaimed.

The Greek words meaning “faith and truth” that the BSB translates as faithful and true can be understood in two ways:

1. This is a hendiadys; that is, the two words “faith” and “truth” refer to one thing. For example, the NIV says:

the true faith (NIV, REB)

1. The two words refer to two things. For example, the GNT says:

the message of faith and truth (BSB, GNT, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and translate this as one phrase, “the true faith.” “The true faith” refers to God’s message.

See faith, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

teacher of the Gentiles: Gentiles are people who are not Jews. You may wish to put a footnote or glossary entry in your translation to explain who Gentiles are.

2:7d

I am telling the truth; I am not lying about anything.

- What I am saying is true. I am not lying.

I am telling the truth; The translators of some versions add the words “in Christ.” For example, the KJV says, “I speak the truth in Christ.” However, most scholars agree that these words were not present in Paul’s original letter to Timothy. The Editorial Committee of the United Bible Societies New Testament (4th edition) gives the reading without “in Christ” an {A} rating, indicating that the text is almost certain. I am not lying: Paul had written in 2:7b, that he had been appointed as an apostle. Then he added that he was telling the truth and not lying. This could refer to three things:

1. the whole sentence (GNT, NLT, GW)
2. just the phrase that he was a teacher of the Gentiles (NJB)
3. just the phrase that he was an apostle

Other English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you translate this to refer to the whole sentence. Probably some people were saying that Paul was not really an apostle. Others may have been saying that Christ had not really authorized Paul to teach the Gentiles.

General Comment on 2:7b–d

Paul was not saying that God had chosen him to do three different jobs (herald, apostle, and teacher). Instead, he was saying that he had one task that had three parts. These same three parts are also mentioned in 2 Timothy 1:11.

General Comment on 2:7a–d

Another way to translate this verse is:

^{7a}That is why ^{7b}God sent me as an apostle to announce ^{7c}and teach his true message even to those who are not Jews. ^{7d}What I am saying is true. I am not lying.

1 Timothy 2:8

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The

men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:8

In 2:2a, Paul told Timothy whom believers should pray for. Here in 2:8, he told him how the men should pray. They should pray, “lifting holy hands,” and “without anger or disputing.”

2:8a

Therefore I want the men everywhere

- ¶ I am telling men that wherever they meet to worship God,
- ¶ Therefore, in every place where believers gather to worship God, I command the men

Therefore: This translates the Greek word *oun*. This Greek word connects this verse with 2:1–7. Some translations leave the connection implicit here. You should use the method in your language that most clearly conveys that 2:8 is the result of previous verses, that is, God wants Christians to pray for everyone. Therefore, men should pray, lifting holy hands in prayer, without anger or disputing.

I want: Because Paul was an apostle (as he mentioned in 2:7b), he had authority to tell believers what he wanted them to do. He could also expect them to obey him. Therefore, when Paul wrote I want, he meant “I command.”

the men: The Greek word here that the BSB translates as men means males as opposed to females. It seems that Paul was speaking here about a problem that specifically affected the male believers.

everywhere: At the time when Paul was writing this letter, believers often met in each others’ houses to pray and worship God. The words that the BSB translates as everywhere probably refer to all the different places where believers met. Ferguson (1991). For example, the NLT says:

wherever you assemble

2:8b

to pray, lifting up holy hands,

- they should make sure that they are living in a holy way before they lift their hands to pray to God.
- to pray, raising their hands in total dedication to God.

to pray, lifting up holy hands: At the time when Paul was writing, people normally prayed standing up. They also often lifted their hands while they prayed. Stott,

page 82, refers the reader to the following references about standing for prayer: Nehemiah 9:5; cf. Genesis 18:22; 1 Samuel 1:26; Mark 11:25; Luke 18:11, 18:13; Revelation 7:9. He refers to the following references about “lifting” or “spreading” hands in prayer: Psalm 28:2; Lamentations 3:41; cf. Exodus 9:29, 17:11–12; 1 Kings 8:22; Nehemiah 8:6; Psalms 63:4, 134:2, 143:6. This was also a common way to pray in the Old Testament. See Psalm 134:2, Lamentations 2:19 for examples.

holy hands: Before men pray they should be sure to give themselves totally to God. Paul was emphasizing this when he said that men’s hands should be holy.

2:8c without anger or dissension.

- They should not be angry or still have an unresolved argument with someone.
- They should stop being angry with anyone and if they have been arguing with someone, they should resolve the argument before they pray.

without anger or dissension: Here Paul mentioned specifically in what sense the men should be holy when they prayed. They should not feel angry toward anyone and they should not be continually quarreling with anyone. Jesus said something similar in Matthew 5:23–24.

anger: Paul was saying that a person should not pray while he is angry with someone else. He was probably thinking mainly that believers should not be angry at each other. He meant that people should stop being angry so that they can pray.

dissension: Paul meant that people should resolve their arguments and quarrels before they pray.

1 Timothy 2:9

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:9–15

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy how female believers should dress and behave when they met to worship God. Paul had instructed the men in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for them (2:8). In this paragraph he instructed the women in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for the women.

2:9a

Likewise, I want the women to adorn themselves with respectable apparel,

- ¶ Also when believers meet to worship, women are to dress appropriately.
- ¶ Concerning women, I want them to dress in a way that people consider to be proper.

Likewise, I want: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Likewise literally means “in the same way.” In 2:8, Paul told men what he wanted them to do. Here, he began to tell women what he wanted them to do. It may be helpful in some languages to supply “I want” (from 2:8a) as the BSB has done.

the women: This probably refers to any female who is considered old enough to be married, even if she is still unmarried. Your language may have a general word that refers to both married and unmarried adult women. If so, you should use it here.

to adorn themselves with respectable apparel: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to adorn themselves with respectable apparel is literally “to adorn themselves with modest clothing.” It is important to dress and behave modestly. Paul was telling the woman that they should not dress or behave in a way that made everyone look at them. Some of them probably spent too much money on clothes. Others maybe dressed in ways that people thought inappropriate.

respectable apparel: The Greek word *kosmios* that the BSB translates as respectable apparel refers to dressing in a way that people in the community think of as proper, acceptable, or appropriate. See Louw and Nida on *kosmios*; 88.48 and 66.10.

2:9b

with modesty, and with self-control,

- They should be careful to dress respectably and properly.

with modesty, and with self-control: This part of the verse further describes the way in which women should dress.

modesty: The Greek word *aidōs* Liddell and Scott say this word (*aidōs*) is used “as a moral feeling, reverence, awe, respect for the feeling or opinion of others or for one’s own conscience, and so shame, self-respect... sense of honour.” Louw and Nida (88.49) define it as “the quality of modesty, with the implication of resulting respect—‘modesty.’” *aidōs* that the BSB translates as modesty means that a woman should dress in a way that did not offend other people. The way she dresses should also not bring shame and dishonor upon her.

If she did not dress with modesty, people might think that she was dressing to attract men. Every culture has different standards of modesty. So try to avoid using a word or expression that describes specifically what is considered “modest” in your culture.

self-control: The Greek word *sōphrosunē*, page 134, says, “This word was used of one of the four cardinal virtues in Platonic philosophy (Plato, Republic 4.430e) and signified a command over bodily passions, a state of self-mastery in the area of the appetite.” *sōphrosunē* that the BSB translates as self-control means almost the same thing as *aidōs* modesty. It means to act in a way that people consider correct, acceptable, or appropriate.

These two words translated modesty and self-control mean almost the same thing. In some languages there will not be two separate words for this idea. If this is true in your language, you may translate it with one emphasized word:

with the utmost decency

General Comment on 2:9b

In some languages, it may be necessary to explain in more detail what Paul meant here. One way to do this is:

They should always be sure that their clothing covers their body sufficiently, rather than dressing in order to cause men to desire them.

2:9c–d

In 2:9c–d, Paul gave instructions about things Christian women should avoid when they made themselves beautiful. He chose as examples some ways in which immoral women (such as prostitutes) in Ephesus dressed. He could also have been referring to the way wealthy women dressed.

2:9c

not with braided hair

- They should not braid their hair,
- They should not arrange their hair in fancy ways,

2:9c begins with the implied command “Do not adorn yourselves [with...].” You may need to supply a suitable verb here.

braided hair: When women braid their hair, they twist several strands of it together in a special way. They may have one, two, or many braids. In many parts of the world, this is a normal and respectable way for a woman to dress her hair. However, in Paul’s time,

women normally did not braid their hair. Instead, they parted it in the middle, pulled it back, and fastened it with a pin or scarf. S. M. Baugh in *Women in the Church*, pages 47–48.

In 2:9c, Paul was referring to the elaborate hairstyles that wealthy women in Ephesus considered fashionable. See Hurley, page 199. Paul said that Christian women should not wear their hair in these ways. Instead, they should wear their hair in a more simple arrangement.

If in your culture women do not braid their hair, you may want to follow the GNT, which says:

fancy hair styles

Respectable women in many cultures do braid their hair. If this is true in your region, try to use a more general expression.

2:9d

or gold or pearls

- nor should they wear jewelry made of material such as gold or pearls,

gold: Gold was a very valuable metal. Here Paul was referring to jewelry made from gold that women wore to decorate either their hair or their body.

pearls: The word pearls refers to small, round, white objects that grow inside the shells of oysters. They also are expensive, sometimes even more valuable than gold. Here Paul was referring to jewelry which included pearls. If pearls are unknown in your region, you will need to use a phrase like “expensive jewelry.”

General Comment on 2:9d

Paul was not telling the women that they should never wear jewelry. Instead, he was explaining what it meant in Ephesus to dress modestly (2:9a), and with decency and propriety (2:9b).

2:9e

or expensive clothes,

- nor should they wear extravagant clothes.

expensive clothes: Paul was saying that believers should not dress in clothing that cost a lot of money. If they did so, people might think they were doing so just to show how wealthy and beautiful they were. In English, words like “extravagant,” “ostentatious,” and “showy” convey this meaning. It is the opposite of “respectable” in 2:9a.

General Comment on 2:9c–e

Different cultures differ in what they consider as modest, decent and proper clothing, hair styles and jewelry. Therefore, the details of Paul's instructions do not apply to all women in every place in the world for all time. The important thing is that in every culture female believers should dress in a way that their culture considers to be proper.

1 Timothy 2:10

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:9–15

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy how female believers should dress and behave when they met to worship God. Paul had instructed the men in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for them (2:8). In this paragraph he instructed the women in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for the women.

2:10

In 2:9, Paul gave instructions about what women should not do. In this verse, he told them what they should do.

2:10a

but with good deeds,

- Instead, women should act kindly toward other people.
- Instead, women should concentrate on doing things that help other people.

with good deeds: Earlier in this chapter, Paul had said that women should not try to make themselves beautiful with jewelry or expensive clothes. Here he was saying that they should rather “adorn themselves” with good deeds. This is a figure of speech. Obviously people cannot literally make themselves beautiful with good deeds.

In some languages, it will not be possible to use the same verb for putting on jewels and clothes and also for putting on good deeds. If that is true in your language, you will probably need to use different verbs. Do whatever is most natural in your language.

2:10b

as is proper for women who profess to worship God.

- That is the right behavior for women who claim to worship God.
- That is what God wants women who say that they worship him to do.

as is proper: Paul was using the word proper to refer to what God wants women to do. Paul was saying that God wants women to do good things to help other people.

who profess to worship God: Paul was talking about women who said that they were believers and that they worshiped God.

worship: The Greek word that the BSB translates as “to worship God” here is a word that is sometimes translated as “godliness.” It does not only refer to worshiping God, but also to obeying and respecting him.

1 Timothy 2:11

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

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In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy how female believers should dress and behave when they met to worship God. Paul had instructed the men in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for them (2:8). In this paragraph he instructed the women in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for the women.

2:11

A woman must learn in quietness and full submissiveness.

- Every woman should listen to what is being taught without interrupting. She should also show complete respect to the one who is teaching.
- When other people are teaching the believers, all women should learn by listening quietly and very respectfully.

Paul continued to give instructions to women in general in 2:11–12. In these verses he told Timothy the way that women should behave when believers met together.

A woman: That is, every woman, all women. In some languages it will be better to use a plural here.

must learn: Paul was saying that people must learn about God. This normally happened when believers met together so that someone could teach them from Scripture. Some people interpret this to mean that Paul is commanding that women learn, and is implying that they would be able to teach men after they have learned. They say that the real problem is that women in Ephesus had not learned before they taught. However, this overlooks the fact that Paul is not emphasizing that women learn, but that they learn quietly and submissively. Also, Paul expressly forbids women from teaching men in verse 12. For a more detailed rebuttal, see Schreiner in *Women in the Church*, pages 121–123.

in quietness: Paul did not mean that women should be totally silent in church. This is clear from 1 Corinthians 11:5, where Paul referred to women praying and prophesying during public worship. Paul probably meant that women were to listen quietly when someone was teaching the believers. They were not to chatter and interrupt the person who was teaching God's message.

and full submissiveness: Paul meant that women were not to argue publicly with those who taught the believers. They were to be respectful and submit to their authority.

full: The Greek word that the BSB translates as full is literally “all.” Paul meant that women were to be completely respectful to those who taught the believers.

1 Timothy 2:12

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

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Paragraph 2:9–15

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy how female believers should dress and behave when they met to worship God. Paul had instructed the men in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for them (2:8). In this paragraph he instructed the women in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for the women.

2:12

This verse is similar to 2:11. This verse starts with the word *de* in the Greek. Some people think that with the use of *de* here Paul is making a contrast, saying that “a woman can learn, but she cannot publicly teach

the Scriptures to men or have authority over them.” However, that is not the point Paul is making. Paul stresses in 2:11 not just that a woman learn, but that a woman learn in quietness and full submission. Learning in quietness does not contrast with not permitting a woman to teach or to have authority over a man. Instead, it reinforces it. Some think that verses 11 and 12 are chiasmic. Schreiner in *Women in the Church*, in footnote 88 on page 124, says, “I question whether there is a chiasm here because then the idea of exercising authority should have preceded teaching. Instead, the two verses are closely related, with an *inclusio* binding them together. Another problem with seeing a chiasm is that the scholars cited above do not agree on the chiasmic arrangement.” The chart below shows how the two verses are similar:

Verse 11	Verse 12
a woman	a woman
let her learn	I do not permit...to teach
with full submission	or to have authority over a man
in quietness	be silent

2:12a

I do not permit a woman to teach or to exercise authority over a man;

- I do not allow any woman to teach other believers or to rule over the men in the Christian community.
- I do not allow women to teach men about God or rule over them.

I do not permit: Paul was not merely expressing his personal opinion. Here I disagree with Phillips' translation, which says, “Personally, I don't allow...” All through this section, he had been speaking as an apostle. This meant that God had given him the authority to tell believers what to do (see 2:1a, 2:8a, 2:9a). In this verse he continued speaking the same way. The Greek expression that the BSB translates as I do not permit meant that Paul was emphasizing that others should obey him.

a woman: That is, every woman, all women. If you used a plural in 2:11, you should do the same here.

to teach: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as teach refers to three things:

1. instructing people about Christ
2. instructing people about what Scripture teaches
3. instructing people about the way in which God wants people to behave

or: When Paul used the word *or* here, he was saying that women should neither teach men nor have authority over them. Some people (like Philip Payne in “The Interpretation of 1 Timothy 2:1–11: A Surrejoinder,” unpublished paper referred to by Moo in the reference below) take this as an example of hendiadys. They say that Paul does not say anything here about women not exercising authority over men. Instead, they say that the word *or* indicates that women should not teach men in an authoritative way. But other people (like Douglas Moo in “What Does It Mean Not to Teach or Have Authority Over Men? 1 Timothy 2:11–15,” in *Recovering Biblical Manhood and Womanhood*, page 187) point out that the Greek word *or* is not usually used in hendiadys. They say that Paul is prohibiting women from both teaching and exercising authority, whether done together or separately.

to exercise authority: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *to exercise authority* means that a person controls, dominates, or begins to exert authority over another person. Kroeger and Kroeger say that one of the senses of the word “have authority” is “to represent oneself as the author, originator, or source of something.” So, they say that certain women were teaching that they were the originator of men, and that what Paul was forbidding here was not that women “teach or have authority over men” but that women “teach that they are the originator of man.” They continue to say that pagan thought in the area had long held that woman was the source of man. They also say that certain types of gnosticism known to have been taught in the area of Ephesus about 100 to 200 years after this time may have already been taught in less well-developed forms during Paul’s time. These types of gnosticism also taught that woman was the source of man. So, Paul was combating that false teaching in this verse. However, see the exhaustive study of this word by Baldwin in *Women in the Church*, pages 65–80, and his exhaustive study of the full context of each occurrence of the word known in Koine Greek, pages 269–305. According to Baldwin, the Kroegers’ claims as to the meaning of the Greek word “to have authority” is based on a misinterpretation of one of the attested meanings “to be primarily responsible for or instigate something.” Furthermore, the Kroegers’ theory is speculative, assuming that specific forms of later Gnostic teachings were also taught during the time which Paul wrote. See also Schreiner’s survey and critique of various positions in *Women in the Church*, pages 130–134. John Stott, pages 74–81, draws a distinction between what is culturally conditioned and what are timeless principles in verses 8 through 15. He says that the timeless principles are

that men should pray without sin, anger, or fighting, that women should dress modestly, and that women should be submissive to men. He says that the culturally conditioned elements are the way men pray (with lifted hands), the particular way women should not dress (with gold or braided hair), and the way women should be submissive to men (by being silent and not teaching). Further, on page 81, he distinguishes between two kinds of teaching roles. One is where the teacher is seen as an authority figure, and the other where the teacher is seen as a servant, under the authority of Scripture. He indicates that it would not be appropriate for a woman to be in the first role, but that a woman would be able to be in the second role without violating the principle of remaining in submission to men. Whereas I like Stott’s distinction between what is cultural and what is timeless, I think it would be hard for a woman to fill a pastoral role where she is the principle teacher without her also exercising authority over men. Even though she remains under the authority of Scripture and relates to the congregation as servant, she would need to speak with the authority of Scripture to declare what the word of God says. How would she be able to do the things which Paul tells Timothy to do, such as “command certain men not to teach false doctrines” (1:3), “command and teach these things” (4:11), publicly rebuke those who have sinned (5:20) and “command those who are rich in this present world not to be arrogant” (6:17), without exercising authority over them? Stott admits that such a woman should be “a member of a pastoral team whose leader is a man.” But this essentially undercuts what he says, because then the man would be the principle authoritative teacher, not the woman.

This expression is similar to 2:11, where Paul said that women should learn in “full submissiveness.” Paul meant that women should not have authority over men in the Christian community. They were to submit to the authority of the male teachers, not try to rule over them.

over a man: Paul was still talking about men and women in general, not husbands and wives. He had been talking about women and men in general since 2:8a.

2:12b she is to remain quiet.

- Instead, she should be quiet when someone is teaching.
- Instead, women should listen quietly.

she: This refers to every woman, not a specific woman. If you used a plural in 2:11 and in 2:12a, you should do the same here.

is to remain quiet: The Greek word that the BSB translates as remain quiet here is the same word as was translated “quietness” in 2:11. Paul did not mean that women should never speak (see the note on 2:11). He meant that they should not speak while someone else was teaching.

1 Timothy 2:13

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:9–15

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy how female believers should dress and behave when they met to worship God. Paul had instructed the men in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for them (2:8). In this paragraph he instructed the women in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for the women.

2:13–14

In these verses Paul gave two reasons why he did not allow women to teach or exercise authority over men. These reasons are based on what the book of Genesis records about the first man and woman, Adam and Eve.

1. The first reason is that God created Adam before Eve (see 2:13a).
2. The second reason is that Satan, the devil, deceived Eve, not Adam (see 2:14b).

2:13a

For Adam was formed first,

- The reason I say this is that God created Adam, the man, first.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason for the previous statement. Here Paul introduced the two reasons why he did not allow women to teach or have authority over men.

Adam: The book of Genesis says that Adam was the name of the first man. God had created Adam from the dust of the ground. In some languages, it may be necessary to say explicitly that Adam was the first man.

was formed: Paul was referring to the time when God made Adam out of earth. See Genesis 2:7.

first: In this context, first means “before Eve.” See 2:13b.

2:13b

and then Eve.

- Then he made Eve, the woman.

Eve: The book of Genesis calls the first woman Eve. God made Eve from one of Adam’s ribs. See Genesis 2:21–22.

General Comment on 2:13a–b

You should not try to include all the information about Adam and Eve in your translation, nor use long explanations. However in some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit some details. One way to do this is:

The reason why women should not teach men or rule them is that when God created human beings, he made Adam, the man, before he made Eve, the woman.

1 Timothy 2:14

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:9–15

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2:14a

And it was not Adam who was deceived,

- Another reason is that Adam was not the one whom Satan deceived.

And: Here Paul gave the second reason that women should not teach or rule men. He implied that it was often easier for the devil to deceive women than it was for him to deceive men. The view that women tend to be more easily deceived than men has historically been the more popular view. Modern western ideas make this interpretation unpopular, but I have not seen any other convincing interpretation of what Paul says here. For example, some people understand verse 14 to imply that Eve’s problem was not that she was deceived, but that she ate the fruit without

consulting Adam, and then, by offering the fruit for Adam to eat, was taking an improper role by, in a sense, “teaching” him. Stott, page 81, promotes this view and says, “the essence of Eve’s part in the fall was not that she was deceived, but that she took an improper initiative, usurped Adam’s authority and thus reversed their respective roles.” However, the focus in verse 14 is on deception, not teaching. Eve stands not as a type of Ephesian women who were teaching false doctrine, but as a type of Ephesian women who were being deceived by false doctrine. If it were Paul’s point in verse 14 that Eve should not have been teaching Adam, it is strange that he should leave teaching unmentioned and refer only to her deception! Kroeger and Kroeger’s interpretation that these statements are actually combating proto-Gnostic teachings is attractive, but speculative. They say that Paul was combating the proto-Gnostic teaching which said that Adam had been tricked into thinking that he was created before Eve, that the God who had made the material universe was the highest God of all, and that he should worship this God. For more details and interaction with other views see Schreiner in *Women in the Church*, pages 140–146. Keener, in *Dictionary of Paul and His Letters*, page 591, says that Paul’s argument from Eve’s deception is likely to be ad hoc: “It is far more likely that Paul instead uses Eve to illustrate the plight of the particular women he addresses in Ephesus, who are easily deceived because they are untrained. Paul elsewhere uses Eve for anyone who is deceived, not just women (2 Cor 11:3).” However, the point remains that Paul is specifically referring to women here. Furthermore, Paul sets the context by referring to all women, not just untaught women, in 2:11 and 2:12a. See the notes on 2:11. He said that the behavior of Eve and Adam was proof of this. If a woman is deceived, she may not teach what is true.

This does not mean that woman should never teach. In Titus 2:3–5 Paul wrote that women could teach other women. In 2 Timothy 1:5 and 3:14–15 he wrote that women should teach their children. However here Paul was saying that women should not teach men.

it was not Adam who was deceived: Paul was referring to Genesis 3:1–13. These verses explain that Satan appeared to Eve as a snake. He tempted her to eat the only fruit that God had forbidden Adam and her to eat. The snake did not speak to Adam or deceive him. Adam chose to eat the fruit when Eve offered it to him.

2:14b

but the woman who was deceived

- It was the woman Eve whom Satan deceived.

but the woman who was deceived: The snake tricked or deceived Eve by causing her to disbelieve what God had said about the fruit.

Paul’s point here was that Satan was able to deceive Eve more easily than he could deceive Adam.

2:14c

and fell into transgression.

- The result was that she became a sinner.

fell into transgression: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as fell into transgression means “deliberately broke God’s law.” Eve did not obey God’s command. Kroeger and Kroeger say that this combats Gnostic teaching which said that Eve actually did a good thing when she ate of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. They presume that people taught this in the time when Paul and Timothy lived. She became a person who had disobeyed God.

General Comment on 2:11–14

Paul’s conclusion is in 2:12 and his reasons are in 2:13–14. However, in some languages, it is more natural to state reasons before the conclusion. If this is true in your language, you may need to combine and reorder the verses. One way to do this is:

¹¹ When men teach about God, women should learn by listening quietly and respectfully. ^{12–14} For God made Adam before he made Eve. Also, Adam was not the one whom Satan deceived. Satan deceived Eve and she disobeyed God. Therefore, I do not allow women to teach or have authority over men.

General Comment on 2:14a–c

In some languages, it may be necessary to conclude 2:14 with a sentence to summarize what Paul was saying. For example, you could say:

Those are the reasons why women should not teach or have authority over men.

1 Timothy 2:15

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Timothy that it was important that believers should pray

In this section Paul told Timothy some things that the believers should do when they met together regularly to worship God. They should pray for everybody. The men should pray in holiness and without anger, and the women should dress and behave modestly and appropriately.

Paragraph 2:9–15

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy how female believers should dress and behave when they met to worship God. Paul had instructed the men in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for them (2:8). In this paragraph he instructed the women in Ephesus about a problem that was typical for the women.

2:15a

Women, however, will be saved through childbearing,

- But women will be saved through giving birth to children,
- But God will save women through giving birth to children,

Women, however, will be saved through childbearing: This is a very difficult expression to understand. Scholars understand it in two main ways:

1. It means that God will save women spiritually (from sin) while they are bearing (and raising) children. Moo, in *Recovering Biblical Manhood & Womanhood*, page 192, says, “We think it is preferable to view verse 15 as designating the circumstances in which Christian women will experience (work out; cf. Philippians 2:12) their salvation—in maintaining as priorities those key roles that Paul, in keeping with Scripture elsewhere, highlights: being faithful, helpful wives, raising children to love and reverence God, managing the household (cf. 1 Tim 5:14; Titus 2:3–5).... Probably Paul makes this point because the false teachers were claiming that women could really experience what God had for them only if they abandoned the home and became actively involved in teaching and leadership roles in the church. If this interpretation is correct, then verse 15 fits perfectly with the emphasis we have seen in this text throughout. Against the attempt of the false teachers to get the women in Ephesus to adopt ‘libertarian,’ unbiblical attitudes and behavior, Paul reaffirms the Biblical model of the Christian woman...” For example, the REB says:

salvation for the woman will be in the bearing of children (REB, GNT, RSV, NJB, CEV, NCV)

1. It means that women will be kept safe physically during childbirth. For example, the NASB says:

women will be preserved through the bearing of children (NASB, NET, KJV)

Other versions are ambiguous. Neither interpretation is completely satisfactory. If it is possible for you to translate this expression in a neutral way, you should do so. However, we know that interpretation (2) is not true because Christian women do suffer pain, or even die, when they bear children. So, if you must choose an interpretation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

however: The Greek particle *de*, which the BSB translates as *however* shows contrast. Although Eve “became a sinner,” God is able to save women from the consequences of Eve’s sin and of their own sin.

childbearing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *childbearing* literally refers to “giving birth to children.” Some modern commentators say that the text here probably represents all aspects of a woman’s normal role in Paul’s day, including raising children and all the things that women normally do to manage a household. However, the UBS Translator’s Guide objects to this, saying “this broader interpretation of the Greek noun, though more acceptable to modern thinking, does not seem warranted; the related verb in 5:14 means quite specifically ‘to bear children,’ not ‘to rear children.’” However, it is possible that Paul used the verb figuratively as metonymy for raising children.

2:15b–c

Here Paul described the way the women in 2:15a should act.

2:15b

if they continue in faith, love,

- as long as they continue to believe in Christ, love other people,

if they continue in: God wants people to act as believers continually: he wants them to show “faith”, “love”, and “holiness.” He does not want them to behave this way only occasionally. We note that this verb, *continue*, is plural in the Greek, whereas the verb *will be saved* is singular. However, the verb *will be saved* in 2:15a refers to women generically. So, when Paul switches to the plural here, he is not making a significant change. Paul did a similar thing when he referred to men in 2:8a in the plural, then switched in 2:12a to the singular, making a generic reference. They need to persevere. Paul said a similar thing in Romans 11:22 and Colossians 1:23.

they: This refers to the women mentioned in 2:15a.

faith: In some languages it may be necessary to translate *faith* as a verb. It may then be necessary to provide an object for the verb. If this is true in your language, you could say:

believe in Christ

See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

love: In this verse, Paul did not say whom the women should love. There are three possibilities:

1. He meant that the women should love other people
2. He meant that the women should love God
3. He meant that the women should love both God and other people

It is difficult to know which of these interpretations is best, and most English translations are ambiguous. If it is possible for you to translate this in the same ambiguous way, you should do so. However, if you must supply an object, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

2:15c
and holiness, with self-control.

- and behave in a pure and appropriate way.

holiness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as holiness means to behave in a way that pleases God. It is the way he wants believers to behave. See holiness in the Glossary.

self-control: The Greek word that the BSB translates as self-control means to act in a way that people consider correct, acceptable, or appropriate. Paul used the same word in 2:9b to describe the way in which women should dress.

1 Timothy 3:1

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:1–7

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy the qualities that a person needed to have in order to become an “overseer.” An overseer was someone who led and taught a group of believers.

3:1a

This is a trustworthy saying:

- ¶ This saying is reliable:
- ¶ This saying is something you can be sure is true,
- ¶ Believers know the following words, which can be trusted:

This is a trustworthy saying: This is an expression that Paul used often in his letters to Timothy and Titus. See 1 Timothy 1:15, 4:9; 2 Timothy 2:11; Titus 1:9, 3:8. You should try to use the same expression of introduction in all these places. Paul used this expression to introduce a saying that was well-known among believers at that time.

trustworthy: Paul said that what he was about to say was trustworthy. That means that it was true and reliable. Other ways to say this could be: “This saying really is true,” or “people should believe this.”

saying: A saying is an expression that is well known to people. In some languages it may be possible to use a word like “proverb.”

3:1b

If anyone aspires to be an overseer,

- If someone longs to become an overseer,
- Any person who really wants to be an overseer of other believers

If anyone aspires to be an overseer: This was a saying that was often repeated among the believers at that time. Timothy probably knew it well.

If: This saying begins with If, which often means that the speaker is not sure whether something will really happen or not. However, in Greek and English, it can also be used when the speaker knows that the event happens sometimes. Here Paul was not wondering whether someone was going to wish to become an overseer or not. He was telling Timothy what to do when it happened. In some languages it may be better to say something like:

The person who sets his heart on being an overseer [desires a noble task].

anyone: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as anyone here can include men and women. But it is clear from the list of requirements to be an overseer (3:2–7) that only men were overseers. So it is acceptable to translate this as “any man.”

aspires to: This Greek verb that the BSB translates as aspires to literally means “stretches toward.” It means that a person strongly desires something.

be an overseer: The Greek word *episkopē* that the BSB translates as *be an overseer* refers to the position of being an overseer.

overseer: In the New Testament, the Greek word *episkopos* was one of the names used for the leader of a group of believers. Another name that the New Testament used for this kind of leader is the Greek word translated as “elder.” Paul used the word translated “elder” in 4:14c, 5:17a, and 5:19a. If you can use two different words, it is recommended that you do so. However, in some languages, using two terms may cause readers to think Paul was talking about two different groups of people. If this is so in your area, use the same term for both Greek words.

English versions sometimes translate overseer by the word “bishop,” but this may be confused with the role of a bishop in the modern church. You should consider carefully what is the most appropriate term in your language. If there is already a church in your area, it may be best to choose the term already used for a church leader who teaches.

In the rest of this paragraph, Paul explained some of the responsibilities of an overseer. For example:

1. he was responsible for teaching the believers (3:2)
2. he was responsible for caring for them (3:5)
3. he was responsible for leading them (3:5)

3:1c

he desires a noble task.

- what he wants to do is very good.
- desires to do something that is excellent.

he desires: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *desires* is a different word than the one translated as “aspires to” earlier in the verse. However they both mean that the person wants something strongly. In some languages it may not be possible to say that someone desires a job or a “task.” In such languages, it may be necessary to say “he desires to do [a noble task].”

a noble task: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *noble* literally means “good,” “fine.” Paul meant that it was a worthwhile thing to lead and teach believers.

task: That is, “job,” “work,” “activity.”

General Comment on 3:1a–c

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder this verse so that Paul’s comment about the truthfulness of the saying comes after the saying itself. For example:

There is a saying among believers: “If anyone longs to become an overseer, he desires to do something noble.” This saying can be trusted.

1 Timothy 3:2

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:1–7

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy the qualities that a person needed to have in order to become an “overseer.” An overseer was someone who led and taught a group of believers.

3:2a

An overseer, then, must be above reproach,

- That is why each overseer must be someone whom others cannot fault.
- Therefore, an overseer must behave so well that no one can truthfully accuse him of doing wrong.

An overseer: Even though Paul used the singular form *overseer* here, he was not saying that there was always only one overseer per church. He was describing the qualities that each overseer needed to have. In some languages it may be better to use plural forms here and in the rest of the list. For example, it may be better to say “overseers must be above reproach” rather than to say “the overseer must be above reproach.”

then: The Greek word *oun* that the BSB translates as *then* normally means “therefore.” It is not a time word. Paul used this word to begin the list of the character qualities a person should have if he wanted to become an overseer. Since it was noble to want to be an overseer, such people needed to fulfill certain qualifications. Another way to translate this connection could be “because of that,”

must be above reproach: Paul said that overseers should behave well so that no one would be able to accuse them of doing something wrong. They should be people whom other people respected as men who

behaved in a godly way. This word is also used in 5:7b and 6:14b.

3:2b the husband of but one wife,

- He must be a faithful husband,
- He must be a man who does not have sex with anyone other than with his wife.

the husband of but one wife: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the husband of but one wife literally says “a one-wife husband” or “a one-woman man.” Scholars interpret this in two main ways: There is a third interpretation followed by the NRSV, that is, an overseer must only be married once.

1. An overseer must not be married to more than one woman at the same time; that is, he must not be polygamous. For example, the GNT says:

he must have only one wife (BSB, GNT, NIV, RSV, GW, NCV, KJV, NASB, REB, NET)

1. An overseer must not have sex with anyone other than his wife; that is, he must not commit adultery. Many commentaries follow this interpretation. For example, the NLT says:

faithful to his wife (NLT, CEV)

Either of these interpretations is possible. If an elder was not faithful to his wife, people would criticize him or criticize the church. So Paul wanted each church leader to be faithful to his wife. However, interpretation (2) is followed by several English versions. You may wish to follow the same interpretation as the version most in use in your area. It is recommended that whichever interpretation you choose, you mention the other in a footnote.

It is also important to notice that the same Greek expression is used in Titus 1:6. Make sure that you translate both passages the same way.

3:2c temperate, self-controlled,

- restrained, self-disciplined,
- He must be able to control how he behaves in all situations.

temperate: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temperate means “behaving in a sober, restrained manner.” Louw and Nida (88.87) on *nēphalios* It often refers to not drinking too much alcohol. But most commentators agree that the meaning is more general here. It includes not getting drunk, but it also refers

to not losing control of oneself in any other way. The same word is used in 3:11c and Titus 2:2.

self-controlled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as self-controlled means “being sensible and moderate in one’s behavior.” Louw and Nida (88.94) on *sōphrōn* It describes a person who thinks and acts wisely. Because the overseer is in control of himself, he is able to act calmly and appropriately in every situation. This word is also used to describe an overseer in Titus 1:8. It also occurs in Titus 2:2, 2:5–6, 2:12.

These two words translated temperate and self-controlled mean almost the same thing. They both refer to a person who can control the way in which he reacts to things or situations. Both words also occur together in Titus 2:2. Paul probably used both words together to emphasize that an overseer should be in control of himself in every area of his life. So, if you do not have two words to use in your translation, you could combine them and say:

he should be self-controlled in everything he does

3:2d respectable, hospitable, able to teach,

- respected, kind to strangers, a good teacher,
- He must be a person whom people respect. He must be ready to welcome guests into his home. He must be able to teach God’s message well.

respectable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as respectable means “orderly,” “well-behaved,” or “virtuous.” It means that other people value and admire a person who is respectable.

hospitable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hospitable literally means “loving strangers.” An overseer must be a person who welcomes guests into his home. He may also give guests food or a place to stay for the night. This word is also used in Titus 1:8.

able to teach: An overseer must be a person who is able to teach believers what Scripture means. The Greek word that the BSB translates as able to teach is also used in 2 Timothy 2:24.

1 Timothy 3:3

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:1–7

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy the qualities that a person needed to have in order to become an “overseer.” An overseer was someone who led and taught a group of believers.

3:3a

not dependent on wine,

- not someone who habitually gets drunk,
- He must not be a drunkard.

dependent on wine: Someone who is dependent on wine is someone who makes a habit of drinking too much wine or other alcoholic drinks so that he becomes drunk. Your language might express this with a single word, like the English word “drunkard,” or you may use an expression such as “someone who is always getting drunk,” or “habitual drinker.” See also Titus 1:7 where the same Greek word is used.

3:3b

not violent but gentle,

- not fighting a lot, but remaining calm,
- He must not like to fight. Instead he should be gentle.

Some Greek manuscripts include words that can be translated “not greedy of filthy lucre” (that is, “not greedy for money”). The KJV follows that text. However, most scholars agree that this phrase was not present in Paul’s original letter to Timothy. So you should omit the words as the BSB has done. Metzger, pages 640 and 641, indicates that the words “not greedy of filthy lucre” are a gloss derived from Titus 1:7 and were probably not present in the original. The Editorial Committee of the UBS New Testament (4th edition) does not list this reading in its critical apparatus.

not violent: The Greek word *plēktēn* that the BSB translates as violent means “striker, brawler.” This means a person who often fights with other people or who is rough with others in language or actions. It refers mainly to fighting physically, but it can include yelling and arguing too. An overseer must not lead the believers by forcing them to do things in this way. The same word is used in Titus 1:7.

but gentle: The Greek word *epieikēs* that the BSB translates as gentle is the opposite of “violent.” If a person is gentle, he is kind, patient, calm, and respectful. He also considers other people before he does something. The same Greek word is used in Titus 3:2.

3:3c

peaceable,

- not argumentative,
- He must not habitually argue with other people.

peaceable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as peaceable literally means “not-fighting.” It refers to someone who avoids arguing or disagreeing with other people. The word is also used in Titus 3:2.

There are two ways you can translate this:

- In a positive way, as the GNT has done, that is:

peaceful (BSB, GNT, NJB, NCV, NLT, NASB, CEV)

- In a negative way, as the NIV has done; that is:

does not quarrel with other people (NIV, RSV, KJV, NET, GW)

You should choose whichever style works best in your language.

3:3d

and free of the love of money.

- and not greedy for money.
- He must not be a man who is eager to have a lot of money.

free of the love of money: An overseer should not be someone who is interested in getting as much money as possible. The word that the BSB translates as love of money is also used in Hebrews 13:5; Luke 16:14; and 2 Timothy 3:2.

1 Timothy 3:4

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:1–7

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy the qualities that a person needed to have in order to become an “overseer.” An overseer was someone who led and taught a group of believers.

3:4a

An overseer must manage his own household well

- He must lead his own family well,
- He must be in control of his own family,

manage his own household well: The Greek word that the BSB translates as manage means to influence the way people behave. Louw and Nida (36.1) say that the word in the Greek (proistēmi) means “to so influence others as to cause them to follow a recommended course of action,” and it implies “a minimum of control on the part of the one guiding or leading.” An overseer should train his family to behave in ways that please God. In some languages, it is possible to use a word meaning “guide” or “lead.” In other languages it may be possible to say “be in control of his family.”

3:4b

and keep his children under control, with complete dignity.

- and he must teach his children to respectfully obey him in everything.

keep his children under control, with complete dignity: This is part of managing a family well. An overseer was to train his children and make sure they obeyed him respectfully.

with complete dignity: The Greek word *semnotēs* that the BSB translates as dignity means “esteem,” “reverence,” “honor.”

In this context, Paul was saying that the children were to obey their father to show that they respected him. That is, they were to esteem him and honor him by the way they behaved. See the NIV, RSV, GNT, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, and NCV.

complete: The Greek word that the BSB translates as complete is literally “all.” Paul used this word to say that an overseer’s children should respectfully obey him in every way.

1 Timothy 3:5

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:1–7

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy the qualities that a person needed to have in order to become an “overseer.” An overseer was someone who led and taught a group of believers.

3:5a

For if someone does not know how to manage his own household,

- If someone cannot lead his own family well,
- A person who cannot control his own family well

For if someone does not know how to manage his own household: This repeats the expression from 3:4a and you should translate it in the same way.

3:5b

how can he care for the church of God?

- how can he look after the community of God’s people?
- will certainly not be able to care for God’s people.

care for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as care for has, in this context, a similar meaning to the word translated “manage” in 3:4a and 3:5a. Try to find a term that refers to caring for a group of people.

the church of God: That is, the church that belongs to God.

church: The Greek word that the BSB translates as church does not refer to a church building, but to all true believers. Together they form the assembly or community of God’s people. Avoid using a term that might suggest that Paul was referring to a building. Some ways of translating the term church are:

the assembly of God’s people

the community of God’s people

God's family

God's people

See also the notes on 3:15c and 5:16c.

General Comment on 3:5a–b

This verse is a rhetorical question. In this context, Paul used the rhetorical question to emphasize that a man who was unable to manage his own family would certainly be unable to care for God's people. If you do not use rhetorical questions in this way in your language, you should use a statement instead. For example, you could say:

Someone who is not able to manage his own family will certainly not be able to care for God's church.

Some English versions use parentheses round this verse to indicate that this verse digresses from the main point of the paragraph. You should show that this is a digression in the way that is most natural in your language.

1 Timothy 3:6

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:1–7

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy the qualities that a person needed to have in order to become an “overseer.” An overseer was someone who led and taught a group of believers.

3:6a

He must not be a recent convert,

- He must not be someone who has only recently become a believer.

recent convert: The Greek word that the BSB translates as recent convert refers to a person who has only been a believer for a short time.

3:6b

or he may become conceited

- Otherwise, he may become proud,

or he may become conceited: Paul said that if a recent convert is chosen as an overseer there is a danger that he may become conceited.

conceited: The word that the BSB translates as conceited refers to people who think and behave as though they are superior to other people. They are very proud. In many languages, there is an idiomatic way to say this. The GNT uses an English figure of speech and says “swollen with pride.” See the note on 6:4a. This Greek word also occurs in 2 Timothy 3:4.

3:6c

and fall under the same condemnation as the devil.

- and incur the same punishment that the devil has.
- then God will punish him in the same way that he punished the devil for being proud.

fall under the same condemnation as the devil: This can also be translated:

incur the same judgment as the devil

earn the same judgment as the devil

the same condemnation as the devil: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the same condemnation as the devil probably refers to the judgment. See TDNT III, page 942: “Materially, κρίμα [=‘judgment’] has in these expressions the sense of punishment, though it is strictly the verdict or sentence which brings on the punishment.” See also BAG, sense 4b: “mostly in an unfavorable sense, of the sentence of condemnation, also of the condemnation and the subsequent punishment itself...” that the devil receives. This means that God will punish a person who has become conceited in the same way that he punished the devil for his pride. See the NIV, NJB, GNT, NASB, and CEV.

Paul did not make explicit here the way that God punished the devil. So it would be best if you also did not make this explicit.

the devil: The devil is the chief of all evil spirits. The name of the devil is Satan. He is also referred to in some parts of the New Testament as “The Evil One.” See devil in the Glossary.

1 Timothy 3:7

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:1–7

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy the qualities that a person needed to have in order to become an “overseer.” An overseer was someone who led and taught a group of believers.

3:7a

Furthermore, he must have a good reputation with outsiders,

- He should behave so that even those who are unbelievers will recognize that he is a good man
- People outside the Christian community must think well of him

Furthermore, he must have a good reputation with outsiders: Paul meant that even those who are not believers must think well of a person who becomes an overseer.

outsiders: When Paul referred to outsiders, he was referring to those who were not believers.

3:7b

so that he will not fall into disgrace

- so that he will be less likely to be disgraced
- so that people will not discredit him.

so that he will not fall into disgrace: This gives the reason that an overseer must have a good reputation. If he does not, he will fall into disgrace. This means that those who are not believers will have good reasons to criticize and accuse him. Because he is a leader among the believers, they may also say the same things about other believers.

3:7c

and into the snare of the devil.

- or be trapped by the devil.
- It will be as if the devil trapped him like a person catches an animal so that it cannot escape.

and into the snare of the devil: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as “fall” in 3:7b is implicit in this part of the verse. However, in some languages it may be better to say:

and be trapped by the devil

When Paul talked about falling into a snare, he was using a metaphor. He was saying that an overseer who has a bad reputation is like an animal that has been caught in a trap. He cannot easily escape and so can no longer do the work that God has given him to do.

the snare of the devil: Paul was referring to the snare that the devil sets for people when he tempts them. Just as people set traps to catch animals, the devil sets traps to tempt people to become proud or sin in other ways.

1 Timothy 3:8

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:8–13

In 3:1–7 Paul told Timothy the sort of people who ought to be overseers. In the following verses, Paul described the sort of people who should be deacons. Many of these qualifications are similar to those for overseers.

3:8a

Deacons likewise must be dignified, not double-tongued

- ¶ Like the overseers, deacons also must be men who deserve respect and they must be honest.

Deacons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Deacons normally means “servants.” But in this verse it refers to believers who had a special job within the community of believers. Deacons basically took care of special needs of believers. For example, one of their tasks was to care for the widows.

Most English versions translate the word as “deacons,” but the GNT says “church helpers.” You should

choose a term that is suitable in your culture for such a leadership job.

likewise: Paul had given a list of qualifications for overseers in 3:1–7. He was now going to list the qualifications for deacons (3:8–13). In some languages it may be enough to use the word “also.”

dignified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as dignified is a general word. It means that a deacon must behave in a way that deserves respect from other people. That is, other people will esteem and honor him because he has earned that respect by the way he behaves.

not double-tongued: The Greek term that the BSB literally translates as not double-tongued means “sincere.” Another way to express this is:

not saying things they do not mean (NCV)

3:8b or given to much wine

- They must not habitually drink too much wine and become drunk.

or given to much wine: Just as an overseer should not be “dependent on wine” (3:3a), Paul said that deacons should not be “given to much wine.” This means the same thing—any leader among believers must not get drunk.

wine: The word wine refers to a drink made from grapes. It is fermented and therefore alcoholic. During the time when Paul wrote this letter, people normally drank wine with their meals. Paul said that deacons should not drink too much wine and therefore become drunk.

3:8c or greedy for money.

- They must not be so eager to get money that they cheat others.

greedy for money: In 3:3d, Paul said that overseers should be “free of the love of money.” Here Paul makes a similar statement about deacons. The Greek word *aischrokerdē* that the BSB translates as greedy for money literally means “shamefully greedy.” Scholars interpret this in two ways:

1. It refers to people who do wrong things in order to get money. (NIV, CEV, NCV, GW) This is also the view of many commentaries.
2. It refers to people who are greedy for money and possessions, whether or not the person does any-

thing wrong to get them. (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NLT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek word that Paul used here contains a part that means “shameful, disgraceful.” So it probably refers to someone who is willing to lie, cheat or take bribes in order to get the money he wants. This kind of person might use his position of authority in the church as a way to get money from other people. One possible way to translate this is:

He must not be a person who will do anything to get money.

The same term is used in Titus 1:7 and 1:11.

1 Timothy 3:9

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:8–13

In 3:1–7 Paul told Timothy the sort of people who ought to be overseers. In the following verses, Paul described the sort of people who should be deacons. Many of these qualifications are similar to those for overseers.

3:9

They must hold to the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience.

- They must keep on believing God’s true message, which he has revealed, and their conscience must tell them that they have not sinned.
- They must be committed to following the true teaching that God has shown to us^(incl). And they must have done nothing that makes them feel guilty.

They must hold to the mystery of the faith: This means that deacons must consistently believe in the true message of faith that God has revealed to people.

the mystery of the faith: In English, as in other languages, the word “mystery” normally refers to some-

thing that no one can know or understand. However, when Paul used the word “mystery” together with the faith, he was referring to the true message about the faith. This is the message about the Christian faith that God revealed to people, or caused them to understand. For example, the GNT says:

the revealed truth of the faith

See also the NLT. Paul also used this expression in Ephesians 3:1-13.

the faith: In this context, Paul used the word faith to refer to everything that people believe and do in order to follow Christ. See faith, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

a clear conscience: A person who has a clear conscience does not feel guilty because he knows that he has done the right thing.

conscience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conscience refers to the part of a person that helps him know what is right and what is wrong to think or do. A conscience causes a person to feel ashamed or guilty if he does wrong. It also makes him feel good when he does what is right.

However, in many languages, there is not a word that means conscience. In some languages, there may be an idiom that can be used. In other languages, it may be necessary to translate the expression “good conscience” by an expression like:

doing what he knows is right

See the note on 1:5c.

1 Timothy 3:10

Section 3:1-16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1-7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8-13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14-16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:8-13

In 3:1-7 Paul told Timothy the sort of people who ought to be overseers. In the following verses, Paul described

the sort of people who should be deacons. Many of these qualifications are similar to those for overseers.

3:10a

Additionally, they must first be tested.

- Before people become deacons, they must be evaluated.
- When deacons are chosen, first let them prove that they have the right qualities.

Additionally, they must first be tested: Paul told Timothy that someone who might become a deacon should be tested to discover if he had the right qualities. Only if he had these qualities should he be appointed as a deacon.

Paul did not say who should test a deacon. So it is recommended that you do not explain that either. Perhaps you could say:

Let them prove themselves.

But, if in your language you need to specify who tested the deacons, it is recommended that you use a general term. For example, you could say:

The believers must test them

Paul also did not explain the way that deacons should be tested. There are many possibilities, but it is recommended that you avoid specifying any method of testing in your translation.

first: In this context, this means before starting to serve as a deacon.

3:10b

Then, if they are above reproach,

- Then, if they cannot be accused of doing wrong,
- Then if no one can find fault with them,

if they are above reproach: The Greek word that the BSB translates as above reproach means that the men being tested cannot be truthfully be accused of doing wrong. It has a similar meaning to the word that the BSB also translates as “above reproach” in 3:2a.

3:10c

let them serve as deacons.

- let them become deacons and serve the believers.
- they can be chosen to work as deacons.

let them serve as deacons: That is, once these men have passed the test, they can be appointed as deacons.

deacons: See the note on 3:8a.

1 Timothy 3:11

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:8–13

In 3:1–7 Paul told Timothy the sort of people who ought to be overseers. In the following verses, Paul described the sort of people who should be deacons. Many of these qualifications are similar to those for overseers.

3:11a

In the same way, the women must be dignified,

- Like the deacons themselves, their wives must behave so that other people respect them.

In the same way: This verse begins with a Greek word that the BSB translates as *In the same way*. Paul also used this word in 3:8a where he began to list the requirements for deacons. In that verse the BSB translates it as “likewise.”

the women: There is a major interpretation question in this verse. The Greek word that the BSB translates as *the women* means “women” in some contexts and “wives” in other contexts. There is no special word that only means “wife.” Therefore, there are two possible ways to interpret this word and therefore this verse:

1. It means wives and therefore refers to the wives of the deacons. (NIV, GNT, KJV, NET, GW, NLT)
2. It means “women” and therefore refers to female deacons (deaconesses). (BSB, REB)

Many English versions are ambiguous but most of those that do choose an interpretation follow interpretation (1). Therefore it is recommended that you also translate this word as wives. Here are some reasons why Paul was probably referring to wives of deacons:

1. Paul talked about male deacons in 3:8–10, then he continued talking about male deacons in 3:12–13. Paul probably did not interrupt himself here to talk about female deacons. It is more likely that he was talking about the wives of the deacons.

2. Paul followed 3:11 by saying that a deacon (like an overseer) needed to be a “husband of one wife” (3:12a). If he had been referring to female deacons in 3:11a, he would probably have said that female deacons should be faithful to their husbands.

However, it is impossible to be absolutely certain which interpretation is correct. Fee, page 88, says, “This sentence is one of the genuine puzzles in 1 Timothy.” If possible, you should explain both possibilities in a footnote.

dignified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *dignified* is a general word. It means that these women must behave in a way that deserves respect from other people. That is, other people will esteem and honor them because they had earned that respect by the way they behave.

This is the same word that Paul used in 3:8a. You should use the same term here.

3:11b

not slanderers,

- They must not say bad things about other people.

slanderers: When Paul said that deacons’ wives must not be slanderers, he meant that they must not gossip or say hurtful things about other people. It does not matter whether or not the things are true. If they are meant to be hurtful, the women should not say them. Paul used the same word in Titus 2:3. You should try to use the same term in both verses.

3:11c

but temperate and faithful in all things.

- Instead they must be self-controlled. They must be people whom other people trust in all situations.

temperate: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *temperate* means “behaving in a sober, restrained manner.” It often refers to not drinking too much alcohol. But most commentators agree that the meaning is more general here. It includes not getting drunk, but also includes not losing control of themselves in any other way. The same word is used in 3:2c and Titus 2:2.

faithful: If a person is faithful, people can trust him to fulfill his responsibilities and to do what he promises. He is trustworthy, dependable, and reliable. Two ways to translate this are:

a person whom others trust

a person who always does what he says he will do

in all things: Most scholars and English versions agree that in all things is grammatically attached to the word faithful. So the BSB expression faithful in all things could be translated “completely faithful.”

1 Timothy 3:12

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:8–13

In 3:1–7 Paul told Timothy the sort of people who ought to be overseers. In the following verses, Paul described the sort of people who should be deacons. Many of these qualifications are similar to those for overseers.

3:12a

A deacon must be the husband of but one wife,

- A deacon must be a faithful husband.
- A deacon must be a man who does not have sex with anyone other than with his wife.

deacon: See the note on 3:8a.

the husband of but one wife: This is the same phrase that Paul used in 3:2b about overseers. You should follow the same interpretation here as you chose there and place the other one in a footnote.

3:12b

a good manager of his children and of his own household.

- He must take care of his children well, along with all the other members of his family and the servants in his household.
- He must be in control of his children and everyone else who lives in his house.

a good manager: Paul used the same Greek word here as he did in 3:4a. You should translate it in the same way here.

his own household: The Greek word that the BSB translates as household referred to two groups that normally lived together in the same house or compound. First, there was the family, a group of people

related by blood or marriage. Second, there may have been slaves and servants who belonged to or worked for that family. Louw and Nida (10.8) on oikos You should choose a term or expression that includes both groups.

1 Timothy 3:13

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:8–13

In 3:1–7 Paul told Timothy the sort of people who ought to be overseers. In the following verses, Paul described the sort of people who should be deacons. Many of these qualifications are similar to those for overseers.

3:13a

For those who have served well as deacons acquire for themselves a high standing

- Deacons who work well will be highly respected.
- People will highly respect those who serve other believers well as deacons.

For those who have served well as deacons: Paul was referring to deacons who help other people in an excellent way.

a high standing: People will honor deacons who fulfill their responsibilities well. For example, the NLT says:

Those who do well as deacons will be rewarded with respect

3:13b

and great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus.

- As a result, these deacons will be able to tell people confidently what they believe about Christ Jesus.

great confidence: The Greek word that the BSB translates as confidence refers to being confident, bold, without fear.

in the faith: This is a very general expression that states the way in which deacons who have served well can be confident. However scholars interpret this in different ways. The main interpretations are:

1. The deacons are not afraid to tell other people about their faith in Christ. For example, the GNT says:

Those helpers who do their work well...are able to speak boldly about their faith in Christ Jesus. (GNT)

1. The deacons have boldness in their relationship with God, and they trust God more and more. For example, the NLT says:

Those who do well as deacons...will have increased confidence in their faith in Christ Jesus. (NLT, NIV, GW, NCV)

Many English versions are not clear as to which interpretation they follow. If it is not possible for you to translate this in a general way, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Some people, however, think that when Paul used the word Christ before the word Jesus, as in Christ Jesus, he was emphasizing that Jesus was the Messiah.

In most English versions “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

However, it is possible that, in some languages, people may be confused to see the names in two different orders. They may even think that Paul was referring to two different people. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ.” This is the more usual word order in the New Testament.

Christ: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

1 Timothy 3:14

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:14–16

Paul again stated the reason that he was writing this letter. Then he quoted a hymn about Christ.

3:14a

Although I hope to come to you soon,

- ¶! Although I really want to come to Ephesus to visit you soon,

Although I hope to come to you soon: When Paul said that he hoped to visit Timothy, he meant that he really wanted to go and visit Timothy.

come: Consider the way that your language uses verbs of motion. In some languages it may be better to use “go,” or “return” instead of “come.”

3:14b

I am writing you these things

- I am writing these orders for you for this reason:

these things: Here, these things refers to the instructions that Paul was giving to Timothy. In this context, these things refers to the entire letter that Paul wrote to Timothy.

1 Timothy 3:15

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:14–16

Paul again stated the reason that he was writing this letter. Then he quoted a hymn about Christ.

3:15a**in case I am delayed,**

- I may have to postpone my coming,

in case I am delayed: Paul knew that there was a possibility that he would not visit Timothy very soon. The Greek verb is active (“I delay”) rather than passive (I am delayed). So it should not be translated as meaning that he might be held back by force. Paul knew that he might himself decide to wait.

3:15b**so that you will know how each one must conduct himself in God’s household,**

- but I still want you to know how people should behave with other members of God’s family,

so that: The connector so that introduces the purpose for which Paul was writing to Timothy. Paul wanted Timothy to know the way to teach the believers even if Paul himself could not come to visit.

how each one must conduct himself: Paul was referring to the way that God wanted believers to behave. He was including himself, Timothy, and all other believers. Paul was especially referring to the way that believers should treat each other.

God’s household: This is a metaphor that refers to the community of believers. Believers are related to each other like brothers and sisters in a family. They are related to God like children are related to their father. Paul used the same Greek word for household here as he did in 3:12b.

3:15c**which is the church of the living God,**

- which is the community which belongs to God, who truly lives,

which is the church of the living God: Paul here used a different description of God’s household (3:15b). It refers to the people who belong to the living God.

church: The Greek word that the BSB translates as church does not refer to a church building, but to all true believers. Together they form the assembly or community of God’s people. Avoid using a term that might suggest that Paul was referring to a building. Some ways of translating the term church are:

the assembly of God’s people

the community of God’s people

God’s family

God’s people

See also the notes on 3:5b and 5:16c.

the living God: That is, God is alive and active. He is not like idols that never lived. The same phrase occurs in 4:10b. The other NT references are Matthew 16:16, 26:63; Acts 14:15; Romans 9:26; 2 Corinthians 3:3, 6:16; Hebrews 3:12, 9:14, 10:31, 12:22; Revelation 7:2.

3:15d**the pillar and foundation of the truth.**

- the pillar and foundation that supports the truth and makes it strong.
- The church supports God’s true message like a pillar supports a building and it strengthens the message like a foundation makes a building strong.

the pillar and foundation of the truth: This is a metaphor that explains that the church supported and strengthened the truth. The truth (of the gospel) was like a building, and the community of believers was like a pillar and foundation. Just as a pillar and a foundation support and strengthen a building, the community of believers supports and strengthens the truth.

pillar: A pillar is a tall post, usually made of stone, that supports the roof of a building. The same Greek word is used in Galatians 2:9 and Revelation 3:12, 10:1. The picture below shows the way that pillars support the roof of a building.

foundation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foundation does not occur anywhere else in the NT. So scholars do not agree about its precise meaning here. There are two possibilities:

1. It could mean foundation or ground, that is, something that is the base on which a building is erected. (BSB, NIV, GW, CEV, NCV, KJV)
2. It could mean support, bulwark, or prop, that is, something that helps to hold a building up or protects it. (GNT, RSV, NJB, NASB, NLT, REB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The church is like the foundation of a building. The foundation of a building causes the building to remain strong.

the truth: When Paul mentioned the truth, he was referring to the gospel. See the note on the truth in 2:4b.

1 Timothy 3:16

Section 3:1–16: Paul described the sort of people who should lead a community of believers

In this section, Paul described the qualifications for Christian leaders, those who lead a group of believers.

This section can be divided into three paragraphs:

Paragraph 3:1–7: The sort of people who should be overseers

Paragraph 3:8–13: The sort of people who should be deacons

Paragraph 3:14–16: The reason Paul wrote this letter to Timothy

Paragraph 3:14–16

Paul again stated the reason that he was writing this letter. Then he quoted a hymn about Christ.

3:16a

By common confession, the mystery of godliness is great:

- Without any doubt, our^(incl) faith contains a deep mystery:
- No one can rightly deny that what God has revealed to us^(incl) is awesome.

By common confession: The Greek word that the BSB translates as By common confession literally means “undeniably, most certainly.” It means that the statement that follows is absolutely true.

the mystery of godliness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mystery here is the same word as in 3:9. See the note there. Paul was referring to the true message that God has revealed to people.

In the rest of this verse, Paul explained the aspects of this mystery, The mystery is that God himself came to earth as Jesus. Paul called it the mystery of godliness because when people understand it they want to be godly.

godliness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as godliness the way people behave when they respect God. See godliness, godly in the Glossary.

great: The word great in English can have more than one meaning. In this verse it means “wonderful” or “awesome.”

3:16b–g

Here, Paul stated in six short lines what “the mystery of godliness” is. These six lines are possibly a hymn that the believers sang in Paul’s time, or they may be a creed that believers recited. To show this, you may

want to print them on separate lines as some English versions have done.

3:16b

He appeared in the flesh,

- Christ became a human.

He: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He literally means “who.” This suggests that this hymn/creed was part of a longer composition. Both the literal “who” and the BSB’s He are ambiguous: they could refer to either God or Christ. If it is possible in your translation to retain the ambiguity you should do so. If you must choose, you should use “Christ” or “Christ Jesus.” There is also a textual issue as some manuscripts begin with the word “God” rather than “who”. The KJV follows this reading. However, the oldest manuscripts use “who” to start the hymn. The Editorial Committee of the UBS New Testament (4th edition) gives the reading with “who” an {A} rating, indicating that the text is almost certain.

appeared in the flesh: That is, he “became a human” or “came to earth as a human being.”

3:16c

was vindicated by the Spirit,

- He was proved to be the Son of God by the Holy Spirit.
- The Holy Spirit showed that he really was the Son of God.

was vindicated by the Spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as vindicate means “to prove that something or someone is right.” Therefore, when Paul said that Christ was vindicated by the Spirit, he meant that the Holy Spirit showed that Christ was the Son of God, as he claimed to be. Paul did not specify here in what way the Spirit vindicated Christ, so you should not say so either.

the Spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Spirit probably refers to the Holy Spirit.

In some languages it may be necessary to use the normal term for “Holy Spirit” instead of simply “the Spirit” to make it clear.

3:16d

was seen by angels,

- He was seen by angels.
- Angels saw him.

was seen by angels: This could refer to several different events in Jesus’ life. For example, it could refer to:

1. the angels who saw Jesus at the time of his resurrection

2. the angels who saw Jesus after his ascension
3. the angels who saw Jesus during the time of his life on earth

The text is not explicit and so in your translation you should not make this explicit either.

angels: In this context, The word that the BSB translates as angel refers to “a supernatural, spiritual being who is a messenger from God.”

3:16e
was proclaimed among the nations,

- The message about him was preached to every nation.
- The apostles told the good news about him to people everywhere.

was proclaimed among the nations: In some languages, it may be necessary to state who proclaimed about Christ. The subject could be “his disciples” or “the apostles.”

nations: This word refers to people who are not Jews, people of every language, culture, and ethnic group.

3:16f
was believed in throughout the world,

- He was believed in by people everywhere in the world.
- In all places where believers preached about Christ, people believed in him.

was believed in throughout the world: It may be necessary in some languages to state who believed in Christ. One way to do this is:

people of the world believed in him

3:16g
was taken up in glory.

- He was taken up into the glory of heaven.
- God took him up into heaven.

was taken up in glory: Again in some languages it may be necessary to state who took Christ up in glory. If this is true in your language, you should say that God took Christ up in glory.

in glory: In this context the word glory can mean two things:

1. It refers to the place where God took Christ, that is, heaven. The term glory is used because God, who is awesomely bright, glorious and splendid, is in heaven. Versions that follow this interpretation use the preposition “into” or “to” before the word glory. For example, the CEV says:

he was taken up to glory (CEV, GNT, KJV, REB, NLT, GW)

1. It refers to the manner in which God took Christ to be with him—in an amazing, powerful, glorious way. Versions that follow this interpretation usually use the preposition in before the word glory. For example, the NIV says:

was taken up in glory (BSB, NIV, RSV, NJB, NASB, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1): that God took Christ up to heaven. See glory, meaning 3, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 3:16e–g

In some languages it will be best to reorder these verse parts so that they appear in chronological order. For example:

^{16g}was taken up in glory.

^{16e}was preached among the nations,

^{16f}was believed on in the world,

That is, Christ was taken up to glory before his disciples preached about him.

1 Timothy 4:1

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

4:1a Now the Spirit expressly states

- ¶ The Holy Spirit plainly says
- ¶ But the Spirit has often spoken these very clear words:

Now: This word indicates the way that this paragraph connects with what Paul had just said. It indicates a contrast. The church was “the pillar and foundation of the truth” (3:15d), and this truth “was believed on in the world” (3:16f). Even though that was true, some people were going to abandon this truth and even teach against it. If you have a suitable way in your language to indicate this connection you should use it here.

Paul was not writing to warn Timothy that someday false teachers would come to Ephesus. They were already there, as Paul had written in 1:3-7.

the Spirit: That is, the Holy Spirit.

expressly states: What the Holy Spirit communicated was clear, precise, and easy to understand.

states: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as states is in the present tense. Paul probably used the present tense in order to indicate that the Holy Spirit oftenThis is an instance of the customary or habitual present, which refers to “repeated activity on a regular or habitual basis.” See Perschbacher, page 281. said this.

Paul was probably referring to the way that the Holy Spirit communicated through the prophets within the Christian community. The Holy Spirit also revealed this information through Jesus’ teaching (see Mark 13:22 and Matthew 24:10-11). And Paul himself had prophesied this in his farewell to the Ephesian elders recorded in Acts 20:29-30.

It is not clear in the Greek text how much of the following verses was spoken by the Holy Spirit. It is recommended that you not make explicit where the quotation ends. If you have to make it explicit, you should probably make the quotation end at the end of 4:2.

4:1b that in later times

- that in these end days
- In the time before Christ returns

later times: Scholars understand the phrase that the BSB translates as later times in two main ways:

1. The phrase refers to the time between Christ’s resurrection and his return. This period is sometimes called the “last days” in the Bible. So the later times were not still in the future in Paul’s day. They had already begun. For example, the NJB says:

during the last times (NJB, KJV, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. The phrase refers to time that was later than or after the time when the Holy Spirit spoke the message. For example, the REB says:

in time to come (BSB, REB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NASB, NET, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was saying that people were already abandoning the faith even at the time when he was writing. He also expected more people to abandon it after he finished writing.

4:1c some will abandon the faith

- some will give up believing the true teachings about Christ.
- some people will stop believing Christian teachings.

abandon the faith: The Greek word that the BSB translates as abandon means “to desert/discard something.” In this context, it refers to a person who no longer believes in or obeys the Christian faith.

the faith: Paul was referring in general to everything that people believe and do in order to follow Christ. See faith, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

4:1d to follow deceitful spirits

- They will accept evil spirits who mislead them

to follow deceitful spirits: The Greek word that the BSB translates as follow can also mean “being devoted to” or “paying close attention to.” Believers had followed the true teaching about Christ. Other people had chosen to abandon that teaching (4:1c) and follow the teachings of deceiving spirits instead.

deceitful spirits: The word that the BSB translates as spirits is a general word and can be used for human spirits, the Holy Spirit, and also evil spirits. By itself it does not indicate good or evil. But the adjective that the BSB translates as deceitful, as well as the context, show that Paul was referring to evil spiritual beings.

These beings have the following characteristics:

1. They are spiritual beings, not the spirits of people who have died. Therefore, do not use a term that you use to refer to ancestor spirits.
2. These spirits serve and work for Satan.
3. They can take control of a human being.

Compare the term you use here with the term you use elsewhere for “evil/unclean spirits.” Also see the note on “demons” in 4:1e.

deceitful: This indicates that the spirits deliberately attempted to make people believe lies.

4:1e and the teachings of demons,

- and believe false teachings that come from demons.

the teachings of demons: Paul probably meant that false teachers were going to teach things that demons wanted them to teach. In some languages, a literal translation of the teachings of demons would make people think that the demons themselves actually taught the people. If this is true in your language, you could say:

They will believe people who teach false ideas that demons want people to believe.

demons: The terms deceiving spirits and demons refer to the same sort of spiritual beings. If you do not have two different terms you can use, use the same term for “spirit” and “demon.”

1 Timothy 4:2

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

4:2a influenced by the hypocrisy of liars,

- The people who teach these things will act like they are telling the truth, but really they will be lying.

the hypocrisy of liars: When Paul said that these false teachers were liars practicing hypocrisy, he meant that they acted like they believed one thing when they really believed something else. They seemed to be true believers in God, but they were really teaching false ideas that came from demons. Perhaps your language has an idiomatic way to say that someone is hypocritical that you could use here.

4:2b whose consciences are seared with a hot iron.

- They will no longer know whether they are doing right or wrong, in the same way that flesh can no longer feel anything when someone has burned it with a hot iron.
- Their consciences have been destroyed so that they do not know right from wrong.

consciences: The Greek word that the BSB translates as consciences refers to the part of a person that helps him know what is right and what is wrong to think or do. See the note on 1:5c.

seared with a hot iron: This is a figure of speech that has two possible meanings:

1. The false teachers' consciences were so damaged that they no longer knew whether they were doing right or wrong. This is the same way that flesh can no longer feel anything when someone has burned it with a hot iron. For example, the GNT says:

whose consciences are dead, as if burnt with a hot iron (BSB, GNT, NIV, RSV, KJV, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. A person or an animal that is branded with a hot iron belongs to the person who owns the brand. In the same way, the false teachers now belonged to Satan. So the NJB says:

whose consciences are branded as though with a red-hot iron (NJB, REB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The false teachers no longer knew whether they were sinning or not.

1 Timothy 4:3

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

4:3a**They will prohibit marriage**

- They wrongly teach that people must not get married.

They will prohibit marriage: Paul did not use a future tense here, but a present tense, as in the NIV: “They forbid people to marry.” The false teachers were already spreading their wrong teaching and telling people that it was wrong to get married. By saying that believers should not get married, the false teachers were saying that a man and a woman should not have any kind of sexual relationship. See also 1 Corinthians 7:3–5, where Paul implied that there were people who were teaching that even married couples should not have sex. There have been people throughout history who have taught that sex is bad. Among these are the Essenes, the Encratites (described by Irenaeus), and Tertullian. For more details, see Stott, page 113.

Paul implied that it is wrong to forbid people to marry. In some languages, you will need to make it clear in the translation that Paul implied that this was wrong.

4:3b**and require abstinence from certain foods**

- They also wrongly tell people that they must not eat some kinds of food.

require abstinence from certain foods: That is, the false teachers taught the people not to eat some kinds of food.

certain foods: The Greek word that the BSB translates as certain foods is a general word that refers to any kind of solid food. It does not refer to drinks. The false teachers were saying that there were some kinds of food that believers should not eat. For example, they may have been saying that it was not good to eat meat. Paul used the same Greek word that he used here, *brōma*, to refer specifically to meat in Romans 14. The evidence that he was doing this is that he interchanged the word in that chapter with the Greek word *krea*, which can only mean “meat.” For example, in Romans 14:20, he said that people should not destroy the work of God for the sake of *brōma*. He continued teaching this point in Romans 14:21 by saying that therefore people should abstain from eating *krea* if they would offend another believer and damage him spiritually by eating meat. Note also that in Romans 14:2 Paul was using as an example the Christian whose faith was weak and who therefore ate only vegetables. This indicates that in this chapter he was contrasting people like that with people whose faith was stronger, so that they could eat meat without feeling guilty. It also indicates that when he spoke about *brōma* in

Romans 14:20, he was referring to meat. In 1 Corinthians 8:13, Paul interchanged *brōma* in a single verse with *krea*. It is likely that Paul used *brōma* to refer specifically to meat here in 1 Timothy 4:2 also. If that is how he used this word here, then he was saying that the false teachers were saying that it was always wrong to eat meat. The main difference between the people who had weak faith, whom Paul described in Romans 14 and 1 Corinthians 8, and the false teachers against whom he was writing here in 4:3 is that the weak people did not teach other people that meat was inherently evil and that it was always wrong to eat it, as the false teachers taught. This difference was the main reason why Paul condemned the teaching of the false teachers here in 4:3 (see also Colossians 2:16–17, 2:21–23), in contrast with the gentle and considerate way that Paul recommended for strong believers to treat weaker believers in Romans 14 and 1 Corinthians 8. See Knight, page 190. It is possible that they considered certain foods unclean or impure, as the Old Testament law had said.

4:3c**that God has created to be received with thanksgiving by those who believe and know the truth.**

- But God made every kind of food so that all those who believe and know his true message would accept the food and thank him for it.

that: That is, the kinds of food that the false teachers were telling the believers not to eat.

to be received: God created food for people to eat. When Paul said that they receive it from God, he meant that God supplies the food. Paul implied that it cannot be bad because it comes from God and everything that God created is good (see 4:4a).

with thanksgiving: This means that people should thank God for their food.

by those who believe and know the truth: Paul implied that believers may eat all foods because God made food for people to receive with thanksgiving. Be careful that your translation does not make people think that God made food only for believers.

believe and know: Paul was not talking about two groups of people (one that believes, and another one that knows). He was talking about only one group of people, true believers.

the truth: The expression the truth is also used in 2:7d and 3:15d. It refers to the gospel, the message from God about Christ.

1 Timothy 4:4

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

4:4a

For every creation of God is good,

- What those people say is wrong because everything God has made, including food, is good,

For: In this verse Paul explained the reason that the false teachers were wrong when they told people not to eat certain foods.

every creation of God is good: Paul was referring to Genesis 1:31 which says: “God saw all that he had made, and it was very good.” Paul referred to this to support his statement in 4:3c. Everything that God created is good, so people can freely eat all kinds of food.

4:4b

and nothing that is received with thanksgiving

- We^(incl) accept all food and thank God for it.

nothing: That is, no food.

that is received with thanksgiving: This is the same phrase that Paul used in 4:3c and you should try and use the same words here.

4:4c

should be rejected,

- and there are no kinds of food that should be avoided.
- and so we^(incl) should not say that people should not eat certain food.

should be rejected: That is, it is acceptable to eat all food and it is wrong to teach that certain food should not be eaten.

1 Timothy 4:5

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

4:5

because it is sanctified by the word of God and prayer.

- For it is made holy by what God has said and by what we^(incl) pray before eating.
- For God in the Scriptures has declared it to be holy, and when we^(incl) thank God for it we^(incl) agree with him.

because: The Greek word *gar* that the BSB translates as *because* can also be translated “for.” Paul used the word here to summarize the reasons the false teachers were wrong to ban some kinds of food.

it is sanctified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *sanctified* means “made holy, consecrated.” All foods are acceptable, for no food that God has made is impure or unclean. See also Acts 10:15.

by the word of God and prayer: This is the means by which food has been made holy.

the word of God: This refers to what God said in Scripture.

This is an example of personification, where Paul talked about the word of God as if it were a person. It is actually God who sanctifies food by his word. So in some languages it may be necessary to translate this as:

God made everything holy by what he said

God has declared everything to be holy

prayer: Paul was probably referring to the prayer of thanksgiving that he had mentioned in 4:3c. When

people thank God for food, they are agreeing with God that it is good.

General Comment on 4:4–5

In some languages it may be better to reverse the order of these verses so that the cause comes before the result. One way to do this is:

^{4a}For everything God created is good. ⁵It is declared holy by the word of God and by prayer. ^{4c}So nothing is to be rejected ^{4b}but everything should be received with thanksgiving.

1 Timothy 4:6

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:6–8

Paul once more gave Timothy some direct commands about how he could be a good servant of Christ. He must reject false teaching and train himself to behave in ways that please God.

4:6a

By pointing out these things to the brothers,

- ¶ As you teach these things to the brothers,
- ¶ Explain these things to your spiritual brothers and sisters.

By pointing out these things: Paul was indirectly commanding Timothy to point certain things out to other believers. Sherman and Tuggy (1994) say about the English language, “It is commonly understood that such forms as “Would you like to do the dishes?” means “I would like you to wash the dishes; please wash them.” This is a gentle way of suggesting that someone do something. Greek, English, Spanish, and probably many other European languages use this (and other devices) for gentle suggestions. For instance, we all react to the sentence “If we confess our sins, he will cleanse us” as meaning “We should

confess our sins, since he will cleanse us.” Notice the mismatching between the surface grammar and the meaning which it expresses. Grammatically, the sentence is made up of a dependent conditional clause attached to an independent clause. Semantically, however, the relationship is reversed; that is, the central appeal unit is expressed by the dependent clause, and the supporting motivational unit is expressed by the independent clause. This mismatching between the grammar and the meaning is a device for making the exhortation or command a gentle one.” Other ways to express this are:

In pointing out these things (NASB)

when you point these things out (GW)

pointing out: In this context, Paul meant that Timothy should make the other believers aware of “these things.”

these things: It is not clear what things Paul was referring to here. It could be:

1. the things that Paul had mentioned immediately before this, that is, in the previous section (4:1–5). Paul was giving the reasons why it was acceptable to eat any kind of food.
2. all the instructions that Paul had given in the letter so far.

Most translations do not make clear what these things refer to. It is recommended that you also leave this ambiguous if you can. However, Paul was probably emphasizing at this point what he had written about immediately before this in 4:1–5. So if it is necessary for you to make a choice here, it is recommended that you translate these things in a way that refers to the immediately preceding verses.

brothers: The word brothers refers to believers, or other Christians. This term probably includes both men and women. In your translation, you can say “all the other believers” or “all the brothers and sisters.”

4:6b

you will be a good servant of Christ Jesus,

- you will be serving Christ Jesus in an excellent way.
- If you do this, you will be serving Christ Jesus well.

a good servant of Christ Jesus: There are several interpretations of what Paul meant when he said that he expected Timothy to be a good servant of Christ Jesus. The two most likely meanings are:

1. He expected Timothy to do the work of Christ by teaching others. In other words, he expected Timothy to do what Christ wanted and commanded.
2. He expected Timothy to be a person whom Christ appointed to teach and help others.

It is recommended that you use a general expression here rather than making one of these interpretations explicit. But if you must be specific, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Some people, however, think that when Paul used the word Christ before the word Jesus, as in Christ Jesus, he was emphasizing that Jesus was the Messiah.

In most English versions “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

However, it is possible that, in some languages, people may be confused to see the names in two different orders. They may even think that Paul was referring to two different people. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ.” This is the more usual word order in the New Testament.

Christ: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

4:6c

nourished by the words of faith and sound instruction

- Also God will nurture/train you by means of the faith and the good teaching

nourished by: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nourished by is a word used when referring to rearing a child. The word in Greek is *entrephō*. Some people, including Louw and Nida, BAG, and NEB understand this to refer primarily to being trained. Louw and Nida (33.242) translate the active form of this word as, “to provide instruction and training, with the implication of skill in some area of practical knowledge—‘to train, to teach.’” BAG gives as the definition, “bring up, rear, then train in something.” Newman gives the

definition for the middle form as, “live on, feed oneself on.” Knight (page 194), referring to Robertson, mentions that this word “was used by Plato (Leges 7.798a) of those who are ‘nourished in the laws.’” Arichea and Hatton (page 97) say that it refers to both nourishing and training: “The word for nourished occurs nowhere else in the New Testament; the metaphor very likely comes from child rearing and pertains to all the activities that have something to do with the nurturing of a child, such as feeding and training.” In this context, it is a metaphor that means “being trained by.”

Paul was saying that when Timothy taught other believers, God would use those teachings to train not only the listeners but also Timothy himself.

the words: The expression the words is connected to both “the faith” and “the good teaching.”

faith: Here, faith refers to Christianity. In other words, it refers to all that God revealed to people concerning what we should believe and do in order to follow Christ properly. See the note on faith at 3:9. See faith, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

sound instruction: The sound instruction refers to the true teaching about God. It contrasts with the false teaching that Paul had been warning Timothy about.

4:6d

that you have followed.

- which you have obeyed.

that you have followed: That is, that Timothy had chosen to listen to and obey.

General Comment on 4:6a–d

In some languages it may be better to reorder this verse. One way to do this is:

^{6a}Teach these things to the brothers, ^{6c-d}and the truths of the faith and the good teaching you follow will nourish/train you. ^{6b}In this way you will be a good servant of Christ Jesus.

1 Timothy 4:7

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).

2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:6–8

Paul once more gave Timothy some direct commands about how he could be a good servant of Christ. He must reject false teaching and train himself to behave in ways that please God.

4:7a

But reject irreverent, silly myths.

- Completely avoid the teachings which are untrue, and foolish stories that do not help people honor God.

But reject: The phrase But reject: means to ignore or choose not to pay attention to something. Paul told Timothy that he should study and obey the truths of the faith. He should reject: false teachings.

irreverent, silly myths: Paul said that the false teachings were really only myths. A myth is a story that has been made up and passed down from one generation to another and taught to the people. It may be based on something that happened in the past or it may be something made up to explain why people follow certain customs. But it is not true like history. See the note on 1:4a.

irreverent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as irreverent means that these myths did not help people to respect God. See godless, Word 2, in the Glossary.

silly myths: The Greek words that the BSB translates as silly myths is literally “old wives’ tales.” That is a common idiom in English as well as Greek. It refer to foolish stories, or to stories that are not worth telling. However, the term did not imply that women or old people were foolish. Paul was simply using a common term for a story that was not worth believing or even telling. If you have an idiom that is used for similar stories, you may be able to use it here. Otherwise it is recommended that you use a general expression like “silly” as the BSB has done.

4:7b

Instead, train yourself for godliness.

- Instead, constantly train yourself to behave as God wants you to.
- Instead, constantly learn to obey God in everything.

Instead: This is the way that the BSB translates the Greek word *de* that connects 4:7a with 4:7b. Many English versions leave the connection implicit. The

connection between 4:7a and 4:7b is that instead of paying attention to worthless teachings (4:7a), Timothy should train himself to be godly (4:7b).

train yourself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as train refers to doing regular and intense physical exercise to prepare for a sport or athletic contest. Paul used this figure of speech to describe the continual effort and discipline that is needed to behave in a way that pleases God.

In some languages, it may not be possible to use a word that relates to sports in order to talk about a person’s spiritual life. Other languages may not even have the concept of training for a sport. If this figure of speech will not work in your language, you could say something like:

Instead, constantly be forming good habits in order to behave like God wants you to.

godliness: Paul had already used the Greek word that the BSB translates as godliness in 2:2c A person who practices godliness expresses his faith by what he does; he behaves in a way that shows that he respects God. See godliness, godly in the Glossary.

1 Timothy 4:8

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:6–8

Paul once more gave Timothy some direct commands about how he could be a good servant of Christ. He must reject false teaching and train himself to behave in ways that please God.

4:8–10

In 4:9, Paul used an expression that he had used before (see the note on 1:15a). He was indicating that he was quoting a saying that was probably known to Timothy and other believers.

However, in this chapter, scholars do not agree about the contents of the saying. There are two main views:

1. The saying is in 4:8. The CEV indicates that it is following this option by placing quotation marks in 4:8. Knight, page 198, says, “The following considerations have convinced me that v. 8 is the saying: V. 8 looks like a proverbial saying, a point acknowledged by those who opt for v. 10. It contains two unique words, *γυμνασία* [=‘exercise’] (a NT hapax) and *σωματικός* [=‘bodily’] (only here and Lk. 3:22 in the NT), whereas v. 10 contains none, and it is more stereotyped in form than v. 10. V. 9 urges a personal response to the saying with the words ‘worthy of full acceptance,’ words that are only added to the citation-commendation formula when the note of personal response is not contained in the saying itself (see the comments on 1:15; Faithful Sayings, 30, 143f.), which is the case with v. 8, but not with v. 10, with its first person plural (‘we’) verbs....V. 10 does seem to be a more lofty theological statement than v. 8 and does include the note of salvation found in other ‘faithful sayings’ (e.g., 1 Tim. 1:15), but certainly v. 8 is equally significant as a theological statement, and the concept of salvation is not present in all the ‘faithful sayings’ (e.g., 1 Tim. 3:1; cf. also 2 Tim. 2:11–13). And form is a surer guide than content. Finally, the foil statement in v. 8a, *γὰρ σωματικὴ γυμνασία πρὸς ὀλίγον ἐστὶν ὠφέλιμος* [=‘for bodily exercise for a little is profitable’] can be better explained as part of a ‘saying.’” However, most other versions only indicate that they follow this interpretation by the way they word the verse or by the punctuation they use. (BSB, CEV, GNT, NJB, RSV, KJV, NASB, NET, NCV, NLT, GW) Most commentators also support this view.
2. The saying is found in 4:10. (NIV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as it is supported by the majority of scholars.

4:8a

For physical exercise is of limited value,

- For it is somewhat useful to exercise your body,
- You should do this because as you know, it is quite good for a person to train himself so that his body becomes strong.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *For* connects 4:8 with 4:7. It explains the reason that it was important for Timothy to train himself to be godly (4:7b).

physical exercise: This phrase refers to the way an athlete trains his body to become strong. Paul used the same word for exercise here as he used in the

expression “train yourself” in 4:7b. However here he added the word that the BSB translates as physical, that is, “bodily.”

is of limited value: When Paul said that physical training is of limited value, he meant that physical training did benefit people in some way. However, he made it clear in 4:8b that godliness benefited people more. Physical training helps people only while they are alive on earth. Godliness helps people now and also after they die.

4:8b

but godliness is valuable in every way,

- but to be godly is useful for everything,
- But it is better for a person to try hard to behave like God wants him to behave,

but: The word that the BSB translates as *but* indicates that there is a contrast between physical training (4:8a) and spiritual training (4:8b).

godliness: Paul was still talking about training, but now the emphasis was on spiritual training. As the note on “godliness” in 4:7b said, the Greek word that the BSB translates as godliness refers to the way people behave when they respect God. See godliness, godly in the Glossary.

is valuable in every way: This contrasts with the words that the BSB translates as “is of some value” in 4:8a.

4:8c

holding promise for the present life and for the one to come.

- because this helps a person both while he is alive on this earth and also after he dies.

holding promise: This part of the verse explains the way in which “godliness has value for all things” (4:8b). It is because it holds promise. This means that when a person trains himself in godliness, he can be sure that there will be a reward (from God).

for the present life and for the one to come: This verse does not state what the rewards might be. But it does say that there will be rewards both before and after a person dies. The CEV has one way to express this:

It promises life now and forever.

Paul used a saying that was well known to the believers at that time. He had done the same thing in 1:15a and 3:1a.

1 Timothy 4:9

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

4:9a

This is a trustworthy saying,

- ¶ This saying about godliness is reliable
- ¶ What I have just said is commonly spoken among believers, and you can be sure that it is true.

This is a trustworthy saying: This is an expression that Paul used often in his letters to Timothy and Titus. See 1 Timothy 1:15, 3:1; 2 Timothy 2:11; Titus 1:9, 3:8. You should try and use the same expression for trustworthy saying in all these places. Paul used this expression to refer to a saying that was well known among believers at that time.

Since this saying refers back to something Paul has already said in 4:8, it may be necessary to change the wording of the sentence. For example:

What I have just said is a trustworthy saying

See the General Comment on 4:8–9 for a suggestion that involves changing the order of the verses.

trustworthy: Paul said that what he had said was trustworthy. That means that it was true and reliable. Other ways to say this could be: “This saying really is true,” or “people should believe this.”

saying: A saying is an expression that is well known to people. In some languages it may be possible to use a word like “proverb.”

4:9b

worthy of full acceptance.

- and everyone can believe it without doubting it.
- It is worthy to be believed completely.

worthy of full acceptance: Because the saying is “trustworthy”, everyone should believe it and should not doubt it in any way. They can be sure that it is true.

General Comment on 4:8–9

As mentioned above, Paul quoted the saying in 4:8, but he did not mention that it was a saying until 4:9. So, in some languages it may be helpful to reverse the order of 4:8 and 4:9 so that Paul’s statement in 4:9 introduces the saying. One way to do this is:

^{9a}For this is a trustworthy saying ^{9b}that deserves full acceptance. ^{8a}Physical training is of some value. ^{8b}However godliness has value for all things, ^{8c}as it holds promise for both the present life and the life to come.

1 Timothy 4:10

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

4:10a

To this end we labor and strive,

- For this is our^(incl) aim when we^(incl) work and struggle for our^(incl) faith
- Because of this saying, we^(incl) work hard to do this

In the Greek text, this verse uses the particle *gar*, which the BSB leaves implicit. This word indicates the way that this verse connects with what Paul had just said. It indicates that this verse is a reason or logical support for what he has just said. If you have a suitable way in your language to indicate this connection you should use it here.

To this end: There are two interpretations about what the word *this* refers to:

1. It refers back to the saying in 4:8. The English versions that follow this interpretation usually include a connection like *for* or “this is why” in their translation. (RSV, NET, NASB)

2. It refers forward to 4:10b. The English versions that follow this interpretation usually begin 4:10 as a new sentence with no overt connection to the verses before. (NIV, GNT, NJB, CEV, GW, probably the BSB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek words at the beginning of this verse often point back to something already mentioned. The Greek expression for the words “to this” is *eis touto*. This expression is found 13 times in the New Testament. When it occurs with an infinitive (Acts 26:16) or with a *hina* (John 18:37 x2; Acts 9:21; 1 John 3:8; Romans 14:9; 2 Corinthians 2:9; 1 Peter 3:9, 4:6), it points forward in the sentence. When it occurs with an indicative verb (Mark 1:38; 1 Thessalonians 3:3) it points back to a previous proposition. It occurs with *hoti* only here and in 1 Peter 2:21. In 1 Peter 2:21 it clearly points back. Consequently, it is likely that it points back here in 1 Timothy 4:10, also. BAG comments on the construction in its entry for *houtos*, page 596, saying, “1. b. In particular, the neut. is used *α. w. ref. to what precedes:....Freq. w. prepositions...dia touto...eis touto...ek toutou....*” Knight, page 202, says, “V. 10 begins with two transition terms, *εις τοῦτο* and *ἕχαρ. εις τοῦτο* ...has reference to the promise and its content. *ἕχαρ* ‘shows that this verse is to serve as a reason or confirmation of the preceding thought that godliness is profitable for all things...’ (Huther). Both terms bridge over v. 9 to v. 8 and tie v. 10 very closely with v. 8.”

labor: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as labor often refers to physical work like working in a field. However, in this context, Paul was not talking about literal working. See the next note on “strive.”

strive: Some translations, such as the KJV and NLT, follow a version of the Greek text that says “suffer reproach” instead of strive. The majority of the editorial committee for the UBS Greek New Testament (4th edition) chose the variant “struggle.” However, they gave it a {C} reading, which means that the Committee had difficulty in deciding which variant to place in the text. Metzger, page 642, says, “A majority of the Committee preferred the latter [‘struggle’] partly because it has slightly better attestation and partly because it seems better suited to the context.” Most English versions follow the UBS text here. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as strive often refers to competing in an athletic contest or to fighting as a soldier does. He also used the same verb in 1 Corinthians 9:25, where it clearly refers to competing as an athlete. In this context, Paul probably meant the verb to mean “fight, struggle” rather than “compete as an athlete.” Paul used the same verb in 6:12a.

As with the verb that the BSB translates as labor Paul did not use this verb literally.

These two words translated labor and strive mean almost the same thing. Paul used both to emphasize the tremendous effort that he and Timothy exerted in order to be godly. In some languages it may be necessary to combine these two terms into one expression, For example:

for this we work very hard

4:10b

because we have set our hope on the living God,

- because we^(incl) trust in God, who truly lives,

because: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because is *hoti*. This word can have many different meanings. Here, it means “because.” For example, see the RSV and the GNT. Paul used this word to introduce a detailed explanation of 4:10a.

we have set our hope on: This means that Paul and Timothy trusted in God. They believed that God would save them and give them the eternal life that he had promised to give them. The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as have set our hope on implies that this was something that they were doing continually.

our: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

the living God: Paul used this expression here in the same way that he used it in 3:15c. In both verses, he used the expression to emphasize that God is active. The next part of this verse, 4:10c, says that God is active in the sense that he “saves” us.

4:10c

who is the Savior of everyone,

- who is the Savior of all people,
- He is the one who is able to save everyone,

the Savior of everyone: Paul and Timothy put much effort into obeying God. He said here that that was because God was the Savior of everyone. This means that God is the only one who can save all people, and that he is able and willing to do so.

Savior: The word that the BSB translates as Savior refers to a person who rescues someone from danger. In this context, Paul was talking about God, who rescues us from the consequences of our sin. See the note on “our Savior” in 1:1c and the note on “save” in 1:15c.

everyone: Paul wanted to emphasize that God wanted to save everyone, not just a certain kind or group of people.

**4:10d
and especially of those who believe.**

- and particularly of those who believe in him.
- and who does save those who trust in him.

especially: The Greek word that the BSB translates as especially is *malista*. In this context, it means especially, that is, “particularly,” or “above all.” Another possible meaning for *malista* is “that is” or “in other words.” Several modern commentators follow this interpretation. Paul was stating more exactly who the people are whom God saves. They are the people who believe. Knight, page 203, says, “Skeat (‘Especially the Parchments’) argues persuasively that *μάλιστα* [=‘especially’] in some cases...should be understood as providing a further definition or identification of that which precedes it and thus renders it by such words as ‘that is.’ He cites several examples from papyrus letters that would seem to require this sense and that would in their particular cases rule out the otherwise legitimate alternate sense.” See Skeat, T. C., “‘Especially the Parchments’: A Note on 2 Timothy IV.13,” *Journal of Theological Studies* 30 (1979) 173–177. This is the normal meaning of the Greek word. It is true that God is the Savior of all people (4:10c). That is, he is the only one who can save people and he is able and willing to do that. But God is especially the Savior of believers in the sense that he has actually saved them.

believe: To believe means to trust in Christ, which also implies to obey him.

1 Timothy 4:11

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:11–16

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy how to convince people to accept his teaching, even though he was young. He told Timothy to be a good example for the other believers (4:12b). He told him to read the Scriptures to people and to teach them (4:13b). He also told Timothy to use the gift that God had given him (4:14a). This gift was the ability that God had given him to teach and to lead other people. Paul also told Timothy to keep progressing spiritually (4:15c), and to persevere (4:16b). Adapted from Stott, pages 120–125.

4:11

Command and teach these things.

- ¶ I Command and teach these things that I have written to the other believers.

these things: Paul was referring to the things that he had been writing about, especially in the previous paragraph (4:6–10).

General Comment on 4:11

People teach something and then command people to obey it. Therefore, in some languages it may be more logical to reverse the order of the verbs in this verse. You could say:

Teach the believers all these things that I have written and command them to obey them.

1 Timothy 4:12

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:11–16

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy how to convince people to accept his teaching, even though he was young. He told Timothy to be a good example for the other believers (4:12b). He told him to read the Scriptures to people and to teach them (4:13b). He also told Timothy to use the gift that God had given him

(4:14a). This gift was the ability that God had given him to teach and to lead other people. Paul also told Timothy to keep progressing spiritually (4:15c), and to persevere (4:16b). Adapted from Stott, pages 120–125.

4:12a

Let no one despise your youth,

- Behave in a way that no one will show disrespect for you because you are young,
- so that no one will ignore your teaching because they think that you are too young to be a teacher.

Let no one despise your youth: People who lived when Paul did normally expected spiritual leaders to be older than Timothy was. Therefore, some people thought that he was too young to teach them so they didn't want to obey him.

The form of the Greek verb is a third-person command. It could better be expressed in English as “May no one look down on you.” Paul was telling Timothy that he should behave in ways that made him deserve respect. Then people would respect him and not look down on him. The next verses told Timothy how to do this. Use a form of the verb in your language that will best fit this context.

despise: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as despise means “regard as worthless,” “show disrespect to,” or “regard as inferior.”

youth: Timothy was probably between thirty and forty years old when Paul wrote this letter. Try to use a word for youth that includes Timothy's age group. In some cultures, people do not consider a man of this age group a youth. If this is true in your area, you may need to state that some people thought that Timothy was too young to teach them.

4:12b

but set an example for the believers

- and be a good model for the believers to follow.
- You must behave in a way that the other believers in Christ can copy.

set an example: The word that the BSB translates as example means a “model” or “pattern.” Paul wanted Timothy to behave in a way that other believers could copy. If he did that, people would respect him and would listen to what he taught them, even though they considered him young.

an example: In some languages there is no noun that means example. In such languages it may be possible to use a verb like “demonstrate” or “show.” For example:

Instead, show the other believers how to behave as God wants them to.

4:12c–d

Paul wanted Timothy to be an example to the other believers in the way he behaved. In the rest of this verse Paul listed five ways in which Timothy was to be an example. Some translations, such as the KJV, add a sixth way, the words “in spirit”, after “in faith” in 4:10d. However, the oldest and best Greek texts that Bible scholars know about do not have the words “in spirit” here. That is why most modern translations do not include this phrase.

4:12c

in speech, in conduct,

- Always speak what is right and behave correctly.
- Show them by your example how to speak and how to behave as believers should.

in speech: This is the first way in which Timothy was to be an example. Paul meant that Timothy should be careful that everything he said was true, kind, and helpful to others. He should avoid lying or gossiping.

in conduct: This is the second way in which Timothy was to be an example to the other believers. Paul meant that Timothy should behave in a way that pleased God and that others could imitate. Other believers should not have any reason to criticize him for his behavior.

4:12d

in love, in faith, in purity.

- Love people. Trust Christ. Do not sin.
- Show them how to love people, how to trust Christ, and how to live without sinning.

in love: This is the third way in which Timothy was to be an example to the other believers. Paul meant that Timothy should be an example to other people by loving them. Here Paul was probably referring to loving people more than to loving God. So if you need to use a verb here with an object, you should say:

in the way you love other people

in faith: This is the fourth way in which Timothy was to be an example to the other believers. Paul told Timothy to be an example to other people in faith. He meant that Timothy should be an example in the way he trusted in God. There is a second possibility here. Rather than talking about faith in God, Paul meant that Timothy should be faithful to his calling. Knight, page 206, says “The previous and following usages of πίστις [=‘faith’] as a Christian virtue coupled with

ἀγάπη [=‘love’] and other virtues in the PE [=Pastoral Epistles] (see above) incline one to understand πίστις here as “faith,” i.e., “trust,” as do the preponderance of cases elsewhere in Paul (e.g., 1 Tim. 2:15; 6:11; 2 Tim. 2:22; 3:10; Gal. 5:6, 22, but for a contrary view on Gal. 5:22 cf. the commentaries of Burton and Bruce).” See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

in purity: This is the fifth and final way in which Timothy was to be an example to the other believers. Paul meant that Timothy was always to behave in a pure way. The Greek word that the BSB translates as purity often refers to avoiding sexual sin in particular. However in this context, it probably refers to avoiding any kind of sin, including sexual sin.

General Comment on 4:12b–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder this verse. For example, you could begin with the list of the ways in which Timothy should be an example. Here is one way to do that:

^{12c}speak what is right, behave in a way that pleases God, ^{12d}love other people, trust in God, and behave in a blameless way. ^{12b}Then you will be an example to the other believers.

1 Timothy 4:13

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:11–16

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy how to convince people to accept his teaching, even though he was young. He told Timothy to be a good example for the other believers (4:12b). He told him to read the Scriptures to people and to teach them (4:13b). He also told Timothy to use the gift that God had given him (4:14a). This gift was the ability that God had given him to teach and to lead other people. Paul also told

Timothy to keep progressing spiritually (4:15c), and to persevere (4:16b). Adapted from Stott, pages 120–125.

4:13a

Until I come,

- Until I arrive,
- Until I join you in Ephesus,

Until I come: Paul mentioned in 3:14a that he planned to visit Timothy in Ephesus. Presumably, when he arrived, he would give Timothy further instructions.

4:13b

devote yourself to the public reading of Scripture,

- take time to read the Scriptures aloud to the believers when they meet together.

devote yourself to: The Greek word that the BSB translates as devote yourself to means to occupy your time doing something or to work diligently at a task. In 4:13b–c, Paul told Timothy to devote himself to three things: reading, preaching, and teaching. In some languages, it may not be possible to use the same verb (devote yourself) with each of these tasks. Use what is appropriate in your language.

the public reading of Scripture: The Greek word that the BSB translates as public reading of Scripture is simply the word that means “reading.” In some languages, as in many English versions, it may be helpful to supply the following information:

1. Paul was talking about reading aloud in worship services.
2. Paul was referring to reading from the Bible. At the time when he wrote this letter, he was referring only to the Old Testament.

4:13c

to exhortation, and to teaching.

- Also take time to announce God’s word to them and explain to them what it means.

exhortation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as exhortation refers to announcing an important message. In this context, the message is what the Scripture says.

teaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as teaching refers, in this context, to instructing and training people about Scripture.

1 Timothy 4:14

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teach-

ing that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:11–16

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy how to convince people to accept his teaching, even though he was young. He told Timothy to be a good example for the other believers (4:12b). He told him to read the Scriptures to people and to teach them (4:13b). He also told Timothy to use the gift that God had given him (4:14a). This gift was the ability that God had given him to teach and to lead other people. Paul also told Timothy to keep progressing spiritually (4:15c), and to persevere (4:16b). Adapted from Stott, pages 120–125.

4:14a

Do not neglect the gift that is in you,

- Remember to do the task that God has given you the special ability for.
- Never stop doing the work which God made you able to do

Do not neglect: The Greek word that the BSB translates as neglect means “ignore, be unconcerned about.” Therefore, to not neglect something means to pay attention to it. Paul wanted Timothy to remember to use his gift. In some languages you may need to say this positively instead of negatively. For example, you could say:

Pay attention to [your gift]

the gift that is in you: This refers to some kind of special ability or talent that God gave to Timothy through the Holy Spirit. Paul did not make explicit what this gift was because, of course, Timothy already knew what it was. It probably included an ability to teach and preach.

In some languages, there is no noun that means “ability.” If this is true in your language, you could say:

the work that God made you able to do

Be careful to use a word for “work” that can include activities such as teaching and preaching.

4:14b

which was given you through the prophecy spoken over you

- This is the ability that you received through a message from God
- since you received his message about it

In 4:14b–c, Paul reminded Timothy about the way that he had received his gift from God.

which was given you: If you need to supply a subject here, you should say that God gave Timothy the gift.

prophecy spoken over you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prophecy refers to special messages that the Holy Spirit gives to people.

Paul was probably referring to a prophecy that one (or more) of the elders had received from God (4:14c). God probably told them to tell Timothy that God had given him the ability to preach and teach. Another example of a prophetic message is recorded in Acts 13:1–3.

4:14c

at the laying on of the hands of the elders.

- when the group of elders put their hands on your head.

at the laying on of the hands: In the Christian community, it was usual to place hands on a person to commission them for a special task. For example, the believers in Antioch commissioned Paul and Barnabas to go and preach the gospel in other places (Acts 13:3). Kelly, page 108, referring to Daube, says that the Greek for “laying on of the hands of the presbytery” “...is a rendering of the Hebrew *semikhah* *zeqenim*, a technical term whose literal translation is ‘the leaning-on of elders’, and which in effect meant, ‘the leaning, or pressing, of hands upon someone with the object of making him an elder or rabbi’....The net result is to confirm the traditional view that Timothy is a special, ad hoc apostolic delegate....” Here in 4:14, Paul was referring to the time when the elders stood around Timothy and placed their hands on him.

God had given Timothy the ability to preach and teach. This ceremony was intended to show the other believers in Ephesus that God had given Timothy those abilities.

Scripture does not say where the elders placed their hands, but it was probably on Timothy’s head.

of the elders: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the elders refers to a group or council of elders.

elders: This term refers to leaders of a local group of believers. The word “overseer” in 3:1b and 3:2a probably refers to the same people.

General Comment on 4:14a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder this verse. One way to do this is:

- ^{14c} Remember when the group of elders put their hands on you ^{14b}and God gave them a message to tell you about the special ability he had given you.
^{14a}Do not ignore that ability.

1 Timothy 4:15

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
2. He should be a good example to others (4:12b).
3. He should read aloud the Scriptures to encourage the believers to obey them (4:13b).

Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:11–16

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy how to convince people to accept his teaching, even though he was young. He told Timothy to be a good example for the other believers (4:12b). He told him to read the Scriptures to people and to teach them (4:13b). He also told Timothy to use the gift that God had given him (4:14a). This gift was the ability that God had given him to teach and to lead other people. Paul also told Timothy to keep progressing spiritually (4:15c), and to persevere (4:16b). Adapted from Stott, pages 120–125.

4:15a

Be diligent in these matters

- Do these things earnestly,
- Practice these things carefully

Be diligent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be diligent means to pay attention to something and to do it earnestly, with enthusiasm and energy. It means the opposite of “neglect.” See the note on 4:14a.

these matters: Paul was referring to all the things that he had written about in 4:11–14.

4:15b

and absorbed in them,

- and pay great attention to them,
- and devote yourself fully to them,

and absorbed in them: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as absorbed in them literally means “devote yourself to them” (4:13b). Paul used this expression to emphasize how important his instructions to Timothy were.

4:15c

so that your progress will be evident to all.

- so that everyone will be able to see that you are progressing in your ability to preach and teach.

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that connects 4:15c with 4:15a–b. In 4:15c, Paul explained the reason that Timothy should obey Paul’s instruction in 4:14a–b. The reason was so that other believers would see how he was progressing spiritually.

your progress: Paul expected people to see Timothy’s progress, but he did not say what he meant by progress. Paul was probably thinking about progress in Timothy’s faith, and he probably expected Timothy to be able to use his gift better (4:14a).

1 Timothy 4:16

Section 4:1–16: Paul told Timothy how to teach the believers

In this section, Paul warned Timothy against people who were teaching false doctrines. They were teaching that believers should not marry and that there were certain kinds of food that they should not eat. Paul told Timothy several things that he should do to oppose the errors of the false teachers. For example:

1. He should teach correct doctrines (4:11).
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Paul wanted Timothy to continue to do these things and not become discouraged.

Paragraph 4:11–16

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy how to convince people to accept his teaching, even though he was young. He told Timothy to be a good example for the other believers (4:12b). He told him to read the Scriptures to people and to teach them (4:13b). He also told Timothy to use the gift that God had given him (4:14a). This gift was the ability that God had given him to teach and to lead other people. Paul also told

Timothy to keep progressing spiritually (4:15c), and to persevere (4:16b). Adapted from Stott, pages 120–125.

4:16a

Pay close attention to your life and to your teaching.

- Be very careful in the way you behave and make very sure that what you teach about God is correct.

Pay close attention: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Pay close attention could also be translated as “focus on,” “be careful concerning,” “consider carefully.” The verb form in Greek suggests that Paul was commanding Timothy to continue to do something that he was already doing. He was not telling him to do something new. Paul was commanding Timothy to continue to pay careful attention to his behavior and what he taught.

your life: The Greek word that the BSB translates as your life is literally “yourself.” This refers to behavior. Paul was telling Timothy to pay attention to the way that he behaved as a believer.

your teaching: The word that the BSB translates as teaching refers to the facts that Christians should believe about God and Christ. These were the facts that Paul and other apostles accepted as true. This was what Paul had taught Timothy (4:6) and was now telling Timothy that he should teach other believers (4:13c). See the note on 1:10d.

4:16b

Persevere in these things,

- Persist in this
- Never give up doing this.

4:16c

for by so doing

- because if you do so
- In that way,

for by so doing: Here Paul told Timothy the reason that it was so important to persevere.

Paul was not implying that Timothy might not persevere. The form of the Greek verb indicates that Paul was reminding him to continue to do things that he was already doing. See the note on 4:16a.

4:16d

you will save both yourself and those who hear you.

- you will help yourself and also your hearers to reach complete salvation.
- God will save both you and those who listen to you.

you will save both yourself and those who hear you:

Paul was not saying that Timothy and the other believ-

ers in Ephesus were not saved. Rather here he used the future tense (will save) to refer to the time when believers arrive in heaven. At that time their salvation is complete. In heaven there is no more suffering or persecution.

Specifically Paul was saying Timothy’s teaching and preaching was the way in which God was confirming Timothy’s own salvation. God was also using that teaching and preaching to tell others about himself so that they also could be saved. The New Testament writers wrote in the same way elsewhere (for example, in 1 Corinthians 9:22).

1 Timothy 5:1

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:1–2

Paul told Timothy to treat all believers as if they were members of his family.

5:1a

Do not rebuke an older man,

- ¶ Do not harshly correct a man who is older than you are.
- ¶ Do not reprimand an older man in a disrespectful way.

Do not rebuke an older man: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as rebuke can also be translated “scold” or “correct severely.” This command and the following ones are addressed specifically to Timothy.

an older man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as an older man is the same one that Paul used in 4:14 to refer to a church leader. However, in this verse, Paul was referring to any man who was older than Timothy.

5:1b

but appeal to him as to a father.

- Instead, respectfully appeal to him as you would appeal to your own father.
- Rather, advise him respectfully, as if you were advising your own father.

but: The connector that the BSB translates as but indicates that 5:1b contrasts with 5:1a.

appeal to: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appeal to means “to exhort,” “to encourage,” “to advise strongly,” or “to urge earnestly.” Use a word or phrase in your language that expresses the way that a son might respectfully urge his father to do something.

as to a father: Paul was telling Timothy to treat older men in a way that showed that he respected them and loved them.

5:1c

Treat younger men as brothers,

- Act toward younger men as you would if they were your brothers.

Treat: In the Greek text, there is no verb in this part of the verse. The BSB has supplied the verb Treat. Or you might use the verb “exhort” from 5:1b. Paul wanted Timothy to show these men that he cared about them and that he was concerned for their welfare.

younger men: This probably refers to men who were younger than Timothy himself.

brothers: In some languages, it is necessary to differentiate between “older brothers” and “younger brothers.” If this is true in your language, use the term that means “younger brothers” here.

1 Timothy 5:2

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:1–2

Paul told Timothy to treat all believers as if they were members of his family.

5:2a

older women as mothers,

- Act toward older women as you would if they were your mother.

Again there is no verb in this part of the verse. If you need to supply a verb, you should probably use the same verb as you used in 5:1c.

older women as mothers: Paul wanted Timothy to treat older women in a way that showed that he respected and loved them. In other words, he wanted Timothy to speak to such women as though they were his own mother.

5:2b

and younger women as sisters,

- Act toward younger women as you would if they were your sisters.

As in 5:1c and 5:2a, there is no verb in this part of the verse. If you need to supply a verb, you should probably use the same verb as you used in 5:1c.

younger women as sisters: To treat a younger woman as a sister meant to honor and protect her.

5:2c

with absolute purity.

- Do not even think of sinning with them in any way.

with absolute purity: In this context the phrase that the BSB translates as with absolute purity means that Timothy was to avoid any sort of sexual sin when dealing with older or younger women. This included his thoughts and intentions toward these people as well as his actions.

1 Timothy 5:3

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:3–8

A community of believers should care for widows who have no family to care for them.

5:3

Honor the widows who are truly widows.

- ¶ Show widows who have no one to provide for them the respect that they deserve and care for them.

Honor the widows who are truly widows: In this context Honor especially refers to the way that Paul wanted Timothy (and others) to treat widows who were poor. He was to show that he respected them. He wanted people to show this respect by supporting them from the church offering so they could buy what they needed. Knight, page 216, speculates as to why the verb “to honor” is in the second person imperative, singular: “Paul may have been influenced by the second person singular imperative in the fifth commandment (LXX *τίμα* in Ex. 20:12 and Dt. 5:16, as here) and may have assumed that its application to all God’s people would be as obvious here as it is in the Ten Commandments.”

widows: A widow is a woman whose husband has died. At the time when Paul was writing this letter, widows usually had no goods or services to exchange for food or clothing. They had to receive care from close family. A widow with no husband or other close family had no way to feed or clothe herself.

who are truly widows: This refers to widows who did not have children or grandchildren who could care for them. The BSB’s literal translation could be confusing, because although a widow could have several wealthy children, she is, of course, still a widow. However she does not need support from the church because her family can care for her. So it is recommended that you do not translate the Greek literally here but follow the NIV (“widows who are really in need”) or the GNT (“widows who really are all alone.”)

1 Timothy 5:4

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:3–8

A community of believers should care for widows who have no family to care for them.

5:4a

But if a widow has children or grandchildren,

- But if a widow has children or grandchildren,

But: The Greek particle *de* that the BSB translates as *But* indicates that Paul was contrasting widows who had no family (5:3) with those who had a family (5:4a).

children or grandchildren: When Paul was saying children or grandchildren, he was referring to both men and women.

5:4b

they must first learn to show godliness

- those children and grandchildren should learn to practice being godly first of all
- they should begin to show that they believe in God

they must first learn: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *they must...learn* is a third-person command. That means that although Paul was giving the command to Timothy, he meant Timothy to pass it on to others. Paul was actually commanding the children and grandchildren to learn: it was their duty or obligation to take care of their families.

first: This means that one of the most important things for believers to do is to help their widowed mothers and grandmothers.

learn: In this context, the Greek word that the BSB translates as *learn* means to practice or learn by experience, rather than just from books or a teacher.

to show godliness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *to show godliness* means “to show piety, be reverent.” Usually this verb is used about reverence to God. However, here it means that believers should show their devotion to God by the way in which they treat their own family. This is their duty as believers.

5:4c

to their own family

- by caring for this member of their family.
- by the way that they care for this widow who is part of their own family.

to their own family: Believers should take practical care of family members; that is, they should make

sure that they have a place to live and enough to eat and wear.

their own family: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *family* literally means “house, household.” In Paul’s time, a “household” included servants as well as relatives such as grandparents (see the note on 3:12b). Paul wanted people to care for any widow in the household for whom they were responsible.

5:4d

and repay their parents,

- In this way they can repay their mother or grandmother for caring for them.

repay: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *repay* means “to pay something back.” When the believers were children, these women cared for them. Paul wanted the believers to care for their mothers or grandmothers in the same way now.

parents: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *parents* literally means “ancestors.” In this context, Paul was especially talking about mothers and grandmothers. This was because they were the ones who most urgently needed someone to support them when they became widows.

5:4e

for this is pleasing in the sight of God.

- For it pleases God when people do this.
- For this is what God wants people to do.

for: The connector *for* introduces the reason that children and grandchildren should care for their mothers and grandmothers.

pleasing in the sight of God: The phrase *pleasing in the sight of God* refers to the way that God wants people to act. He is pleased when they do so.

General Comment on 5:4a–e

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder this verse. For example, you may need to say first that children should take care of their own family. Then you could say that this is the way that they should learn to put their religion into practice. One way to do this is:

^{4a}But if a widow has children or grandchildren,
^{4c}these should take care of their own family ^{4d}and repay their parents and grandparents. ^{4b}This is the most important way for them to learn to put their religion into practice, ^{4e}and it is pleasing to God.

1 Timothy 5:5

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:3–8

A community of believers should care for widows who have no family to care for them.

5:5

5:5 is connected to 5:4 by the Greek particle *de* that is often translated as “but.” This particle shows that 5:5 contrasts with 5:4. This contrast is between two types of widows. The first type is a widow whom the church should not assist because she has a family (5:4). The second type is a widow whom the church should assist (5:5). The BSB leaves the particle untranslated. But you should express this contrast in the way that is most natural in your language.

5:5a

The widow who is truly in need and left all alone

- The widow who really needs the help of the believers is the one who has no family members still alive,

The widow who is truly in need: The Greek text literally says “the true widow.” Here Paul was talking about widows without families who really needed to be helped by the believers.

left all alone: The first characteristic of a widow who really needed help from other believers was that she was left all alone. Knight, page 218, says, “*καὶ μεμονωμένη* [=‘and having been left alone’], standing between the subject *χήρα* [=‘widow’] and the main verb, is in effect appositional to *ἡ ὄντως χήρα* [=‘the real widow’] and is the first and most basic description of such a person.” That is, she had no family members who could care for her. At the time when Paul lived, widows had no one but family to rely on for care. A widow with no family had no one to help her in any way.

5:5b

puts her hope in God

- who depends on God to help her,

puts her hope in God: This is the second characteristic of a widow who really needed the help of other believers (5:5a). She depended on God to give her what she needed.

5:5c

and continues night and day in her petitions and prayers.

- and who prays continually day and night and asks him to help her.

continues night and day in her petitions and prayers:

The third characteristic of a widow who really needed the help of other believers was that she prayed night and day. To pray night and day means that she prayed frequently and regularly, both during the daytime and the nighttime. REB has another interpretation: “...puts all her trust in God, and regularly, night and day, attends the meetings for prayer and worship.”

In Greek it is normal to say “night and day,” rather than “day and night.” In English it is the other way round. You should use the order that is most natural in your language.

1 Timothy 5:6

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:3–8

A community of believers should care for widows who have no family to care for them.

5:6a

But she who lives for pleasure

- But if a widow only does what she wants to do and not what God wants her to do,
- But widows who spend all their time amusing themselves

But she who lives for pleasure: Paul contrasted a “widow who is truly in need,” whom the believers should help, with the one who lives for pleasure. A widow who lives for pleasure thinks only about what she wants and not about what God wants. She will do whatever causes her to feel good even if she sins by doing it.

5:6b

is dead even while she is still alive.

- she is like a dead person even while she lives.
- are physically alive but spiritually dead.

is dead: A widow who lives for pleasure is obviously alive physically. Therefore when Paul said that she is dead, he meant that she was spiritually dead. That means that she has no real relationship with God.

Speakers of some languages may not use the word dead in this metaphorical way. Therefore they may find it very difficult to understand. If this is true in your area, you may need to say something like:

she lives cut off from God

her life counts for nothing good

In some languages people may be able to translate this as a simile and to say:

her soul is like a corpse

her heart is like it is dead, even though her body is alive

1 Timothy 5:7

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:3–8

A community of believers should care for widows who have no family to care for them.

5:7a

Give these instructions to the believers,

- Command the believers also to obey these orders about caring for widows

5:7 begins with the Greek connector *kai* that is often translated as “and” or “also.” Here, it probably means that Timothy should give these instructions “in addition to” the other instructions that Paul wanted Timothy to give to the believers.

Give these instructions to the believers: In the Greek text Paul did not say to whom Timothy was to give the instructions. The BSB has used the believers as the implicit object. There are two possibilities:

1. Timothy was to give the instructions to the believers in general. (BSB, NIV, NLT, CEV, NCV, REB)
2. Timothy was to give the instructions to the widows. (NJB, GNT)

Most English translations follow the Greek text and do not include an object. Therefore they are ambiguous. See the RSV, NASB, KJV, GW, and NET.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because in this context Paul was talking about the way that believers should help widows. Therefore it was more likely that he meant the instructions to be for the whole group of believers.

these instructions: The expression these instructions refers to Paul’s instructions about the widows in the preceding verses.

5:7b

so that they will be above reproach.

- in order that no one may be able to accuse them of wrong-doing.

so that they will be above reproach: This means, “so that other people will have no reason to criticize them.”

There are two ways to interpret the pronoun “they” in this context:

1. It refers to the believers. (BSB, NIV, NCV, CEV)
2. It refers to the widows. (NJB, REB, GW, probably also GNT, RSV, KJV, NASB, NET, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In 5:7a Paul told Timothy to command the believers to care for widows. Therefore, when Paul mentioned they here he was probably referring generally to believers and saying that no believer should be open to blame.

1 Timothy 5:8

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:3–8

A community of believers should care for widows who have no family to care for them.

5:8

In Greek this verse is connected to the previous verse with a particle, *de*. Here this particle indicates a contrast between Paul’s instructions in 5:7 and the behavior he described in 5:8a. Many English versions leave this connection implicit. But you should express this contrast in the way that is most natural in your language.

5:8a

If anyone does not provide for his own,

- If someone refuses to give his relatives what they need,
- Any believer who does not care for his relatives,

anyone: The Greek word that the BSB translates as anyone stresses that both males and females had the responsibility to provide for their relatives.

provide for: The word that the BSB translates as provide for refers to making sure that people have the basic necessities of life, such as food, water, clothing, and shelter.

his own: This phrase seems to refer to a wider circle of relatives than the term that Paul used in 5:8b, which the BSB translates as “his own household.”

5:8b

and especially his own household,

- especially his close family,

his own household: That is, those of his own immediate family. In the context, this term especially refers

to a believer's widowed mother or grandmother. See 5:4a and 5:4c.

5:8c

he has denied the faith

- he clearly does not really believe what he says he believes.
- shows that he does not really believe in Christ.

denied the faith: In this context, the expression that the BSB translates as denied the faith refers to a person whose actions contradict what he says that he believes. That is, the person may say he is a believer, but he does not care for his family in the way a believer should.

the faith: That is, the Christian religion or body of Christian teaching. See the note on the faith in 3:9. See faith, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

5:8d

and is worse than an unbeliever.

- He is behaving even worse than those who do not believe.

worse than an unbeliever: Paul included this phrase to remind the believers that even unbelievers normally cared for their widowed relatives. Therefore, people who called themselves believers should care for their widowed relatives. If they did not, they were behaving in a way that was worse than unbelievers.

1 Timothy 5:9

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:9–10

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy more about which widows the believers should care for.

Paul had previously stated some requirements for these widows, that is:

1. they had to be without a family who could support them (5:5a)
2. they had to be godly (5:5b and 5:5c)

But these were not the only requirements. In 5:9–10 Paul gave other requirements for widows. If they met those requirements, they could receive special care from the believers.

5:9a

A widow should be enrolled if she is at least sixty years old,

- ¶ Do not include a widow on the list of widows until she reaches sixty years of age.

- ¶ Do not write a widow's name on the list of widows whom the believers regularly support if the widow is younger than sixty.

A widow should be enrolled: In some languages it may be better to translate this as a direct active command:

Put on the list of widows [those widows who...]

A widow: In some languages it may be better to phrase this verse part negatively rather than positively; that is, to say which widows may not be put on the list for support. If this is true in your language, you could begin:

No widows should be enrolled who...

Paul was now only talking about those widows who had no family to help them.

should be enrolled: The phrase that the BSB translates as should be enrolled translates a Greek word that occurs only here in the New Testament. It means "enrolled, enlisted." It seems that the believers kept a list of Christian widows. This was probably a list of the widows for whom the believers regularly provided. The widows on this list probably did have a duty to spend their time serving people in special ways. Perhaps they did some of the things which Paul mentioned in 5:10a–f, such as raising children (perhaps orphans), showing hospitality, helping those in trouble, and doing other good deeds. Knight, pages 222 and 223, says, "So a church may have a list of elderly and godly widows who have no one else to care for them and who commit themselves to serving Christ. The church commits itself to assist these widows and in turn may ask them to perform certain tasks as need arises. Noting all the dimensions of this arrangement keeps one from drawing the false conclusion that the church does not help other widows who are either younger or who do not fully meet the requirements. But the passage does imply that the church enters into this permanent arrangement only with certain qualified widows and with mutually accepted commitments and possible responsibilities. Noting all the dimensions of the arrangement also guards against the erroneous conclusion that Paul is mandating a widows' organization in the church. The teaching of the passage is, rather, that the church only provides for widows which families do not. Thus, where every widow is provided for by her family there is no need for such a list. If, however, there needs to be a list, these are the requirements."

enrolled: In some languages, the concept of enrolling widows on a list may be difficult to translate. If this is true in your language, you could try translating using an expression like:

should be included in the group of widows whom the believers regularly help

at least sixty years old: At the time when Paul wrote, people considered those who had reached sixty years of age to be old people. Women who were over sixty years old did not usually remarry.

5:9b the wife of one man,

- She must also have been faithful to her husband.

the wife of one man: This is the second condition that a widow had to meet before being added to the list of widows. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the wife of one man can be understood in two ways:

1. She should have had sexual relations only with her husband (or husbands) and no one else. For example, the CEV says:

faithful in marriage (CEV, NIV, NLT, NCV)

1. She should have had only one husband her entire life, without ever remarrying. For example, the GNT says:

she must have been married only once (GNT, RSV, NET, REB, NJB, KJV, NASB, GW) See Kelly, page 116, for a defense of this second interpretation.

In 5:14a Paul recommended that younger widows remarry, so interpretation (2) is less likely. Also, Paul used the same Greek expression here that he used in 3:2b (except that here he said “woman” instead of “man”). It is therefore recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

1 Timothy 5:10

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:9–10

In this paragraph Paul told Timothy more about which widows the believers should care for.

Paul had previously stated some requirements for these widows, that is:

1. they had to be without a family who could support them (5:5a)
2. they had to be godly (5:5b and 5:5c)

But these were not the only requirements. In 5:9–10 Paul gave other requirements for widows. If they met those requirements, they could receive special care from the believers.

5:10a and well known for good deeds

- She must be a woman whom people recognize as one who does many kind and helpful things.

and well known for good deeds: This is the third main condition that a widow must fulfill to be included on the list of widows. Paul probably was not speaking about specific good deeds, but referring to the widow’s reputation as someone who frequently did good deeds.

In the rest of this verse Paul gave some examples of good deeds.

and well known: That is, other people know that she is the sort of person who helps others.

General Comment on 5:9a–10a

Paul here gave three conditions that were to be met before a widow could be enrolled or put on the list of widows. In some languages it might be better to make this clear by using three conditional or “if” clauses, like this:

Enroll a widow only if she is over sixty years old, if she has been faithful to her husband, and if people agree that she has always been busy doing good things.

5:10b such as bringing up children,

- For example, she raises children well,

such as: In the BSB, the words such as introduce a list of four specific kinds of good deeds (5:10b–e) for which the widow should be known.

bringing up children: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bringing up children refers to caring for children, providing for their physical needs, and training and teaching them what they need to know to be virtuous people.

children: These children may not have been her own children, but most likely her grandchildren. Use the most general word for children that you can.

5:10c entertaining strangers,

- she welcomes guests into her home,

entertaining strangers: Although the Greek word here is different from the one that the BSB translates as “hospitable” in 3:2d, the meaning is the same. A widow must also be a person who welcomes guests into her home for food and shelter.

5:10d washing the feet of the saints,

- she washes the feet of God’s holy people,

washing the feet of the saints: It was usual in Paul’s time for a guest’s feet to be washed when he arrived. In John 13:1–17, Jesus showed that washing someone else’s feet was an act of humility and love and that it was something believers should do for one another. However, in this context, scholars disagree about whether this expression should be understood:

1. literally (BSB, NIV, RSV, NJB, KJV, NASB, REB, NET, NCV)
2. figuratively. For example, the NLT says:

served other Christians humbly (GNT, CEV, GW, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and translate this literally. Paul was listing some specific good deeds and there is no reason to assume that he was speaking figuratively.

If your readers will not understand the reason that someone might wash someone else’s feet, you might need to add an explanation or a cross reference to John 13:1–17 in a footnote.

the saints: The Greek word for saints literally refers to “the holy ones” or “the sanctified ones.” The word saints refers to someone who believes in Christ.

5:10e imparting relief to the afflicted,

- and she helps people who have problems.

imparting relief to the afflicted: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the afflicted refers to people who are in distress, who are suffering in some way, or who are experiencing hardship/difficulties.

5:10f and devoting herself to every good work.

- She must have done many different things to help people.

- That is, she must be continually helping people in different ways.

devoting herself to every good work: This is a general statement that summarizes what Paul had just been saying. The widow must have been faithfully and consistently showing all sorts of kindness to people.

devoting herself to: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as devoting herself to means that she should occupy her time with doing good deeds or that she should work diligently to do good deeds. See also the note on 4:13b.

1 Timothy 5:11

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:11a But refuse to enroll younger widows.

- ¶ Concerning younger widows, do not write their names on the list of widows.

But refuse to enroll younger widows: The order of the words in the Greek text indicate that Paul was now focusing on the younger widows as his topic. The NIV shows this by saying, “As for younger widows,” but you should use a natural way in your language to show this focus.

But refuse to enroll: That is, they should not be put on the list mentioned in 5:9a.

younger widows: This Greek phrase refers to widows who were younger than sixty.

5:11b For when their passions draw them away from Christ,

- For when their human desire to live with a man again grows stronger than their promise to serve Christ as a widow,

For: This introduces the first reason that Paul gives for excluding younger widows from the list.

when their passions draw them away from Christ: The BSB phrase their passions draw them away translates a single Greek word. This word only occurs here in the New Testament. It implies that Paul did not expect these young women to be able to discipline or restrain their physical (sexual) desires. He expected these desires to grow and to become stronger than the women’s desire to serve Christ.

Christ: Notice that in this verse Paul refers to Jesus only using the name Christ. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

5:11c
they will want to marry,

- they want to marry again.

they will want to marry: It seems that these younger widows promised in some way that they would serve Christ as widows for the rest of their lives without remarrying. However later on, they change their mind. Paul was saying that it was not realistic for young widows to promise this because most young widows would want to remarry.

1 Timothy 5:12

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:12a
and thus will incur judgment

- By remarrying, they will cause themselves to be judged
- As a result, God will punish them

and thus: In this context the BSB has used the connector thus to mean “by doing this.” It introduces a sentence that explains what will happen to those widows who break their promise to Christ by remarrying.

will incur judgment: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as will incur judgment literally means “having judgment.” Scholars interpret this in two main ways:

1. God had reasons to judge Louw and Nida give the following for the meaning of krima (“to judge”): “(1) a legal decision (56.20); (2) the authority to judge (56.22); (3) a verdict, as the legal decision rendered by a judge, whether for or against the accused - ‘verdict, sentence, judgment’ (56.24); (4) condemnation, as to judge a person to be guilty and liable to punishment - ‘to judge as guilty, to condemn, condemnation’ (56.30); (5) a lawsuit (56.2); or (6) a judgment, as the content of the process of judging - ‘judgment, decision, evaluation’ (30.11). BAG says that the word means “ ‘a judicial verdict’ mostly in an unfavorable sense, of the ‘sentence of condemnation,’ also of the ‘condemnation’ and the subse-

quent ‘punishment’ itself.” these widows; that is, he would punish them in some way for not keeping their promise.

2. Other people had reasons to judge these women, that is, they would think badly about the widows because they had not kept their promise. The NJB followed this interpretation clearly:

people condemn them for...

Most English versions are ambiguous, though they seem to imply interpretation (1). It is recommended that you also follow interpretation (1). Paul was saying that in some way God would punish a widow who promised not to remarry and then broke that promise.

5:12b
because they are setting aside their first faith.

- because they have not kept their first promise.
- for not doing what they had promised to do.

their first faith: Paul did not specify to whom this first faith had been promised. There are two main possibilities:

1. The widow promised the first faith to the other believers when they put her name on the list. She was then promising to serve Christ without remarrying for the rest of her life. If she remarried, she would be promising her faith to her new husband and this would break her first faith. For example, the GNT says:

...Christ,¹² and so become guilty of breaking their earlier promise to him. (GNT, REB, CEV, NCV)

1. The widow promised the first faith to her first husband, which she breaks by remarrying.

Many English versions are ambiguous and do not specify to whom the first faith was promised. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul elsewhere recommends remarriage and does not consider it to be breaking a promise to the first husband.

1 Timothy 5:13

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:13a
At the same time they will also learn to be idle,

- As well as this, they get accustomed to idleness
- Also, the younger widows get used to doing nothing.

At the same time: Paul used the Greek word that the BSB translates as At the same time to introduce a second reason that younger widows should not be added to the list of widows.

they will also learn to be idle: The Greek term that the BSB translates as idle refers to not remaining busy, not working, and being lazy. Widows who were on the list were supported by the church. For that reason, they did not need to work to get the things they needed. As a result, some of them could get into the habit of doing nothing. Instead, they were supposed to use their time to help others.

5:13b

going from house to house

- and visiting in other people's homes.
- Rather than working, they spend their time visiting in the homes of various people.

going from house to house: Paul was saying that while these younger widows were idle, they began to spend their time going from house to house visiting people. One reason that they did this was to learn what these people were doing. Then they were gossiping about it with other people (5:13d). Some languages will have idiomatic and descriptive ways of speaking about these things.

5:13c

and being not only idle,

- Not only do they become lazy,
- And worse than being idle,

not only: Paul used the words that the BSB translates as not only to indicate that there were other things that young widows often did when they were not busy managing their homes (5:14c). It is implied that these things were even worse than just being idle.

5:13d

but also gossips and busybodies,

- but they also gossip and meddle with matters that are other people's responsibility.
- they also spend their time gossiping and interfering in other people's lives.

but also gossips and busybodies: The young widows were also acquiring two other bad habits: they were becoming gossips and busybodies.

gossips: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gossips refers to people who enjoy talking about other people when they are not present. Gossips also pass on rumors about other people.

busybodies: The Greek word that the BSB translates as busybodies refers to people who are curious and

meddlesome. This kind of person asks about what another person is doing. Then he or she gives people advice even though they have not asked for advice and do not want it. Your language may have an idiomatic way of saying this that you could use here.

5:13e

discussing things they should not mention.

- They talk about things that they should not talk about.

discussing things they should not mention: This part of the verse summarizes 5:13d. One of the reasons that it is wrong to gossip and be a busybody is that such a person says things that she ought not to.

1 Timothy 5:14

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:14a

So I advise the younger widows to marry,

- That is why I advise younger widows to marry again,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So introduces Paul's conclusion based on what he said in 5:11–13 about younger widows.

I advise the younger widows to marry: Paul advised Timothy to tell younger widows to remarry. Kelly, page 119, says, "It is often argued that this advice proves that the writer cannot be the Apostle, since in I Cor. vii. 25 ff., while not opposed to marriage, he gave it as his opinion that in view of the imminence of the Parousia it was better for the unmarried to remain so. But (a) his Corinthian ruling was given many years previously, and it is agreed that as he grew older his sense of the nearness of the Parousia became dimmer; and (b) that ruling was in any case a general one, whereas here he is dealing with the very special case of widows. It is clearly his view that it is ideally better for anyone, man or woman, whose partner has died to avoid a second marriage, but his good sense and realism make him encourage second marriages where the strain involved in remaining single would be too great. This, as a matter of fact, is exactly the position he adopts in I Corinthians, where we find him (vii. 9; 36) specifically recommending marriage for (a) unmarried people and widows, and (b) partners in spiritual celibacy, provided they find it impossible to control their passions." He did so because he especially did not want the young widows to face the temptations listed in 5:11–13.

5:14b

have children,

- and have children,

have children: That is, to give birth to children. It is implied that Paul expected the mothers to take care of those children.

5:14c

and manage their households,

- and supervise their households,
- They should keep busy caring for their home and family.

and manage their households: The phrase manage their households means to do all the things that women had to do to ensure that they had properly cared for their families. Although the BSB translates the Greek word in the same way as in 3:4, the word is different.

5:14d

denying the adversary occasion for slander.

- and not provide the enemy with any reason to speak evil about them.
- In that way, they will not be giving those who oppose us^(incl) an excuse to criticize them.

denying the adversary occasion for slander: Paul wanted the younger widows to behave well so that no one would have an excuse to criticize the Christians.

the adversary: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the adversary is literally “the one oppressing.” In this verse it can refer to either:

1. the devil
2. any person who opposes Christians and Christianity (NCV says “no enemy”; GNT says “our enemies”)

Most translations do not explain who the enemy is. It is recommended that you use as general a word as possible in your translation. If you must be specific, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was probably talking about the devil. However, one way that the devil slanders Christians is causing people to criticize them.

slander: The Greek word that the BSB translates as slander means “speaking against,” “insulting.” The English word slander implies that someone is saying something false. However the Greek word can also refer to saying true things to insult people. Louw and Nida (33.393) define the Greek word (*loidoria*) as “to speak in a highly insulting manner.” However, Kittel (TDNT abridged in 1 volume, page 538) says that the word group has the sense of “reproach, insult, calumny, and even blasphemy.”

1 Timothy 5:15

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:15

For some have already turned aside to follow Satan.

- For some of the younger widows have already turned away from God and started to follow Satan instead.
- I say this because some have already stopped obeying God and are doing what Satan wants them to do instead.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For is a conjunction, *gar*. This conjunction indicates that 5:15 is a reason for Paul’s instruction in 5:14.

some: That is, some of the younger widows.

already: The Greek word that the BSB translates as already is the first word in the verse, and so it is being emphasized. This emphasis indicates that this verse is a warning. Paul was warning Timothy that some widows were already starting to follow Satan. So his instructions in 5:14 were very important.

turned aside to follow Satan: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as turned aside to follow Satan literally means “turned away after Satan.” Paul meant that some of the younger widows had stopped obeying God. They were now doing things that Satan wanted them to do.

Satan: Satan is the supreme evil spiritual being who leads and directs all other evil spiritual beings. In other parts of the New Testament he is referred to as “the devil” or “the Evil One.”

Satan is a proper name. So keep that name in your translation if you can. However, in some languages, it may be necessary to explain that he is the chief of the evil spirits. See Satan in the Glossary. Also see the note on 1:20b.

1 Timothy 5:16

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:16

In 5:16 Paul summarized what he had been teaching about widows in the earlier part of the chapter. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that this is a summary. For example, you could start the verse with a phrase like:

I say again...

5:16a**If any believing woman has dependent widows,**

- ¶ If any woman who believes in Christ has widows in her family,
- ¶ So, women who believe in Christ who have any widows in their family

If any believing woman has dependent widows:

Some of the older translations, like the KJV, say “man or woman,” instead of only saying “woman.” The KJV says, “If any man or woman that believeth have widows....” However, “woman” is probably the correct text. The Editorial Committee of the UBS New Testament (4th edition) gives the reading “believing woman” a {C} rating, indicating that the Committee had difficulty in deciding which variant to place in the text. Metzger, page 642, says, “...a majority of the Committee, observing that the shorter reading is somewhat better attested than the longer reading, regarded the latter as a natural expansion made by copyists who, in light of ver. 4, felt that a restriction of the principle of this verse to Christian women was unfair.” Paul knew that some of the believing women in Ephesus had widows in their families. Therefore, in some languages, it will not be possible to use an “if” clause here. If that is true in your language, you could say:

Believing women who have widows in their families should...

believing woman: Paul only mentioned women believers here. However, 5:8 makes it clear that men also had this duty. See the note on 5:8a.

dependent widows: Paul used widows^(plur) here because a woman might have more than one widow to care for. For example, she may need to care for her mother, her mother-in-law and her grandmother.

5:16b**she must assist them**

- she should be the one to help them
- should care for them.

5:16c**and not allow the church to be burdened,**

- and not expect the other believers to take that responsibility.
- They should not leave it to the other believers to provide for them.

not allow the church to be burdened: This phrase indicates that believers should not need to care for widows who had families of their own. A literal translation would be difficult in many languages. Some

ways that may make the meaning clearer are, For example:

it is not right for her to ask the church to take care of them

she should not give the church the responsibility of providing for the widows in her family

church: The Greek word that the BSB translates as church does not refer to a church building, but to all true believers. Together they form the assembly or community of God’s people. Avoid using a term that might suggest that Paul was referring to a building. Some ways to translate the term church are:

the assembly of God’s people

the community of God’s people

God’s family

God’s people

See also the notes on 3:5b and 3:15c.

5:16d**so that it can help the widows who are truly in need.**

- This is so that the community of believers can help the widows who really need it.
- Then the other believers will be able to provide for those widows who have no one else to help them.

so that it can help the widows who are truly in need:

This part of the verse tells the purpose for which Paul gave his command in the rest of 5:16. He wanted to ensure that the believers had enough resources to help the widows who had no family.

it: Here, the pronoun it refers to the church. See the note on 5:16c.

the widows who are truly in need: This is the same phrase that was used in 5:3.

1 Timothy 5:17**Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers****Paragraph 5:17–18**

Paul said that the believers should respect their leaders. They should give them money or other things to help them.

5:17a**Elders who lead effectively are worthy of double honor,**

- ¶ Elders who are leading the church well deserve double respect,
- ¶ The believers should respect and generously help those who lead well,

Elders: This term refers to leaders of local groups of believers. The word “overseers” in 3:1b and 3:2a probably refers to the same people. See also the note on 3:8a.

who lead effectively: If you need to say who these elders are leading, you could say, “the church” to indicate the specific context in which these elders direct and lead.

are worthy of: That is, deserve.

double honor: The expression that the BSB translates as double honor could mean either:

1. that believers should honor the elders in two ways: by respecting them and by helping them materially.
2. that believers should honor the elders by helping them materially twice as much as they help other leaders. For example, the CEV says:

deserve to be paid twice as much (CEV, GNT, NLT, REB, probably the NJB)

Most English versions translate this phrase literally and therefore are ambiguous. If you can translate this verse in a way that can allow both these interpretations, you should do so. However, if you must be explicit, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Fee, pages 128 and 129, says, “It is clear from verse 18 that honor (see on v. 3) here includes at least pay. But it is highly unlikely that double honor means “double pay” (as cash), implying either twice as much as others who do not teach or twice as much as the widows. Rather it means “twofold honor,” the honor and respect due those in such positions as well as remuneration.” When Paul talked about double honor, he was talking about two different ways in which believers should honor the elders. He did not mean that believers should give the elders twice the material rewards they gave other people.

honor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as honor is closely related to the Greek word that the BSB translates as “honor” in 5:3. In 5:3, Paul was talking primarily about honoring widows by ensuring that they had the material things that they needed. In 5:18,

Paul also talked about material help. The GNT shows this by translating honor as “pay.”

5:17b**especially those who work hard at preaching and teaching.**

- especially those who have been given the task of preaching and teaching.
- particularly those who teach and who preach God’s message.

especially: The Greek word *malista* that the BSB translates as especially means “particularly,” “above all.” It seems to suggest that there were different kinds of elders among the Ephesian elders. Some preached and taught, but others may have done other things, like visit sick people. Paul was saying that believers should especially honor the elders who preached and taught.

preaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preaching refers to announcing an important message. In this context, it refers to encouraging and urging people to obey God.

teaching: In this context, teaching refers to teaching people about God.

General Comment on 5:17b

In some languages, it may be more logical to reverse the order of the verbs and translate this part of the verse:

especially those whose work is teaching people about God and telling them to obey him.

1 Timothy 5:18**Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers****Paragraph 5:17–18**

Paul said that the believers should respect their leaders. They should give them money or other things to help them.

5:18a**For the Scripture says,**

- As is written in the Scripture,

For: The word that the BSB translates as For indicates that 5:18 is the reason that believers should give generously to help the elders. Paul used an example from the Old Testament.

Scripture: See the note on 4:13b.

says: The Greek word that the BSB translates as says is in the present tense, even though the Scriptures were

written many years before. This is natural in Greek and English. Use the tense that is most natural in your language.

5:18b

“Do not muzzle an ox while it is treading out the grain,”

- “Do not tie up the ox’s mouth to keep it from eating grain as it threshes it.”

This Scripture is in Deuteronomy 25:4.

Do not muzzle an ox while it is treading out the grain: Paul mentioned this Old Testament verse to explain the reason that believers should give generously to help the elders. It was part of the laws that God gave the Israelites many centuries before. It literally meant that farmers should not force an ox to work without letting it eat while it was working. Here Paul used this law as a figure of speech. In this context, the law meant that believers should also not expect an elder to preach and teach without paying him.

muzzle: To muzzle an ox means to put something over its mouth so that it cannot eat.

ox: An ox (plural “oxen”) is a kind of large cow or bull. An ox is very strong, and farmers use oxen for farm work. For example, oxen are used to pull carts or ploughs.

treading out the grain: Here, treading out the grain is an example of the kind of work that an ox did. When a crop such as wheat was harvested, the farmers needed to separate the kernels from the cut stalks. They did this by making an ox walk over the stalks many times.

grain: The word grain refers to the seeds of various types of grasses such as wheat, barley, oats, and millet that people use for food.

5:18c

and, “The worker is worthy of his wages.”

- and “The worker deserves to receive his pay from the one who hired him.”
- and “Workers are entitled to their salary.”

The worker is worthy of his wages: Here Paul quoted something that Jesus had said (Luke 10:7).

General Comment on 5:18a–c

In some languages it may be helpful to make Paul’s comparison explicit in this verse. One way you could do this is:

For the Scripture says, “Do not muzzle the ox while it is treading out the grain,” and “The

worker deserves his wages.” In the same way, those who teach the believers deserve to receive money/help from them.

1 Timothy 5:19

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:19a

Do not entertain an accusation against an elder,

- ¶ Do not accept an accusation against an elder
- ¶ Do not listen to someone who accuses an elder of sinning

Do not entertain an accusation: This is a command addressed to Timothy. In this context, the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Do not entertain an accusation is more clearly translated as:

Do not accept an accusation

an elder: See the note on 5:17a.

5:19b

except on the testimony of two or three witnesses.

- unless two or three people accuse him of the same thing.

except on the testimony of two or three witnesses:

This part of the verse refers to the normal Jewish practice of requiring two or three witnesses to accuse an elder. This rule was in the laws given to Moses (Deuteronomy 19:15). Jesus also quoted it in Matthew 18:16. There needed to be at least two witnesses, or better three witnesses, before a person could be considered guilty.

witnesses: A witness in this context is a person who has seen or heard the elder sin.

1 Timothy 5:20

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:20a

But those who persist in sin should be rebuked in front of everyone,

- Publicly reprimand an elder who sins
- When you know that it is true that an elder has sinned, then rebuke him in front of the other believers

But those who persist in sin: The context indicates that Paul was referring to elders. It may be helpful in

some languages to make this explicit. For example, the GW says:

Reprimand those leaders who sin.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as those who... sin is in the present tense. Paul may have used the present tense for one of two reasons:

1. He was telling Timothy what he should do if an elder became guilty of a particular sin and did not repent of it, even if he only did it once. For example, the NJB says:

If anyone is at fault (NJB, NIV, GNT, KJV, NET, GW, NLT, REB)

1. Paul was telling Timothy what he should do if an elder was continuing to sin in a specific manner. For example, the RSV says:

those who persist in sin (BSB, RSV, NASB, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Knight, page 236, says, “The present active participle *τοὺς ἁμαρτάνοντας* [=‘the ones sinning’] is understood by some to denote continued or persistent sinning (cf. NASB: ‘those who continue in sin’; RSV, ‘those who persist in sin’). One implication would be that a person who is found to have sinned but is not at the moment engaged in the sin should not be dealt with as this verse indicates. Although the note of persistence may be intended by Paul, the more probable understanding is that the accusation is found to be true and the present tense is used to designate present guilt (GNT and NEB: ‘those who commit sins’). It is the committing of sin that is at issue.” It does not seem from the context that Paul was talking about whether or not elders persist in sinning. Rather, he was talking about what believers should do when several people accuse an elder of some sin.

should be rebuked in front of everyone: Paul was telling Timothy that he should confront the leader about his sin in front of all the other believers and tell him that he has sinned.

5:20b

so that the others will stand in fear of sin.

- so that other elders will be afraid to sin.

so that: This Greek word that the BSB translates as so that indicates the purpose for which Timothy should rebuke the elder publicly.

the others: This can refer to:

1. only the other elders (GW)
2. all the other believers (CEV)

Most English versions do not specify who the others are. However the most natural understanding of the context suggests that Paul was referring to the other elders. Therefore, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

will stand in fear of sin: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as will stand in fear of sin literally means “may have fear.” If an elder was rebuked in front of other believers, he would be ashamed. When the other elders saw how ashamed the elder was, they would be afraid to sin. They would want to avoid the same shame.

1 Timothy 5:21

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:21a

I solemnly charge you before God and Christ Jesus and the elect angels

- I solemnly command you with God the Father, Christ Jesus, and the chosen angels as witnesses,
- With God, Christ Jesus and the angels that God has chosen watching us ^(incl), I command you to do this important thing, that is,

I solemnly charge you: The word that the BSB translates as I solemnly charge you means that Paul was commanding Timothy to do something very important.

before God and Christ Jesus and the elect angels:

Paul added this phrase to emphasize that what he was commanding Timothy to do was very important indeed. He was implying that God, Jesus and even the angels would witness whether Timothy obeyed Paul or not.

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Some people, however, think that when Paul used the word Christ before the word Jesus, as in Christ Jesus, he was emphasizing that Jesus was the Messiah.

In most English versions “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur

in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

However, it is possible that, in some languages, people may be confused to see the names in two different orders. They may even think that Paul was referring to two different people. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ.” This is the more usual word order in the New Testament.

Christ: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

the elect angels: Paul referred to the angels here by a word that the BSB translates as elect. This word indicates here that God had chosen the angels.

angels: In this context, the word that the BSB translates as angels refers to “a supernatural, spiritual being who is a messenger from God.” See the note on 3:16d.

5:21b

to maintain these principles without bias,

- to do what I have instructed you to do without discriminating

maintain these principles: That is, follow or obey these instructions.

these principles: The phrase these principles refers to what Paul told Timothy to do in 5:19–20, which was to rebuke elders who had sinned. Arichea and Hatton, page 130, say, “...verse 21 is better interpreted as looking back than forward. For one thing, the instructions that follow verse 21 seem to be less serious than the subject matter of the preceding verses. For another thing, verses 17–20 deal with one subject matter, whereas verses 22–25 deal with a combination of topics without any apparent unity.”

without bias: The phrase that the BSB translates as without bias means to do something without being biased for or against a person. Timothy was to treat every elder the same way.

5:21c

and to do nothing out of partiality.

- or showing any sort of favoritism.
- or favoring one person above another.

do nothing out of partiality: The phrase that the BSB translates as out of partiality is similar in meaning to the phrase “without bias” in 5:21b. Timothy was to treat every elder the same. It should not matter whether or not the elder was a good friend, or wealthy, or powerful, or popular.

General Comment on 5:21b–c

The Greek words that the BSB translates as “bias” and “partiality” mean almost the same thing. Paul probably used both words to emphasize what he was saying. In some languages, there may not be two such similar words. If this is true in your language, you may say something like:

Do not discriminate in any way.

Be completely fair/just in the way you treat people.

1 Timothy 5:22

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

5:22a

Do not be too quick in the laying on of hands

- Do not appoint someone as a leader by putting your hands on him until you have tested him.
- Do not lay your hands on someone to ordain him until he has proved he is faithful to Christ.

Do not be too quick in the laying on of hands: Here Paul implied that Timothy should be careful when he chose people to appoint as new leaders for the community of believers.

Do not be too quick: Paul did not want Timothy to appoint new elders too quickly. In other words, he wanted Timothy to ensure that the person was qualified to be a good elder. Timothy was to be sure that the candidate really was “above reproach” (3:2a).

the laying on of hands: The phrase the laying on of hands refers to the way that Timothy, along with other leaders of the believers, appointed a person to be an elder. They stood around a person, placed their hands upon him and prayed for him.

5:22b

and thereby share in the sins of others.

- Otherwise, you also will be responsible for his sins.
- If you do, it will be as if you too are guilty of his sins.

and thereby share in the sins of others: Paul did not want Timothy to appoint any man to be an elder before

Timothy really knew the man's character. If Timothy did appoint an elder and later the elder sinned, Timothy would then share in the sins of that elder. That means that Timothy would be partly responsible for the sins that the elder committed.

others: This refers in general to elders who sin.

5:22c

Keep yourself pure.

- Make sure that you yourself do not sin.

yourself: Paul used the emphatic pronoun that the BSB translates as yourself to emphasize that Timothy needed to take care not to sin himself.

pure: To be pure means to be free from sin. Timothy needed to avoid having sinful habits or sinning in any major way. If he avoided sin, he would be a good example for the other believers. If he did not stay away from sin, he would be a bad example.

1 Timothy 5:23

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:23

Paul told Timothy in 5:22c to keep himself pure so that he could appoint elders effectively. In this paragraph he made a brief comment to Timothy about wine. Then he resumed his instructions in 5:24 about appointing elders.

5:23a

Stop drinking only water and use a little wine instead,

- ¶ Stop drinking only water, and also drink a little wine
- ¶ Do not keep on drinking only water. Include some wine

Stop drinking only water and use a little wine instead:

During the time when Timothy lived, people frequently drank wine. However, if a person drank too much wine, he would become drunk. See the note on 3:8b.

Apparently Timothy had only been drinking water and not drinking any wine. Paul told him that to drink a little wine as medicine was acceptable.

little: Paul did not define how much “wine” Timothy should drink, but it was a small quantity. It was not enough to make Timothy drunk.

5:23b

because of your stomach

- to help your stomach

- because of the problems you have with your stomach

5:23c

and your frequent ailments.

- since it causes you to be ill so often.
- since your stomach problems make you ill so often.

5:23b–c

your stomach and your frequent ailments: There are two ways to interpret these words:

1. These expressions refer to the same thing. That is, Timothy's frequent illnesses were stomach problems. For example, the GNT says:

to help your digestion, since you are sick so often (GNT, NLT, GW)

1. These expressions refer to different illnesses. In addition to Timothy's stomach problems, he was also often sick with some other illnesses. For example, the CEV says:

your stomach trouble and the other illnesses you always have

Other versions are a little ambiguous, but most likely follow interpretation (2).

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The illnesses were stomach problems that go away when people drink a little wine.

General Comment on 5:23a–c

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder this verse. For example:

Because your stomach makes you ill so often, try drinking a little wine instead of only water.

1 Timothy 5:24

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:24–25

In this paragraph Paul resumed his instructions to Timothy about elders. He stated why Timothy should not be quick to appoint them.

5:24a

The sins of some men are obvious,

- ¶ Some men sin so blatantly
- ¶ Some people sin openly.

The sins of some men are obvious: That is, these sins are not done in secret. They are conspicuous or clear to everyone.

some men: The context shows that Paul was especially referring to some of those men whom Timothy might consider choosing as elders.

men: The word that the BSB translates as men here does not only refer to males. It includes all human beings: men, women, and children.

5:24b

going ahead of them to judgment;

- that you will know about it, even before you examine how they behave.

going ahead of them to judgment: Sometimes, people sin in ways that other people can easily see or discover. Timothy and other church leaders knew that those people had sinned. So they would not need to examine or consider them as possible elders.

judgment: Timothy was going to judge whether men were suitable to be elders or not. Paul used the Greek word that the BSB translates as judgment to refer to the situation that Timothy was going to be in when he judged people.

5:24c

but the sins of others do not surface until later.

- But other men's sins are not known about for a long time.
- But other people sin secretly, and no one knows about it until much later.

the sins of others do not surface until later: Other people sin secretly and their sin may not be obvious until after they have sinned. Timothy had to be careful when he chose new elders. He needed to take time to observe their behavior carefully.

1 Timothy 5:25

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 5:24–25

In this paragraph Paul resumed his instructions to Timothy about elders. He stated why Timothy should not be quick to appoint them.

5:25a

In the same way, good deeds are obvious,

- In the same way, the good things that some people do are clear to everyone.
- In a similar way, sometimes people behave in kind/helpful ways and everybody knows about it.

In the same way: It can take time to learn about how a person has sinned. In the same way, it can also take some time to learn about the good deeds that a person does.

good deeds are obvious: This is the parallel expression to 5:24a. Paul said that not all good deeds are obvious, and you may need to indicate that here in 5:25a.

good deeds: In some languages it may be necessary to translate deeds using a verb. It may be possible to say “behave well” or “do things to help other people.”

5:25b

and even the ones that are inconspicuous cannot remain hidden.

- Even when the good things that they do are not clear immediately, people will certainly recognize later what they have done.
- But other times people behave in kind/helpful ways, and others do not recognize it immediately. Nevertheless, their good deeds will be known later.

even the ones that are inconspicuous cannot remain hidden: Some “good deeds” are not immediately obvious. But in time all “good deeds” will be known.

General Comment on 5:25b

In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning of this verse part more explicit. For example:

But other people do good in ways that people do not learn about immediately. Nevertheless, people will certainly learn later what they have done.

But other times people do not learn about the kind/helpful things that others do at the time when they do them. Nevertheless, people will certainly learn later what they have done.

1 Timothy 6:1

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 6:1–2e

Paul next told Timothy what he should teach believers who were slaves. Some slaves who had become Christians seem to have started to disrespect or disobey their masters. Perhaps they felt that they should only obey God and that they no longer had to obey their masters. Paul told Timothy that he should teach slaves to respect their masters.

6:1a

All who are under the yoke of slavery

- ¶ Every believer who is forced to be a slave
- ¶ All believers who are slaves

All who are under the yoke of slavery: That is, all slaves. But Paul was instructing believers in this letter, so here he was only speaking about slaves who were believers.

under the yoke of slavery: The phrase under the yoke of slavery is a figure of speech. A yoke is a wooden frame that is usually very heavy. Normally it is placed over the necks of two animals to join them together, so that together they can pull something. The animals cannot free themselves from the yoke. Therefore, a yoke became a symbol of slavery.

6:1b

should regard their masters as fully worthy of honor,

- should treat his master as if he deserved the greatest respect,
- should honor their masters in every way,

should regard their masters as fully worthy of honor:

Paul meant that a slave should have a respectful attitude toward the person who owned him. He should be obedient and work hard. His owner might be cruel and not really deserve respect, but Paul said that the slave should still treat him as if he did deserve respect. In Colossians 3:22 and Ephesians 6:5 Paul spoke in more detail about the way that a slave should respect his master.

masters: The masters were the people who owned the slaves.

fully worthy of honor: That is, fully deserve. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as fully worthy of honor literally means “all honor.” Paul used the word “all” to add emphasis and intensity. Slaves would give this honor primarily by obeying their masters.

6:1c

so that God’s name and our teaching will not be discredited.

- so that God’s name and our^(incl) teaching may not be insulted.
- so that other people will not insult God and say that what we^(incl) teach is untrue.

so that: The word that the BSB translates as so that indicates that 6:1c is an important reason why slaves should treat their masters with respect.

God’s name: The expression that the BSB translates as God’s name does not refer to the name by which God was called. It refers to his character, and the kind of being he is. Many languages do not speak

of someone’s name to refer to the person himself. Therefore, in some languages it may be necessary to translate God’s name here simply as “God.”

our teaching: When Paul mentioned our teaching, he was referring to the gospel. In other words, he was talking about what he taught about God and Christ.

our: Here Paul was referring to himself, Timothy, and other leaders among the believers.

discredited: The verb that the BSB translates as discredited here is often translated as “blasphemed.” It means to speak evil about someone or something. If believing slaves did not respect or obey their masters, then unbelievers would insult the gospel and God himself.

1 Timothy 6:2

Section 5:1–6:2: Paul told Timothy how to treat different groups of believers

Paragraph 6:1–2e

Paul next told Timothy what he should teach believers who were slaves. Some slaves who had become Christians seem to have started to disrespect or disobey their masters. Perhaps they felt that they should only obey God and that they no longer had to obey their masters. Paul told Timothy that he should teach slaves to respect their masters.

6:2a

Those who have believing masters should not show disrespect

- If their masters are believers in Christ,, then the slaves should not think that they can respect/obey them less than masters who do not believe
- Those slaves who have masters who are also believers must be as respectful to them as to any master

Those who have believing masters: Here Paul talked about slaves whose masters were believers.

should not show disrespect: The Greek word that the BSB translates as show disrespect literally means “despise” or “look down on.” In other letters Paul commanded believing masters to be kind to their slaves (Ephesians 6:9; Colossians 4:1). Some slaves might try to take advantage of such kindness and therefore show them disrespect. Paul wanted to make sure that that did not happen.

6:2b

because they are brothers,

- because they are brothers in Christ.
- because their masters are spiritually their brothers.

because they are brothers: There are two ways to understand this clause:

1. The word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason that slaves might not respect their masters as they should. If both the slave and the master were believers, they were equal before Christ (Galatians 3:28). Therefore some slaves may have thought that they could treat their masters with less respect because they were equal. For example, the NCV says:

The slaves whose masters are believers should not show their masters any less respect because they are believers. (BSB, NCV, NIV, RSV, NJB, NASB, REB, NET, NLT)

1. The word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason that slaves should not disrespect masters who were believers. They should respect them because they were also believers. For example, the GNT says:

Slaves belonging to Christian masters must not despise them, for they are believers, too. (GNT, CEV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Later in this verse, Paul added the information in interpretation (2).

6:2c

but should serve them all the more,

- Instead, they should work even better/harder for them,

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but introduces the contrast Paul was making. Paul expected believing slaves to respect their unbelieving masters (6:1). Here he was contrasting that with the way he expected them to respect believing masters. He expected them to respect them more.

should serve them all the more: The word that the BSB translates as serve means “work for,” “obey,” or “do the work of a slave.”

all the more: Paul assumed that believing slaves knew that they needed to serve their unbelieving masters well. Here he said that believing slaves should serve their believing master even better than they would serve an unbelieving master.

6:2d

since those receiving their good service

- because the masters for whom they are working

since: The word that the BSB translates as since indicates that 6:2d–e gives a reason that slaves should especially work hard for Christian masters.

those receiving their good service: This refers to the masters for whom the slaves worked.

their good service: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good service literally means “act of kindness.” The slave was acting kindly toward his Christian master by working for him and helping him in practical ways.

6:2e

are beloved believers.

- are also believers, and they love them as brothers in Christ.

are beloved believers: If somebody is dear to a person, it means that the person loves him. The Greek text does not say who loved the masters. There are two interpretations:

1. The slaves loved the masters. For example, the NIV says:

dear to them (NIV, GNT, NCV, GW)

1. God or Christ loved the masters. For example, the CEV says:

he loves them (CEV, NJB)

Some English versions are ambiguous. It is true that God and Christ loved the masters. However, it is more likely in this context that Paul was talking about love between believers. So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was saying that if Christian slaves had Christian masters, they should show that they loved them by serving them well.

General Comment on 6:2c–e

In some languages, it is necessary to state the reason for something before the conclusion. If this is true in your language, you may need to place 6:2c after 6:2d–e. One possibility is:

^{2d}The masters whom they serve ^{2e}are believers, and the slaves love them as they love other believers. ^{2c}That is why they should serve them even better.

Paragraph 6:2f–g

Most English versions begin a new paragraph here because these verse parts refer to all believers, not

just the slaves whom Paul had been talking about in 6:1–2.

6:2f

Teach and encourage these principles.

- ¶ Teach the believers these things which I am writing to you and encourage them to do them.

Teach and encourage these principles: Paul was referring to what he had written from 5:3 to 6:2e.

and encourage: Paul wanted Timothy not only to teach believers these things, but also to exhort them to obey these things.

1 Timothy 6:3

Section 6:3–10: Paul warned that it was dangerous to want to be rich

In this section Paul warned Timothy once more about the false teachers. He also told him that it was dangerous to want a lot of money. He told him that the false teachers were sinning in many ways, but that they were especially sinning by trying to use religion to get more money. He told believers to be content with what they had.

The paragraphs in this section are:

Paragraph 6:3–5: The false teachers taught things about Christ and his message that were incorrect. They discussed unimportant issues that caused arguments. They did not understand how to distinguish between what was true and what was false. They thought that teaching about God was merely an effective way to become rich.

Paragraph 6:6–10: People think that they need to be rich in order to be happy. But the truth is that a person is happy only when he obeys God.

6:3a

If anyone teaches another doctrine

- ¶ Whoever teaches different ideas
- ¶ Some people are teaching things that are untrue

If anyone teaches another doctrine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *If* often introduces a conditional clause. However, in this context the clause it introduces is not really a conditional clause. Paul knew there were people among the Ephesian believers who taught another doctrine. In some languages this can be made clearer by saying “Anyone who...” or “Whoever...”

teaches another doctrine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *teaches another doctrine* literally means “teaches what is different” or “teaches what

is untrue.” The same phrase is used in 1:3d. Paul was warning Timothy against people who taught something different from what Paul himself taught. For example, the CEV says:

Anyone who teaches something different...

6:3b

and disagrees with the sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ

- and does not agree with the correct teaching that our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ gave
- and that are not consistent with the accurate things that our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ taught.

disagrees: The false teachers taught things about Christ and his message that were different from what Christ and his apostles taught.

the sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ: Paul told Timothy that the sound words were of our Lord Jesus Christ. Scholars have understood this in two ways:

1. It means “from our Lord Jesus Christ” and refers to what Christ taught, both when he was alive on earth and through his apostles.
2. It means “about our Lord Jesus Christ” and refers to the things that the apostles taught about Christ.

Most English versions say “the sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ,” which is ambiguous. However, this phrase is most naturally understood as the words spoken by Christ. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

the sound words: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *sound* literally means “healthy.” See the note on 1:10d, where the same Greek word is used. Paul was saying that these words were correct and without error.

our: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Lord* is a general word that means “master.” It was used to address any respected person. Here it refers to Christ. You could translate it as “owner” or “chief.”

Jesus Christ: Notice that in this verse Paul used the more usual order *Jesus Christ* to refer to Jesus. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

Christ: The word *Christ* is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, *Christ* is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word *Christ* was used as another name

for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

6:3c and with godly teaching,

- and with instruction that honors God,
- They also do not teach things which help people to behave as God wants.

godly teaching: When he used the words godly teaching, Paul was talking about the kind of teaching that helps people to behave as God wants them to behave.

godly: See godliness, godly in the Glossary.

1 Timothy 6:4

Section 6:3–10: Paul warned that it was dangerous to want to be rich

In this section Paul warned Timothy once more about the false teachers. He also told him that it was dangerous to want a lot of money. He told him that the false teachers were sinning in many ways, but that they were especially sinning by trying to use religion to get more money. He told believers to be content with what they had.

The paragraphs in this section are:

Paragraph 6:3–5: The false teachers taught things about Christ and his message that were incorrect. They discussed unimportant issues that caused arguments. They did not understand how to distinguish between what was true and what was false. They thought that teaching about God was merely an effective way to become rich.

Paragraph 6:6–10: People think that they need to be rich in order to be happy. But the truth is that a person is happy only when he obeys God.

6:4a he is conceited and understands nothing.

- he is both arrogant and ignorant.
- These people are proud. They think that they know everything, but they do not really understand anything.

conceited: The word that the BSB translates as conceited is used to refer to people who think and behave as though they are superior to other people. They are very proud. In many languages, there is an idiomatic way to say this. The GNT uses an English figure of speech and says “swollen with pride.” See the note on 3:6b. This Greek word also occurs in 2 Timothy 3:4.

understands nothing: This is the second accusation that Paul made against the false teachers in this passage. Paul did not literally mean that the false teachers understood nothing at all. This is an example of hyperbole or exaggeration. He meant that the false teachers did not really understand what they were teaching about when they taught about God. This is similar to what Paul said about them in 1:7b and 1:7c.

6:4b Instead, he has an unhealthy interest in controversies and semantics,

- Such a person is addicted to arguing and quarreling about unimportant issues and words.
- They take an unhealthy enjoyment in debating with each other and arguing about what words mean.

he has an unhealthy interest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as has an unhealthy interest literally means “has a sick desire.” Paul was saying that the false teachers were interested in controversies and quarrels about words. He was also saying that this was harming them spiritually.

controversies and semantics: The two Greek words that the BSB translates as controversies and semantics have almost the same meaning. Moore, page 55, says this is a “near-synonymous doublet (borderline) (coordinate, with ‘and’).” The false teachers liked to argue, dispute, debate, and disagree with other people.

semantics: The false teachers were arguing with other people about semantics. They were possibly arguing about what certain words in the Old Testament meant. Paul warned Timothy again in 2 Timothy 2:14 about how such quarrels could be harmful.

6:4c–5a
In these verse parts, Paul described the results of such unhealthy interest in controversies and quarrels about words. He listed five results:

1. envy (6:4c)
2. strife (6:4c)
3. abusive talk (6:4d)
4. evil suspicions (6:4d)
5. constant friction (6:5a)

These five things were characteristics of the false teachers. They were also becoming characteristics of the people who followed their teaching.

6:4c out of which come envy, strife,

- This leads to envy, conflict,
- The consequences are that they become envious of one another, they quarrel among themselves,

out of which come: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as out of which come introduces the five results that Paul listed.

envy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as envy refers to the emotion that a person feels when he wants something another person has or wants to be like another person. It makes him resentful and discontented with what he has and who he is.

Your language may have an idiomatic way to talk about envy. If so, you could use it here. Louw and Nida (88.160) on *phthonos*

strife: The Greek word that the BSB translates as strife refers to what happens when people quarrel and disagree with one other. In the New Testament this word almost always occurs along with a word that means “envy” or “jealousy.” See Romans 1:29, 13:13; 1 Corinthians 1:11, 3:3; 2 Corinthians 12:20; Galatians 5:20; Philippians 1:15; Titus 3:9. When people are envious of each other, this causes them to quarrel and disagree with each other.

Paul said in 6:4b that the false teachers were interested in controversies and quarrels. Here in 6:4c he said that this resulted in strife among believers. Use a stronger word to translate strife than you did to translate “controversies and quarrels” in 6:4b.

6:4d

abusive talk, evil suspicions,

- abusive speech, suspicious thinking,
- they insult each other, they suspect each other of doing evil,

abusive talk: The Greek word that the BSB translates as abusive talk refers to verbal abuse and insults. The false teachers and those who followed them spoke harshly and said slanderous things about people.

evil suspicions: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as suspicions refers to thoughts that somebody has done something wrong. If a person has evil suspicions, he may accuse other people of wrong doing without any proof.

1 Timothy 6:5

Section 6:3–10: Paul warned that it was dangerous to want to be rich

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Paragraph 6:6–10: People think that they need to be rich in order to be happy. But the truth is that a person is happy only when he obeys God.

6:5a

and constant friction between men of depraved mind

- and unceasing conflict with each other. Their minds have been corrupted
- and are continually bickering with each other. They can no longer tell the difference between right and wrong.

constant friction between men of depraved mind:

This is the final result of the false teachers’ quarreling about words. The term that the BSB translates as constant friction refers to the unpleasant relationship between people who continually quarrel with each other over unimportant things. Here are some possible ways to translate this:

There is no end to their arguments with people

All the time they squabble with each other

men of depraved mind: The phrase that the BSB translates as men of depraved mind refers to the false teachers themselves.

The reason that the false teachers behaved the way they did was because their minds were depraved. Knight, pages 250–251, says, “The ultimate reason for all that precedes (from *τετύφωται* [=‘has been puffed up’; NIV = ‘conceited’] on) is given in two participles (*διεφθαρμένων* [=‘having been corrupted’] and *ἀπεστερημένων* [=‘having been deprived’], genitive to agree with *ἀνθρώπων* [=‘men’]), each followed by a noun indicating where or in what way the participle applies.” See also Knight, page 252. and they were “devoid of the truth” (6:5b).

depraved mind: The Greek words that the BSB translates as of depraved mind refer to people whose minds can no longer discern the difference between right and wrong. Knight, page 252, says that the devil is in view here as the one who causes the corruption.

He says that the devil is also the subject in 6:5c. However, it would probably be a mistake to translate this explicitly with the devil as the agent/subject, here. It would highlight the role of the devil too much, perhaps making it seem that the false teachers were not to blame. Paul himself does not highlight the devil here. He keeps the focus on the actual state of the false teachers. That is why we suggest translating it as a simple fact that their minds are corrupt, without stating that the devil causes the corruption. The Greek text does not say who made these people's minds depraved, and you should avoid trying to make that explicit in your translation.

mind: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mind refers to a person's "way of thinking," or "thoughts." You should use an expression in your language for the part of a person that "thinks."

6:5b

who are devoid of the truth.

- and they can no longer understand what is true.
- It is as if someone has stolen from them the ability to understand the truth.

devoid of the truth: Paul did not say who had made the false teachers devoid of the truth. You also should avoid trying to make that explicit in your translation. Rather, Paul was emphasizing that the false teachers could no longer understand what was true.

6:5c

These men regard godliness as a means of gain.

- They think that teaching about God is a way to make money.
- They think that if they teach about God they can become rich.

These men regard: Here Paul talked about one of the lies that the false teachers thought was true.

godliness as a means of gain: Some translations include the words "from such withdraw thyself" (KJV) at the end of this verse. However, most people who study the Greek texts agree that these words were not present in Paul's original letter to Timothy. The Editorial Committee of the UBS New Testament (4th edition) gives the reading without "from such withdraw thyself" an {A} rating, indicating that the text is almost certain. Metzger, page 643, says, "Although the reading is ancient, as appears from patristic testimony, it must be rejected as a pious but banal gloss, because (a) the best manuscripts of both the Alexandrian and the Western types of text...support the shorter reading, and (b) if it were present originally, no good reason can be assigned for its omission."

The false teachers hoped that when they behaved in a godly manner, they would make lots of money. One way to express this is:

godliness is a good way to make a lot of money.

godliness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as godliness normally refers to the way people behave when they respect God. Paul used the word godliness in this way in 2:2c, 3:16a, 4:7b and 4:8b. However, here in 6:5c, the context is different.

It is most likely that godliness here refers to teaching about God. The false teachers wanted to teach about God so that they could become rich by charging money for people to listen to them. In Paul's time, people often gained money by going from town to town teaching different religions. That is what the false teachers in Ephesus were also trying to do. They were trying to become rich by teaching about God. Kelly, page 135, says, "It has been disputed whether the charge is that they used their show of piety as a lever for material advancement, or that they exacted fees for the esoteric religious instruction they gave to their adherents. The latter is almost certainly correct, for it coheres better with what follows, and also (if we are justified in regarding it as a parallel) with the picture of their strenuous propagandist methods given in Tit. i. ii. Further, it is inconceivable that the profession of Christianity was materially advantageous at any of the times which have been seriously proposed for the composition of the Pastorals. As we have seen (v. 17 f.: cf. 2 Tim. ii. 6), Paul has no objection to church officials, least of all teachers, receiving emoluments. His complaint against the sectaries seems to be that they make money their prime objective and set a specific price upon their wares."

1 Timothy 6:6

Section 6:3–10: Paul warned that it was dangerous to want to be rich

In this section Paul warned Timothy once more about the false teachers. He also told him that it was dangerous to want a lot of money. He told him that the false teachers were sinning in many ways, but that they were especially sinning by trying to use religion to get more money. He told believers to be content with what they had.

The paragraphs in this section are:

Paragraph 6:3–5: The false teachers taught things about Christ and his message that were incorrect. They discussed unimportant issues that caused argu-

ments. They did not understand how to distinguish between what was true and what was false. They thought that teaching about God was merely an effective way to become rich.

Paragraph 6:6–10: People think that they need to be rich in order to be happy. But the truth is that a person is happy only when he obeys God.

6:6

Of course, godliness with contentment is great gain.

- ¶ Instead, we^(incl) get greater riches when we^(incl) please God and are content with what we^(incl) have.
- ¶ But it is better for us^(incl) to do what pleases God and be satisfied with what he gives us^(incl).

Of course: Paul used the Greek word *de* that the BSB translates as *Of course* here. He wanted to contrast what the false teachers thought (6:5c) and what was actually true (6:6).

godliness: In 6:5c, godliness meant “teaching about God.” Here it refers to the way people behave when they respect God. Paul could use this one word to refer to both of these things. However in many languages it will not be possible to use the same word or expression here as in 6:5c.

contentment: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as *contentment* refers to being satisfied. Paul was saying that a person is happy when he is satisfied with what God has given him.

great gain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *gain* is the same word that Paul used in 6:5c. However, there it referred to getting money. Here it has a different meaning and refers to living well with God both now and forever.

great: People think that if they become rich, they will be able to gain good things with their money. But those things are not as good as what people gain when they behave in a way that pleases God.

1 Timothy 6:7

Section 6:3–10: Paul warned that it was dangerous to want to be rich

In this section Paul warned Timothy once more about the false teachers. He also told him that it was dangerous to want a lot of money. He told him that the false teachers were sinning in many ways, but that they were especially sinning by trying to use religion to get more money. He told believers to be content with what they had.

The paragraphs in this section are:

Paragraph 6:3–5: The false teachers taught things about Christ and his message that were incorrect. They discussed unimportant issues that caused arguments. They did not understand how to distinguish between what was true and what was false. They thought that teaching about God was merely an effective way to become rich.

Paragraph 6:6–10: People think that they need to be rich in order to be happy. But the truth is that a person is happy only when he obeys God.

6:7a

For we brought nothing into the world,

- For when we^(incl) were born, we^(incl) did not bring anything with us,^(incl)

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *For* indicates that 6:7 is the reason that we should be content with what we have. Paul stated the reason in a way that sounds like a proverb.

we brought nothing into the world: That is, when we were born, we came into the world with nothing.

we: This refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

6:7b

so we cannot carry anything out of it.

- and when we^(incl) die, we^(incl) cannot take anything with us.^(incl)

we cannot carry anything out of it: Some translations include the words “and it is certain” before the words we can take nothing out of it (see the KJV and NLT). However, the words “and it is certain” are not in the best Greek texts. The Editorial Committee of the UBS New Testament (4th edition) gives the reading without “and it is certain” an {A} rating, indicating that the text is almost certain. Metzger, page 643, says that these words are “an obvious alleviation introduced in order to clarify the sense.” That is, when we die, we can take nothing with us.

we: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

1 Timothy 6:8

Section 6:3–10: Paul warned that it was dangerous to want to be rich

In this section Paul warned Timothy once more about the false teachers. He also told him that it was dangerous to want a lot of money. He told him that the false teachers were sinning in many ways, but that they were especially sinning by trying to use religion

to get more money. He told believers to be content with what they had.

The paragraphs in this section are:

Paragraph 6:3–5: The false teachers taught things about Christ and his message that were incorrect. They discussed unimportant issues that caused arguments. They did not understand how to distinguish between what was true and what was false. They thought that teaching about God was merely an effective way to become rich.

Paragraph 6:6–10: People think that they need to be rich in order to be happy. But the truth is that a person is happy only when he obeys God.

6:8a

But if we have food and clothing,

- Therefore, if we^(incl) have the food and clothing we^(incl) need,
- Therefore, if we^(incl) have enough to eat and drink, and if we^(incl) have the shelter and clothing we^(incl) need,

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But is the connecting word *de*. See footnote 6 for more details about *de*. However here it does not indicate a contrast with 6:7, but a sort of conclusion. Therefore in some languages, it may be better to start the verse with a connecting word like “so” or “therefore.” Arichea and Hatton, page 148, also comment on this, saying: “It should be further noted that the connective used here can be literally rendered as ‘but’ or ‘and.’ If, however, this verse functions as an inference arising out of the assertion in verse 7, then a connective expressing inference or result would be preferable (as, for example, GNT ‘So then,’ Phps ‘Surely, then’). In certain languages it is possible to restructure this verse as follows: ‘So then, we should be satisfied if we have (or, just to have) enough food and clothes.’”

food: The word that the BSB translates as food includes drink as well.

clothing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as clothing refers to anything that covers and protects people. It refers mainly to clothes, but it can also refer to housing. See the definition in BAG of *skepasma*.

6:8b

we will be content with these.

- we^(incl) should be satisfied/content with what we^(incl) have.

we will be content: The verb that the BSB translates as we will be content is a future tense. However, Paul was probably saying that we should be content. Kelly,

page 137, says, “The future ‘we shall be content’ is unexpected, for an admonitory construction such as ‘we should be content’ would seem more in place. It may be that Paul is incorporating a proverbial tag without troubling to modify it. Alternatively, and more probably, the future may be a Hebraism with the force of an imperative.” He meant that wealth does not bring happiness to people. Instead people will be happy when they are content with what God has provided. See the note on 6:6.

we: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

General Comment on 6:8a–b

In some languages it will be better to reorder the verse. For example:

So we should be satisfied if we have enough food and clothes.

Therefore even if sufficient food and clothes are all that we have, we should be content.

1 Timothy 6:9

Section 6:3–10: Paul warned that it was dangerous to want to be rich

In this section Paul warned Timothy once more about the false teachers. He also told him that it was dangerous to want a lot of money. He told him that the false teachers were sinning in many ways, but that they were especially sinning by trying to use religion to get more money. He told believers to be content with what they had.

The paragraphs in this section are:

Paragraph 6:3–5: The false teachers taught things about Christ and his message that were incorrect. They discussed unimportant issues that caused arguments. They did not understand how to distinguish between what was true and what was false. They thought that teaching about God was merely an effective way to become rich.

Paragraph 6:6–10: People think that they need to be rich in order to be happy. But the truth is that a person is happy only when he obeys God.

6:9a

Those who want to be rich, however,

- Some people want to become rich so much that
- People who really want to have lots of money

Those who want to be rich: When Paul referred to Those who want to be rich, he was referring to people, like the false teachers, who wanted to be rich more than they wanted to follow God.

however: The Greek particle *de* connects 6:8 and 6:9. In this context, this particle indicates that there is a contrast between these two verses. The contrast is between those who are content (6:8) and those who want to become rich (6:9). The BSB translates this with the word *however*. If in your language you have a way to show this contrast, you should use it to connect these verses.

6:9b

fall into temptation and become ensnared

- they let themselves give in to whatever tempts them. They get trapped like an animal.
- will be overcome by temptation and caught in a trap like an animal,

fall into temptation: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *fall into temptation* is a figure of speech. It means to give in to temptation, that is, when a person is tempted to do something wrong, they choose to do the wrong thing and so sin.

become ensnared: This is another figure of speech. Paul had used the metaphor of a snare already, in 3:7c. He also used it in 2 Timothy 2:26. The desire to be rich is like a snare or trap that catches an animal. The person caught in such a trap cannot get free by himself.

6:9c

by many foolish and harmful desires

- They want to do things which are unwise and dangerous for them and other people.
- and their own silly and dangerous desires will conquer them.

many foolish and harmful desires: There are two ways to understand this phrase:

1. This is a third trap into which the people who want to become rich fall. (NIV, RSV, KJV, NASB, REB, NET)
2. This is what the trap mentioned in 6:9b consists of. For example, the GNT says:

the trap of many foolish and harmful desires (BSB, GNT, NJB, CEV, GW, NRSV, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

foolish...desires: People who want to become rich also have many foolish...desires, that is, they start to want things that are wrong, unwise, and sinful. This is

what happens to people when they want to become rich more than they want to follow God.

harmful desires: The desires that these people have are not only foolish, but also harmful. They want to do things that could hurt or damage themselves or other people.

6:9d

that plunge them into ruin and destruction.

- These desires will cause them to be ruined and destroyed.
- As a result, they will suffer greatly.

that plunge them into ruin and destruction: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *plunge* means to push someone or something under water. Paul was using a figure of speech here. He meant that the desires of 6:9c often cause overwhelming ruin and destruction. In some languages, it may be necessary to remove the figure of speech and translate only the meaning. One way to do this is:

that cause people to be ruined and destroyed

ruin and destruction: Scholars interpret these two words in different ways:

1. They say that both words refer to suffering on this earth. Moore, page 55, classifies this as a synonymous doublet.
2. They say that *ruin* refers to suffering before death and *destruction* refers to suffering after death, in hell. Knight, pages 256–257, says, “...because *ὄλεθρος* [=‘ruin’] is used in 1 Cor. 5:5 of ‘destruction of the flesh’ here and now, with the hope ‘that his spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus,’ i.e., for eternity, it has been suggested that *ὄλεθρος* refers here also to bodily destruction and *ἀπώλεια* [=‘destruction’] to spiritual destruction (van Oosterzee, Kelly [possible], Spicq, Dornier), or that *ὄλεθρος* refers here to present destruction and *ἀπώλεια* to destruction (perdition) in eternity (so Vine, Expository Dictionary, I, 304; NEB: ‘ruin and perdition’; Robertson: ‘destruction and perdition’). Either or both of these suggestions that see a contrast between the two terms point to the most likely solution (which is not to say that *ὄλεθρος* cannot refer to eternity: it clearly does in 2 Thes. 1:9; cf. 1 Thes. 5:3).”

Either interpretation is possible and it is recommended that you translate them in as general a way as possible.

These two words translated ruin and destruction mean almost the same thing. In some languages it may be necessary to combine these two terms into one expression. For example:

absolute ruin

1 Timothy 6:10

Section 6:3–10: Paul warned that it was dangerous to want to be rich

In this section Paul warned Timothy once more about the false teachers. He also told him that it was dangerous to want a lot of money. He told him that the false teachers were sinning in many ways, but that they were especially sinning by trying to use religion to get more money. He told believers to be content with what they had.

The paragraphs in this section are:

Paragraph 6:3–5: The false teachers taught things about Christ and his message that were incorrect. They discussed unimportant issues that caused arguments. They did not understand how to distinguish between what was true and what was false. They thought that teaching about God was merely an effective way to become rich.

Paragraph 6:6–10: People think that they need to be rich in order to be happy. But the truth is that a person is happy only when he obeys God.

6:10a

For the love of money is the root of all kinds of evil.

- For people who want money too much do all kinds of evil things to get it.
- When a person desires lots of money, he will behave in many kinds of evil ways to get it.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For indicates that 6:10 gives the reason for the statement in 6:9. In other words, it gives the reason that those who want to become rich incur the problems listed in 6:9.

Here, Paul used a proverb to give the reason for 6:9. Knight, page 257, reports that a “widely attested” ancient Greek proverb says “The love of money is the mother-city of all evil.” Paul modifies the proverb, but still keeps it in proverb form.

the love of money: In some languages, it is not possible to love an object like money. If this is true in your language, it may be possible to say something like “wanting money,” or “wanting to become rich.” Or

it may be possible to use a word like “greed.” See the note on 3:3d.

the root of all kinds of evil: To say that “the love of money” is the root of all kinds of evil is a figure of speech. It means that it causes much evil. For example, when people want to become rich, they may easily become selfish. They may cheat, lie, steal, envy, or quarrel. They may hate people, hurt them, and even kill them.

It is not clear from the Greek grammar here whether the word that the BSB translates as the root should be translated as:

1. a root, that is, one source or cause of evil among many possible sources or causes. (NIV, GNT, NASB, NRSV, CEV, NCV, NLT)
2. “the root,” that is, the only source or cause of evil. (BSB, RSV, NJB, KJV, REB, NET, GW)

The Greek text is ambiguous. However, Paul was probably implying that there were other causes of evil as well as the love of money. So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

all kinds of evil: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all kinds of evil can be understood in two ways:

1. It means all sorts or kinds of evil. In other words, the love of money can result in different sorts of evil behavior. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NASB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. It means all evil. In other words, the love of money is the cause of every evil behavior. (RSV, NJB, KJV, REB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

6:10b

By craving it, some have wandered away from the faith

- Some people have gradually stopped believing the teachings about Christ because they wanted money so much,

By craving it, some have wandered away from the faith: Paul knew that some people in Ephesus had wandered from the faith because they were eager for money. It is possible that he was referring to the false teachers. These teachers thought that godliness was a means to financial gain (6:5c). Paul may also have been referring to those who had been influenced by them.

wandered away from the faith: The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as wandered away from literally means “have been led astray.” Here Paul used the Greek verb figuratively. It refers to a person

who has allowed money to hinder him from following Christian teaching. See the note on 1:6a and 6:21b.

the faith: When Paul referred to the faith, he was referring to the true teachings about God and about Christ. See the note on “the faith” in 3:9. See faith, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

6:10c

and pierced themselves with many sorrows.

- and they suffer in many ways, like a person who has stabbed himself.
- and they have caused themselves to suffer in many ways.

and: This part of the verse gives the second thing that happens when people are “crave” money.

pierced themselves with many sorrows: Paul was using a figure of speech here to help the believers understand his point. People suffer physically if they pierce or stab themselves. In the same way, people who are eager for money often suffer terribly. For example, some people work so hard to become rich that they lose friends.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make the comparison explicit. For example, one way to do this is:

[they have] caused themselves to suffer as greatly as if they had pierced themselves with a weapon

If you have no suitable figure of speech in your language, you can translate only the meaning. For example, the NCV says:

they have caused themselves much sorrow

1 Timothy 6:11

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:11–16

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy some specific ways that he should behave. He gave him four main instructions:

1. to “pursue...perseverance” (6:11c, 6:11e)
2. to “fight the good fight of the faith” (6:12a)
3. to “take hold of...eternal life” (6:12b)
4. to “keep this commandment...until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ” (6:14a, 6:14c)

6:11a

But you, O man of God,

- ¶ Timothy, since you belong to God,
- ¶ However, you have devoted yourself to God.

But you: Paul began this verse with an emphatic pronoun you^(sing) along with the Greek word that the BSB translates as But. He used these words to introduce a contrast. He had described those who wanted to become rich and therefore eventually wandered from the faith (6:3–10). Now he described the way that Timothy should behave (6:11–16).

O man of God: Paul called Timothy man of God. There are two ways to understand this:

1. Paul meant that Timothy was a Christian and that he was someone who belonged to God and desired to behave as God wanted him to behave. For example, the NET says:

a person dedicated to God (NET, NLT, CEV)

1. Paul was using the words man of God in a special sense to say that Timothy was like a prophet. This is what the expression man of God meant in the Old Testament. For example, Moses (Deuteronomy 33:1), Samuel (1 Samuel 9), Elijah (1 Kings 17:18) and others were called by this title.

Most English versions translate this phrase literally. If you wish to follow one of the above interpretations in your translation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul called Timothy man of God to highlight that he was commanding Timothy to behave in a way that showed that he belonged to God. This expression is used in 2 Timothy 3:17 as a general term for a believer.

6:11b

flee from these things

- you must avoid all that.
- That is why you must stay away from all such behavior.

flee: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as flee literally means “to run away from.” But here Paul used it in a figurative way to mean “avoid” or “stay away from.” People “avoid” or flee from danger. In the same way, Paul wanted Timothy to avoid behaving in the ways mentioned in 6:3–10.

these things: Paul was talking about the issues that he had discussed in the previous verses: all the ways in which people might sin when they want to become rich.

6:11c

and pursue righteousness, godliness,

- Make every effort to do only what is right. Behave as God wants you to behave.

pursue righteousness, godliness: This is also a figure of speech. In some languages a verb like pursue can only be used with an animate object like a person or an animal. It is not possible to pursue something like righteousness or the other qualities in this list (6:11c-e). People use all their physical energy when they chase after someone or something. Paul meant that Timothy should use all his effort to behave in these ways.

righteousness: This is the first of six qualities that Paul told Timothy to pursue. The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness refers to doing things that God considers right.

godliness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as godliness refers to the way people behave when they respect God. See godliness, godly in the Glossary. Louw and Nida define righteousness (88.13) as “the act of doing what God requires” and define godliness (53.5) as “behavior reflecting correct religious beliefs and attitudes.” They recommend translating the word “godliness” in 1 Timothy 2:2 as “to live as God would have us live” or “to live as God has told us we should live.” So, you can see how similar the two words are.

6:11d faith, love,

- Trust Christ. Love other people.

faith: See faith, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

love: In this verse, Paul was probably talking about love for other people rather than love for God. Knight, page 262, says, “Where, however, Paul indicates or implies the object of love, it is most often human beings (e.g., Rom. 12:9; 13:10; 14:15; 2 Cor. 8:7; Gal. 5:13; Eph. 1:15; 4:2; Col. 1:4; 2:2; 1 Thes. 3:12; 5:13; 2 Thes. 1:3; Phm. 5, 7). Humans seem to be the object in 1 Corinthians 13, which is followed by words similar to those here, i.e., *διώκετε τὴν ἀγάπην* [=‘pursue love’] (1 Cor. 14:1). Thus if a specific object is intended here, and it need not be, it would probably be humans.”

6:11e perseverance, and gentleness.

- Never give up obeying God. Do not become angry with people.

perseverance: When Paul said that Timothy should pursue perseverance, he meant that Timothy should persist in trusting God and in doing what pleased God, no matter what happened.

gentleness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gentleness refers to not being harsh or rough with other people. In the New Testament it usually refers to the way in which a person talks to other people. It can also include the way that a person treats other people. The actual word which Paul uses here, *praupathia*, does not occur anywhere else in the New Testament. However, its synonym *prautēs* occurs eight times, in 1 Corinthians 4:21; 2 Corinthians 10:1; Galatians 5:23, 6:1; Ephesians 4:2; Colossians 3:12; 2 Timothy 2:25; and Titus 3:2.

1 Timothy 6:12

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:11–16

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy some specific ways that he should behave. He gave him four main instructions:

1. to “pursue...perseverance” (6:11c, 6:11e)
2. to “fight the good fight of the faith” (6:12a)
3. to “take hold of...eternal life” (6:12b)
4. to “keep this commandment...until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ” (6:14a, 6:14c)

6:12a

Fight the good fight of the faith.

- Like a good soldier in a war who never gives up fighting, you, too, should never give up trusting in God and obeying him.
- Exert yourself very hard to continue to entrust yourself completely to God.

Fight the good fight of the faith: Paul was saying that Timothy should do three things:

1. He should flee (6:11b) from certain things.
2. He should pursue (6:11c) other things.
3. He should fight the good fight of the faith.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as Fight is different from the one used in 1:18d. The verb there refers to fighting in a war. However, the verb used here is more often used to refer to fighting in an athletic contest such as wrestling. There are therefore two ways to translate this:

1. To use the same verb as in 1:18d. This is easiest if your verb “fight” includes different sorts of fighting. In John 18:36 the word is rendered “fight”; in 1 Thessalonians 2:2 it is rendered “strong opposition.” (BSB, NIV, RSV, KJV, NASB, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

2. To use a verb that means “compete” as an athlete does in a sports competition.¹ Corinthians 9:25; Hebrews 12:1 For example, the GNT says:

Run your best in the race of faith, and win eternal life for yourself... (GNT, REB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as the majority of English versions have done.

Paul used this figure of speech in 2 Timothy 4:7. You should use the same translation in both these passages.

the good fight of the faith: A believer who behaves in the way God wants will encounter difficulties and opposition. The Greek expression that the BSB translates as the good fight of the faith refers to the believer’s struggle against that opposition.

the faith: See faith, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

6:12b

Take hold of the eternal life

- Claim the life with God that lasts forever,

Take hold of the eternal life: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Take hold of literally means “catch” or “grasp firmly.” Paul used this verb figuratively here. He was telling Timothy to claim the eternal life that God had already given him and not to let go of it.

eternal life: The expression that the BSB translates as eternal life means life that never ends. As the note on 1:16d said, a believer’s eternal life begins when he believes in Christ and continues after he dies.

It is likely that Paul was referring to the fact that Timothy’s eternal life had already begun. Therefore, Paul was exhorting Timothy to experience the benefits of eternal life now.

6:12c

to which you were called

- to which God called you,

called: The verb that the BSB translates as called in this context means that Timothy was chosen [to receive eternal life (6:12b)]. If it is necessary in your language to specify who called Timothy, you should say that God called him.

6:12d

when you made the good confession before many witnesses.

- and concerning which, in front of many people, you have stated clearly that you would trust in Christ.

- and about which many people heard you state that you would trust in Christ.

God not only called Timothy, but Timothy publicly accepted God’s call.

when: The Greek word that the BSB translates as when literally means “and.” Scholars suggest translating this word in two ways:

1. It should be translated “and.” God had called Timothy to eternal life (6:12c), and Timothy had publicly stated that he intended to trust in Christ (6:12d). Knight, page 264, refers to Ellicott, who says that the and has “simple copulative power, and subjoins to the foregoing words another and co-ordinate ground of encouragement and exhortation.” (NJB, NLT, NASB, NRSV, KJV, NET, GW)
2. It should be translated when. It tells when God called Timothy to begin experiencing “eternal life.” In other words, he began to experience eternal life when he publicly stated that he intended to trust in Christ. (BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NCV, REB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since this is the more natural way to understand this Greek word.

the good confession: The phrase good confession refers to the time when Timothy publicly said that he believed in Christ.

many witnesses: This “good confession” probably happened when Timothy was baptized. Therefore the many witnesses probably refers to the people who were present when Timothy was baptized and heard him state that he believed in Christ.

1 Timothy 6:13

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:11–16

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3. to “take hold of...eternal life” (6:12b)
4. to “keep this commandment...until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ” (6:14a, 6:14c)

6:13–16

In the Greek the sentence that begins in 6:13 does not end until 6:16d. In many languages this will make a sentence that is too long and very difficult to understand. As you translate these verses, consider where

you might make sentence breaks. However, be sure that you keep the main focus of the verses.

6:13a **I charge you**

- I command you
- With these two as witnesses, I order you

I charge you: That is, Paul was ordering Timothy to do something. It was a command. What he commanded is in 6:14. This is the main clause of this verse.

6:13b **in the presence of God,**

- With God witnessing what I tell you,
- Realize that God the Father is watching as I command you.

in the presence of God: When Paul commanded Timothy in the presence of God, he meant that God the Father was a witness to what Paul was telling Timothy to do. Paul was stressing that what he would say next was extremely important. See also the note on “before God” in 5:21a.

6:13c **who gives life to all things,**

- God who causes everything to live,
- It is he who gives life to everything that lives.

who gives life to all things: This verse part gives a description of God. That is, whatever lives, lives only because God has caused it to live.

6:13d **and of Christ Jesus,**

- and with Christ Jesus also witnessing what I tell you,
- Christ Jesus is also watching.

and of Christ Jesus: Here Paul reminded Timothy that Jesus Christ also was a witness to what Paul was commanding Timothy to do.

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names “Christ Jesus” and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Some people, however, think that when Paul used the word Christ before the word Jesus, as in Christ Jesus, he was emphasizing that Jesus was the Messiah.

In most English versions “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

However, it is possible that, in some languages, people may be confused to see the names in two different orders. They may even think that Paul was referring to

two different people. If this is true in your language, it may be necessary to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ.” This is the more usual word order in the New Testament.

Christ: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

6:13e **who made the good confession in His testimony before Pontius Pilate:**

- Jesus who spoke the truth when Pontius Pilate questioned him;
- Remember that Jesus told the truth about himself to Pontius Pilate.

who made the good confession in His testimony before Pontius Pilate: This clause describes Jesus’ action when he testified before Pilate.

the good confession: The phrase that the BSB translates as the good confession probably refers to what Jesus told Pilate. Jesus told the truth about himself. For example, Jesus knew that his enemies would kill him if he said that he was the king of the Jews. Even though he knew that, he answered “yes” when Pilate asked him that question. See Matthew 27:11; Mark 15:2; Luke 23:3; John 18:33–37.

His testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testimony refers here to giving evidence in a court.

before Pontius Pilate: That is, Jesus testified while standing in front of Pontius Pilate to be judged.

Pontius Pilate: Pontius Pilate was the Roman governor of Judea at the time when Jesus was crucified. It was he who was the judge who tried Jesus and ordered Roman soldiers to execute him.

General Comment on 6:13a–e

In some languages it may be better to reorder this verse. For example:

^{13b}In the sight of God ^{13c}who gives life to everything, ^{13d}and in the sight of Christ Jesus, ^{13e}who while testifying before Pontius Pilate made the good confession, ^{13a}I charge you:

1 Timothy 6:14

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:11–16

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy some specific ways that he should behave. He gave him four main instructions:

1. to “pursue...perseverance” (6:11c, 6:11e)
2. to “fight the good fight of the faith” (6:12a)
3. to “take hold of...eternal life” (6:12b)
4. to “keep this commandment...until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ” (6:14a, 6:14c)

6:14a

Keep this commandment

- to obey what you were told to do
- to do everything that God has commanded you to do

Keep this commandment: The Greek word that the BSB translates as commandment is a general word that refers to any sort of commandment or order. Scholars suggest many different things to which Paul might have been referring. Three of the suggestions are:

1. Paul was referring to everything that God expected Timothy to do as a believer and as a minister of the gospel. For example, the NLT says:

obey his [God’s] commands (NLT, GNT, REB, NCV)

1. Paul was referring to everything that he had commanded Timothy to do in this letter.
2. Paul was referring to what he had commanded Timothy to do immediately before this, in 6:11–12. Translations that supply the word this and use a singular “command” are probably following this interpretation. (BSB, NIV, KJV, GW)

Some English versions are ambiguous. The same Greek phrase occurs in a similar context in 2 Peter 2:21 and 3:2. Also Paul did not use a word meaning this. Therefore, interpretation (1) is probably correct, and it is recommended that you follow it. Knight, pages 266–267 says, “Each option has a certain plausibility to it within this context alone. Hence consideration must be given to use of *ἐντολή* [=‘command’] elsewhere in contexts analogous to this one and to use of analogous terms in 1 Timothy. Paul does not use singular articular *ἡ ἐντολή* frequently; when he does, he refers to one of the Ten Commandments (Rom. 7:8–13), which seems unlikely here. In the non-Pauline NT letters *ἡ ἐντολή* is used in 2 Pet. 2:21; 3:2 (and in 1 John and 2 John of the love command, but that meaning has

not been suggested here and nothing in 1 Timothy 6 would seem to warrant it). In 2 Peter *ἡ ἐντολή* is used ‘as a description of Christianity considered as a body of ethical teaching’ (Bauckham, Jude, 2 Peter, at 2:21; at 3:2 he indicates that the term is used ‘in the same way’). Such a meaning for *ἡ ἐντολή* in 1 Tim. 6:14 would seem to be supported by the significance of analogous terms in the PE [=Pastoral Epistles]: Paul has designated the Christian faith as ‘the command’ (*ἡ παραγγελία*, 1 Tim. 1:5), and in the conclusion of the letter (6:20) he charges Timothy to ‘guard the deposit,’ i.e., the Christian faith (*τὴν παραθήκην φύλαξον*). In 2 Tim. 4:7 he uses the same verb as he does here in saying that he himself has ‘kept the faith’ (*τὴν πίστιν τετήρηκα*). Paul speaks, therefore, about the Christian faith as a command and as that which must be guarded or kept. This formulation of the matter was already presented by Jesus in the Great Commission, which in its Greek form (Mt. 28:20) contains the same verb, *τηρέω*, as 1 Tim. 6:14 and the verb *ἐντέλλω*, which is the cognate of *ἐντολή*.” On pages 267–268, Knight continues, saying, “The other...alternatives...refer ‘the commandment’ to vv. 11–12 or to the whole letter and would seem to require that the text read ‘this,’ rather than ‘the,’ commandment. They also seem not to give adequate attention to the definiteness and absoluteness of the phrase ‘the commandment.’”

6:14b

without stain or reproach

- without fault or failure
- completely so that no one can accuse you of doing wrong

without stain: This is a figure of speech. If something has a stain, on it, it is not perfect. So when Paul said that Timothy should obey God’s commands without stain, he meant that Timothy should obey them perfectly.

or reproach: If Timothy obeyed God’s commands without...reproach, no one would be able to accuse or blame him for the way he behaved.

In some languages it may not be possible to translate these two terms separately or to keep the figure of speech. Some other ways to translate this verse part are:

completely and fully (CEV)

without fault or failure (NET)

6:14c

until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ,

- until our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ returns.
- between now and the time when our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ returns to earth.

until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ: Paul was telling Timothy to keep obeying God's commands until Jesus returned.

our: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord is a general word that means "master." It was used to address any respected person. Here it refers to Christ. You could translate it as "owner" or "chief."

Jesus Christ: Notice that in this verse Paul used the more usual order Jesus Christ to refer to Jesus. It is recommended that you do the same thing.

Christ: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means "the anointed one." But later, by the time that Paul and others wrote letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus. It was no longer used as a title. So here and in other New Testament letters you should spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

1 Timothy 6:15

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:11–16

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy some specific ways that he should behave. He gave him four main instructions:

1. to "pursue...perseverance" (6:11c, 6:11e)
2. to "fight the good fight of the faith" (6:12a)
3. to "take hold of...eternal life" (6:12b)
4. to "keep this commandment...until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ" (6:14a, 6:14c)

6:15a–16b

In these verse parts Paul began to praise God. As in 1:17a–d, consider formatting this section of praise as poetry. One example of this format is to put one verse part on each line and indent the text.

6:15a

which the blessed and only Sovereign One—

- God is the only king who is worthy of praise,
- Praise belongs to God, the only king.

the blessed and only Sovereign One: In the New Testament, the Greek word *makarios* that the BSB translates as blessed is only used to describe God

here and in 1:11. It means that God has every blessing in himself. He is not dependent on anyone else for joy or anything else. Hanson, page 60, says, "It came originally from pagan Greek literature (Homer calls the gods 'blessed'), and was adopted by Hellenistic Judaism, which is no doubt how it entered the vocabulary of the author of the Pastorals. D-C [Dibelius and Conzelmann], rightly no doubt, see here traces of a liturgical style."

In your translation, use an expression that would be appropriate for referring to God. Some possibilities are:

the...Ruler who lives in perfect joy

the...Ruler who has all blessings

the perfect...Ruler

only Sovereign One: God is the only one who rules over everything. He is unique.

6:15b

the King of kings and Lord of lords—

- the greatest King and the greatest Lord,
- He is the King who rules over all other kings and the Lord who is greater than all other lords.

the King of kings: That is, the King who is greater than all other kings.

Lord of lords: That is, the Lord who is greater than all other lords.

General Comment on 6:15b

The title "Kings of kings and Lord of lords" is also used in Revelation 17:14, 19:16. Make sure you translate it in the same way in these places.

6:15c

will bring about in His own time.

- God will cause this to happen at the time he decides.
- He will come on the day which God has chosen.

will bring about in His own time: Paul was saying that God had already decided when Christ would return. When that time comes, God will cause it to happen.

in His own time: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as in His own time means that God will cause this to happen at the exact time that he has chosen.

1 Timothy 6:16

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:11–16

In this paragraph, Paul told Timothy some specific ways that he should behave. He gave him four main instructions:

1. to “pursue...perseverance” (6:11c, 6:11e)
2. to “fight the good fight of the faith” (6:12a)
3. to “take hold of...eternal life” (6:12b)
4. to “keep this commandment...until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ” (6:14a, 6:14c)

6:16a

He alone is immortal

- and he is the only one who lives forever
- Only he will never die.

He alone is immortal: To say that only God is immortal is to say that he is the only one who lives forever and never dies.

6:16b

and dwells in unapproachable light.

- and who is surrounded by light so bright that no one can approach it.
- He lives in light so bright that no one can come near to it.

and dwells in unapproachable light: In the Old Testament, God often demonstrated his presence by appearing as a bright light. This is part of the meaning of God’s “glory.” Paul was probably thinking about this aspect of God’s presence when he wrote that God dwells in unapproachable light. Even Moses was not able to approach the tabernacle when God’s glory (light) filled it (Exodus 40:34–35).

unapproachable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unapproachable means that no one can approach or come near this “light.”

6:16c

No one has ever seen Him, nor can anyone see Him.

- No person while alive has ever seen him, nor is anyone able to see him.

Him: This refers to God.

nor can anyone see Him: Not only has no person seen God, but it is not possible for a person to see God and remain alive (Exodus 33:20).

6:16d

To Him be honor and eternal dominion! Amen.

- People will honor God, and he will always be mighty. Amen.

To Him be honor and eternal dominion: Paul was not praying for God to receive honor and might. Instead, he was praising God because it is right to honor God, and God is mighty. The CEV expresses this:

God will be honored, and his power will last forever.

honor: In some languages it may be necessary to use a verb rather than a noun like honor. To honor someone means to respect him and to treat him as an important person. See the note on 1:17d.

eternal dominion: In Greek the expression that the BSB translates as eternal means that God will always deserve honor and might.

Amen: When people in the Bible prayed to God, they often ended by saying Amen. This means not only that they had finished, but that they fully agreed with what they had said. Because this word is well known even today, many translations just transliterate it. Another possibility is to translate it with an expression like “so let it be.” See the note on 1:17d.

1 Timothy 6:17

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:17–19

Before Paul ended this letter, he gave Timothy some specific instruction to pass on to those who were rich.

6:17a

Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited

- ¶ Tell people who are prosperous in their lives not to think that they are better than everyone else.

Instruct those who are rich in the present age: Paul was giving Timothy instructions to pass on specifically to the rich believers in Ephesus, that is, Timothy was to instruct those who had a lot of money or possessions.

in the present age: Paul added the phrase that the BSB translates as in the present age to emphasize that he was talking about people who had visible riches on earth.

conceited: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conceited refers to people who are proud and think they are better and more important than anyone else.

6:17b

and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth,

- Also tell them not to depend on their money because money can quickly disappear.
- Tell them not to think that their money can solve all their problems because they cannot know how long they will keep their money.

and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth: Many rich people think that money can solve all their problems. However Paul told Timothy to remind them that they should not trust in money like this.

the uncertainty of wealth: Here Paul stated one reason that rich people should not trust in money to solve all their problems. The reason is that riches are uncertain. That is, people can lose their riches very suddenly—perhaps a thief may steal the money.

6:17c

but in God,

- Tell them to depend instead upon God to provide for them.

but in God: Instead of depending on money, rich people (as well as everyone else) should depend on God.

In some languages it may be necessary to say what people should hope in God for. If that is true in your language, you should say something general such as:

but they should depend on God for everything they need

6:17d

who richly provides all things for us to enjoy.

- He is the one who generously gives us^(incl) all things that we^(incl) have so that we^(incl) can enjoy them.

richly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as richly is related to the Greek word translated “wealth” in 6:17b. In this context this word means “generously” or “abundantly.”

for us to enjoy: Here Paul stated the reason that God provides things for believers. He wants them to enjoy what he gives them, that is, he wants them to be happy with what he has given them and thank him for them.

us: This again refers to Paul, Timothy, and the Ephesian believers.

1 Timothy 6:18

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:17–19

Before Paul ended this letter, he gave Timothy some specific instruction to pass on to those who were rich.

6:18a

Instruct them to do good,

- Tell them to do kind things to help people.

Instruct them to do good: Paul also told Timothy to instruct rich believers to do good. In this context do good refers to helping others in practical ways.

6:18b

to be rich in good works,

- They should also abound in kind deeds.

to be rich in good works: This verse part emphasizes 6:18a. Paul wanted the rich believers not only to do good (6:18a) but to do so “richly.” That is, he wanted them to do many good deeds.

rich: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rich literally means “wealthy.” It was used in this literal way in 6:17a. Here the word is used figuratively (as in 6:17e) to mean “generous,” or “abundant.”

In both Greek and English the word rich can have both this literal and figurative meaning. In many languages it is not possible to use the same word in both ways. If this is true in your language, you should not try to use the same word but translate the meaning clearly.

6:18c

and to be generous

- Tell them to give freely to people who are in need,

generous: Paul wanted the rich believers to be generous. The Greek word that the BSB translates as generous refers to someone who gladly gives his money or possessions to other people when they need them.

6:18d

and ready to share,

- and to willingly share what they have with them.

ready to share: Paul also wanted the rich believers to be willing to share their possessions with others.

General Comment on 6:18c–d

These two words translated “generous” and “ready to share” mean almost the same thing. In some languages it may be necessary to combine these two terms into one expression.

1 Timothy 6:19

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:17–19

Before Paul ended this letter, he gave Timothy some specific instruction to pass on to those who were rich.

6:19a

treasuring up for themselves a firm foundation for the future,

- By doing this they will store up their good deeds like treasure for themselves which will be like a strong base for their future in heaven.
- When rich people act like this, it is like they are storing treasure for themselves in heaven to be a solid foundation for their future life there,

treasuring up for themselves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as treasuring up means “to keep safe that which is of great value; to treasure up, to keep safe.” Louw and Nida (65.11) on *apothēsauroō* When a person uses his possessions to do good, it is like he is saving up and storing away something of great value. This will happen for rich people if they will obey Paul’s command in 6:17–18.

a firm foundation: Paul described this treasure as a firm foundation. A foundation is the base on which a house is built so that it will be stable. A foundation is the most stable part of a building. See the note on foundation in 3:15d. The stability of a foundation contrasts with what Paul said about riches on this earth, which easily disappear (6:17b).

Paul was saying here that when a rich person does good deeds, it is like that person is storing treasure. These good deeds act as a strong foundation upon which the person could build or base the future.

Jesus used a similar figure of speech in Matthew 6:20; Luke 12:33, 18:22.

for the future: In this context, Paul was referring to the life that a believer would enjoy forever after death. Paul used the same phrase with the same sense in 4:8c and Ephesians 1:21.

6:19b

so that they may take hold of that which is truly life.

- They should do this in order to ensure that they experience the only kind of life that is really life.
- where they will be certain to live as God meant them to live.

so that: The Greek word *hina* that the BSB translates as *so that* introduces the purpose for which Paul exhorted rich people to obey his commands.

take hold of that which is truly life: This is the purpose for which Paul told rich people to obey his commands in 6:17–18. Living a life which is truly life means living life fully. This is something that a believer can only do in heaven with God. Life with God is true, real life.

take hold of: Paul was saying that when a person uses his possessions to help others, he can begin to experience eternal life. Paul was not saying that people earn their salvation by helping others. See the note on 6:12b.

1 Timothy 6:20

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:20a–21b

In this final paragraph, Paul was once more giving commands to Timothy himself.

6:20a

O Timothy, guard what has been entrusted to you.

- ¶ Timothy, take care to do what God has trusted you to do.
- ¶ Timothy, make sure you do the task that God assigned to you.

O Timothy: Paul addressed Timothy by name in this final paragraph of his letter. In Greek and in English, it is natural to place this name at the beginning of the sentence. However, in other languages, it may be more natural to place it at the end or in the middle. You should place Timothy’s name where it is most natural in your language.

guard what has been entrusted to you: The phrase that the BSB translates as *guard what has been entrusted to you* is a command to care for someone else’s possessions and make sure they are safe.

Here, Paul was not talking about an object that Timothy was to guard. He was talking about a task that God had entrusted to Timothy. This was probably the task of teaching God’s message. God had given this responsibility to Timothy. See the note on 1:11b and 1:18a.

6:20b

Avoid irreverent, empty chatter

- Avoid profane and empty discussions,
- Avoid talking in an ungodly, worthless way

Avoid: The verb that the BSB translates as Avoid literally means to physically “swerve to avoid something.” Here Paul used the verb in a figurative way. He was telling Timothy to avoid certain types of conversation. In other words, he was not to listen to such ideas and he was to make sure that they did not influence what he taught.

irreverent: The word that the BSB translates as irreverent here and in 4:7a was translated as “profane” in 1:9e. Other translation possibilities for it are “godless,” “vile,” or “impure.” See godless, Word 2, in the Glossary.

empty chatter: The Greek word that the BSB translates as empty chatter means “empty, worthless talk.” Paul was telling Timothy to avoid getting involved in conversations that were meaningless.

Paul used the same expression “godless” chatter in 2 Timothy 2:16.

6:20c and the opposing arguments of so-called “knowledge,”

- and avoid those who oppose the true teaching about God even though they wrongly call their teaching “knowledge.”
- and avoid those who teach things that contradict the truth about God. They claim that they teach true knowledge, but that is not true.

the opposing arguments: The Greek word that the BSB translates as opposing arguments refers to something that contradicts something else. Scholars understand this in two ways:

1. Paul was referring to ideas that opposed, or contradicted, the true teaching about God.
2. Paul was referring to false teaching that contradicted itself and so was inconsistent and foolish. The GNT translates it as “foolish arguments.”

It is not clear which of these interpretations many English versions follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

so-called “knowledge”: Paul wanted Timothy to know the difference between true knowledge and what some people claimed to be knowledge. That is, the false teachers claimed that the false teaching was true. Paul made it clear here to Timothy that these opposing arguments were not real knowledge.

1 Timothy 6:21

Section 6:11–21: Paul gave Timothy some final instructions

Paragraph 6:20a–21b

In this final paragraph, Paul was once more giving commands to Timothy himself.

6:21a which some have professed

- Some people have accepted this false knowledge,

which some have professed: This verse part is closely connected to 6:20b. Some people had accepted the false teaching and also claimed that it was true. These people had been members of the Christian community but were no longer members.

6:21b and thus swerved away from the faith.

- and by doing so, they no longer believe/follow the true teachings about Christ.

and thus: That is, in accepting the false teaching.

swerved away from the faith: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as swerved away from originally meant “to miss the mark.” Later it came to mean “to miss, fail, deviate, and depart.” Here it is figurative language. It means that the believers who had accepted the false teaching had stopped following their faith. See the notes on 1:6a and 6:10b.

the faith: See faith, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

6:21c Grace be with you all.

- ¶ May God bless you^(plur) all.

Grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Grace means “favor, good will, kindness.” Paul wanted God to show kindness and favor to Timothy. See Grace, meaning 1, in the Glossary. The same Greek word occurs in 1:2c with the same meaning. Try to use the same term here as you used in 1:2c.

you all: This is the one place in the letter where the word you in Greek is plural. Paul may have meant for more people than Timothy to read the letter, or he expected Timothy to pass on his greetings to the other believers.